Multi-View Depth Image Fusion for Measuring Sediment Rugosity

An In Depth Characterisation of the D456 Camera, and Multi-View Fusion Pipeline

Joab Gray Kloppers

Department of Electrical Engineering
University of Cape Town
Rondebosch, Cape Town
South Africa

Supervisor
RA **Verrinder**

Co-supervisor(s)
A/Prof D **Pillay**, G **Maniel**

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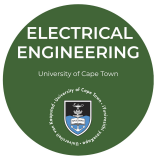

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Joab Gray Kloppers
Department of Electrical Engineering
University of Cape Town
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Abstract

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Joab Gray **Kloppers**

Tue 27 October, 2026

Sediment microtopography, and rugosity in particular, has been proposed as a non-destructive proxy candidate for bioturbation by the sandprawn *Kraussillichirus kraussi* on the intertidal flats of Langebaan Lagoon. An existing scanning system captures repeated multi-view scans of the sediment using an Intel RealSense D456 active stereo camera. However, the camera had not been characterised for close-range scanning of sediment, and each scan was analysed individually, so the reliability of the resulting rugosity values was unknown.

This project characterised the D456 using planar targets at varying working distance, tilt and ambient light, and using 3D-printed reference objects scanned at different resolutions, depth presets and post-processing filter settings. A pipeline was then developed that crops, registers and fuses the multi-view scans before computing ISO 25178-2 areal roughness parameters. AprilTag fiducials and gravity readings from the camera's inertial measurement unit provide coarse alignment. The Point-to-plane iterative closest point method refines this alignment, and a confidence-weighted trimmed mean reconciles the overlapping scans. The pipeline was evaluated on reference objects and on flat and shaped laboratory sand.

Noise increased with working distance, tilt and ambient light. The plane-fit root-mean-square residual rose from 1.22 mm at 604 mm to 4.58 mm at 903 mm. Viewing geometry mattered more than software settings. Increasing the resolution to 1280×720 reduced error by 13.4%, the High Density preset gave the best F-score, and post-processing filters improved error by at most 0.24 mm. Fusion improved every metric at every height. On the large reference surface, it raised the F-score by 14.0 percentage points to 90.9% at 641 mm, and twelve well-spread views matched the accuracy of a full 44-view sweep. On flat sand, fused scans measured a rugosity of 1.0034, against 1.0193 for single scans. On shaped sand, single scans added 2.1 to 2.6 percentage points of spurious excess area, an amount comparable to the signal itself.

Single-scan rugosity is therefore inflated by sensor noise, and multi-view fusion substantially reduces this bias. Rugosity values are only comparable between surveys that share a fixed capture and processing protocol. It is recommended that surveys scan at the shortest practical working distance, use 1280×720 resolution with the High Density preset, capture at least twelve well-spread views, and report rugosity from fused rather than single scans.

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This final year project has been the capstone for the past four years of my life. It represents my entire journey going through the electrical engineering degree, every fascinating discovery, disappointing result and late night. Despite the ups and downs throughout the degree, I am so glad that I pursued this direction. These four years, and especially this project reminded me about my long standing fascination for understanding, and building systems that can help us better understand and influence the world around us. To this, I owe a great deal sof appreciation for the people around me, who allowed me to partake in this journey.

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List of Symbols

Symbol	Description	Unit
Camera model (Section 3.1.1)		
(u, v)	Pixel coordinates in the image	px
λ	Projective scale factor (equal to the depth Z)	m
$\mathbf{X}_w = (X_w, Y_w, Z_w)^\top$	Point in the world frame	m
$(X, Y, Z)^\top$	Point in the camera frame	m
Z	Depth of a point along the optical axis	m
$\mathbf{K}$	Camera intrinsic matrix	–
f_x,f_y	Focal lengths along the image axes	px
c_x, c_y	Principal point	px
$\mathbf{R}$	Rotation matrix ($\mathbf{R}^\top\mathbf{R} = \mathbf{I}$, $\det \mathbf{R} = +1$)	–
$\mathbf{t}$	Translation vector	m
$\mathbf{I}$	Identity matrix	–
Stereo triangulation (Section 3.1.2)		
O_L, O_R	Camera centres of the left and right imagers	–
P	Scene point observed by both imagers	–
x_L, x_R	Horizontal image coordinates of P in the left and right imagers	px
f	Focal length of the rectified imagers	px
B	Stereo baseline (95 mm for the D456)	mm
d	Disparity, $x_L - x_R$	px
σ_d	Standard deviation of the disparity matching error	px
σ_Z	Standard deviation of the depth error	mm
$Z_{\min}$	Minimum measurable depth, $fB/126$	mm
Registration (Section 3.2)		
$\mathbf{p}_i, \mathbf{q}_i$	Corresponding source and target points	m
$\bar{\mathbf{p}}, \bar{\mathbf{q}}$	Centroids of the source and target points	m
N	Number of point pairs (Section 3.2.1) or number of RANSAC trials (Section 3.2.3)	–
$\mathbf{H}$	Cross-covariance matrix of centred point pairs (Eq. 3.5)	m^2
$\mathbf{U}, \mathbf{\Sigma}, \mathbf{V}$	Factors of the singular value decomposition of $\mathbf{H}$	–
$\mathbf{H}$	Homography relating tag corners to image positions (Section 3.2.2)	–
$\mathbf{r}_1, \mathbf{r}_2, \mathbf{r}_3$	Columns of the tag rotation matrix	–
w	Fraction of correct correspondences (inlier ratio)	–
p	Desired probability of drawing an all-inlier RANSAC sample	–
$\mathbf{n}_i$	Surface normal at the target point $\mathbf{q}_i$	–
$E(\mathbf{R}, \mathbf{t})$	Point-to-plane ICP cost function (Eq. 3.6)	m^2
Fusion (Section 3.3)		
$z(x, y)$	Height field of the fused surface	mm
w_k	Weight of measurement k, $\propto 1/\sigma_k^2$	–
σ_k^2	Variance of measurement k	mm^2

Continued on next page

Symbol	Description	Unit
h	Moving least squares (MLS) fitting radius	mm
Evaluation (Sections 3.4 and 4.5.1)		
$\mathbf{s}_i$	Reconstructed point	mm
d_i	Signed distance from $\mathbf{s}_i$ to the closest point on the reference surface	mm
N	Number of reconstructed points (Section 3.4)	–
μ	Bias (mean signed error)	mm
σ	Standard deviation of the signed error	mm
RMSE	Root-mean-square error	mm
τ	Distance threshold for precision, completeness and F-score	mm
S	Set of scanned (reconstructed) points	–
R	Set of points sampled from the reference model	–
s, r	Individual points of S and R	mm
$\lvert S\rvert, \lvert R\rvert$	Number of points in S and R	–
$\mathbb{1}[\cdot]$	Indicator function (1 if the condition holds, 0 otherwise)	–
$P(\tau)$	Precision at threshold τ (Eq. 4.1)	%
$C(\tau)$	Completeness at threshold τ (Eq. 4.2)	%
$F(\tau)$	F-score at threshold τ (Eq. 4.3)	%
Point cloud cropping (Section 5.1)		
$\mathbf{p}_1, \mathbf{p}_2, \mathbf{p}_3, \mathbf{p}_4$	Detected and predicted tag positions (parallelogram completion)	px
(x_d, y_d)	Normalised image coordinates after lens distortion, $(X/Z, Y/Z)$ (Eq. 5.1)	–
ρ	Root-mean-square distance of reprojected points from the nearest integer pixel (Eq. 5.2)	px
$\mathbf{u}_i$	Reprojected pixel position of point i	px
N	Number of reprojected points (Eq. 5.2)	–
$\mathbf{r}$	Direction of a pixel ray	–
$\mathbf{n}$	Normal of a fitted plane	–
d	Offset of a fitted plane (Eq. 5.3)	m
$\mathbf{X}$	Intersection of a pixel ray with a plane	m
Multi-scan fusion (Section 5.2)		
n	Number of independent measurements averaged	–
σ	Standard deviation of a single measurement	mm
$\mathbf{p}_i$	Scan point	m
$\mathbf{q}_j$	Map point paired with scan point $\mathbf{p}_i$	m
$\mathbf{n}_j$	Map normal at $\mathbf{q}_j$	–
$E(\mathbf{R}, \mathbf{t})$	Point-to-plane ICP cost over scan–map pairs (Eq. 5.4)	m^2
w_i	Weight of measurement i (Eq. 5.5)	–
$c_{s(i)}$	Registration confidence of the scan containing point i	–
$\hat{\mathbf{n}}_i$	Unit surface normal at point i	–
$\hat{\mathbf{v}}_i$	Unit vector from point i to the camera	–
r_i	Range of point i from the camera	m
r_0	Reference range for range weighting	m
Roughness estimation (Sections 3.5 and 5.3)		
$p(x, y)$	Polynomial trend surface removed by detrending (Eq. 5.6)	mm
a_{ij}	Coefficients of the detrending polynomial	mm
n	Degree of the detrending polynomial	–
c	Number of points averaged in a grid cell (Section 5.3.3)	–
z_k	Gridded residual height of cell k relative to the mean	mm
N	Number of valid grid cells (Section 5.3.4)	–

Continued on next page

Symbol	Description	Unit
g	Grid spacing	mm
n_x	Number of grid cells along the x axis	–
N_q	Number of valid grid squares	–
A_{true}	True surface area	mm^2
A_{proj}	Projected surface area	mm^2
$A_{\text{triangles}}$	Area of an individual surface triangle	mm^2
∇z	Gradient of the height field	–
σ_n	Standard deviation of uncorrelated height noise	mm
S_a	Arithmetic mean height	mm
S_q	Root-mean-square height	mm
S_{sk}	Skewness of the height distribution	–
S_{ku}	Kurtosis of the height distribution	–
S_p	Maximum peak height	mm
S_v	Maximum valley depth	mm
S_z	Maximum height, $S_p + S_v$	mm
S_{dq}	Root-mean-square gradient (slope)	–
S_{dr}	Developed interfacial area ratio	‰
S_{al}	Autocorrelation length	mm
S_{tr}	Texture aspect ratio	–
S_{td}	Texture direction	°
q	Spatial wavenumber	rad/m
$C(q)$	Power spectral density as a function of wavenumber	mm^4
H	Hurst exponent	–
D_f	Fractal dimension, $3 - H$	–
Camera characterisation (Chapter 6)		
α	Smoothing alpha of the spatial and temporal filters	–
δ	Smoothing delta (edge-preserving step threshold) of the spatial and temporal filters	–
n	Number of frames or scans summarised per data point	–
R^2	Coefficient of determination of a fitted trend	–

List of Acronyms and Glossary

baseline The distance between the optical centres of the two cameras of a stereo pair.

benthic Relating to the bottom of a body of water, and to the organisms that live on or in the sediment there.

bioturbation The reworking of sediment particles and the ventilation of burrows by animals.

CAD computer-aided design.

CSV comma-separated values.

detrending Removing large-scale form, such as tilt or curvature, from a surface by subtracting a fitted polynomial, leaving the texture to be measured.

developed interfacial area ratio The ISO 25178-2 parameter S_{dr}: the percentage by which the true surface area exceeds the projected area.

disparity The horizontal offset, in pixels, between the positions of the same scene point in the left and right images.

ECSA Engineering Council of South Africa.

eutrophication Excessive growth of algae and plants caused by high nutrient levels in the water.

F-score The harmonic mean of precision and completeness at a given distance threshold.

FOV field of view.

FPFH fast point feature histograms.

fusion Merging several registered scans into a single surface.

GAs Graduate Attributes.

GPU graphics processing unit.

ICP iterative closest point.

IMU inertial measurement unit.

intertidal The zone of shore that is exposed at low tide and submerged at high tide.

IP65 Ingress protection rating denoting a dust-tight enclosure that is protected against water jets.

IR infrared.

ISO International Organization for Standardization.

LiDAR light detection and ranging.

MAD median absolute deviation.

microtopography The relief of a surface at millimetre to centimetre scales.

MLS moving least squares.

PCL Point Cloud Library.

PLY Polygon File Format.

PSD power spectral density.

RANSAC random sample consensus.

registration Finding the rigid transformation that places one scan in the coordinate frame of another.

RGB red, green, blue.

RGB-D red, green, blue and depth.

RMSE root-mean-square error.

ROI region of interest.

rugosity The ratio of the true area of a surface to its projected area. A flat surface has a rugosity of 1.

SDK software development kit.

self-affine Describing a surface whose roughness follows a power law across scales, so its power spectrum is a straight line on log-log axes.

SfM structure-from-motion.

STL stereolithography (triangle mesh file format).

subtidal The zone below the low-tide line, which remains submerged.

ToF time of flight.

voxel A cubic cell of a regular 3D grid.

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Background

1.1.1 Sandprawns and bioturbation

Bioturbation, the reworking of sediment particles and the ventilation of burrows by animals [28], is one of the main ways in which benthic fauna, organisms present on the bottom sediment in aquatic environments, shape soft-sediment ecosystems. Burrowing thalassinidean shrimps, the group to which sandprawns belong, are among the most influential bioturbators. Pillay and Branch [41] describe how their burrowing brings buried sediment to the surface, builds mounds that change the structure and increase the area of the sediment surface, and alters the physical and chemical properties of the sediment through burrow construction and irrigation.

On the South African coast, the sandprawn *Kraussillichirus kraussi* (Stebbing, 1900) is a key ecosystem engineer. Venter et al. [56] showed experimentally that sandprawns filter phytoplankton from the overlying water by pumping water in both directions through their burrows. Long-term estuarine data further showed reductions in phytoplankton biom et alass of roughly 70% in sandprawn-dominated areas[56], which suggests that sand prawns help to buffer coastal ecosystems against eutrophication, the explosive growth of algae and plants due to overly high nutrient levels. Sandprawn abundance is commonly estimated from manual counts of burrow openings [34], which are laborious and describe only one aspect of the altered surface.

This project forms part of a wider study (Stressor interactions and synergisms in coastal sedimentary ecosystems PHASE 2: from genes to ecosystem processes) which studies the effects human interactions have on the intertidal flats and benthic ecosystems.

1.1.2 Measuring sediment microtopography

Bioturbators create mounds, burrow openings and depressions at the sediment surface. The microtopography of the surface, its relief at millimetre to centimetre scales, therefore carries a signature of the activity beneath it. Schenone et al. [49] showed in laboratory incubations that sediment microtopography predicted localised benthic ecosystem functioning. In a later field study using structure-from-motion (SfM) photogrammetry, they found that it explained a substantial proportion of the variance in biodiversity and ecosystem functioning across subtidal habitats [50]. Microtopography is summarised by areal roughness parameters. Of these, rugosity is a metric used frequently in ecological studies[29] and is the ratio of the true surface area to its projected area, and is closely related to the developed interfacial area ratio defined in ISO 25178-2 [2].

Measuring microtopography in the field is non trivial. Common mechanical sampling methods are invasive and damage the fragile structures being measured, whilst only capturing fractions of the true complexity. Non-contact alternatives such as light detection and ranging (LiDAR) and SfM photogrammetry can be expensive and cumbersome to process [7]. Azhar et al. [7] addressed this with a low-cost framework. A consumer red, green, blue and depth (RGB-D) camera, the Asus Xtion Pro Live, captured depth images of intertidal sediment,

from which roughness parameters were computed after detrending. Low-cost RGB-D sensors have similarly been used to quantify habitat complexity [25]. The Xtion relies on structured light, which is degraded by strong ambient light [21]. It therefore had to be operated inside an opaque enclosure, which limited the area of each scan.

1.2 Problem statement

The overarching project adapted, by Agoritsa Spirakis, the framework of Azhar et al. [7] to an Intel RealSense D456, mounted on a portable aluminium rig above the sediment. The D456 is an active stereo camera [4]. It computes depth on the camera by matching texture between two infrared (IR) imagers, and a projected IR dot pattern adds texture where the surface has little of its own [17, 26]. Unlike a structured-light camera, it can therefore still recover depth from naturally textured surfaces when ambient light washes out the projected pattern. As inherited, however, the system had two shortcomings.

First, its configuration had not been systematically evaluated. This covers the working distance, viewing angle, lighting, stream resolution, depth unit, visual preset and post-processing filters. Published evaluations of depth cameras [11, 21, 45] consider other camera models and mostly indoor scenes of planar or manufactured objects. None characterises the D456 on sediment-like relief at the sub-metre working distances of the rig.

Second, each surface was scanned at least four times from different mount rotations, but each scan was analysed individually. A single scan is noisy and has viewpoint-dependent errors. It also contains holes wherever relief hides the surface from the camera. The repeated scans were not combined to reduce these effects.

This project therefore characterises the D456 for close-range scanning of sediment-like surfaces. It also develops a processing pipeline that fuses multi-view scans into a single reconstruction, from which roughness parameters are computed and validated.

1.3 Project objectives

The objectives of this project were to:

- Characterise the D456 as functions of working distance, camera tilt and ambient lighting, using planar targets.
- Characterise the D456 stream settings (resolution, depth unit and visual preset) and post-processing filter settings, by evaluating scans of 3D-printed reference objects of known geometry across the different parameters.
- Develop a pipeline that automatically crops each scan to the analysis region marked by AprilTags, registers scans taken at different tilts and rotations, and fuses them into a single surface. Characterise how reconstruction accuracy depends on the combination of views.
- Develop a roughness estimation pipeline that levels, detrends and grids the fused surface and computes standardised areal roughness parameters, including rugosity. Validate it against the reference objects and against sand collected in the field in a laboratory setting.

1.4 Scope, limitations and assumptions

Scope. The project was carried out over 12 weeks, with final submission on 27 October 2026. It was limited to the existing hardware, and no other cameras were evaluated. The hardware comprised:

- A single Intel RealSense D456 on a 1 m aluminium-extrusion frame with a height-adjustable cross member.
- A manually rotated camera mount, turned in 45° increments, on a servo-driven tilt stage made by a masters student Theon Smith.
- Four adjustable AprilTag boundary markers.
- An overhead shading tarp.

Testing used planar targets, three 3D-printed reference objects, and sand collected from the Langebaan Lagoon (Klein Oesterwald). The sand was scanned in the laboratory in dry, wet and waterlogged states. Field deployment on the intertidal flats was not possible within the time available.

Limitations. The characterisation and the chosen configuration target smooth, gently undulating relief of a few centimetres, representative of sandprawn mounds. They may not transfer to objects with sharp edges. The fused surface is represented as a single-valued height field, so overhangs such as burrow walls cannot be represented. It is also smoothed with a 10 mm moving least squares (MLS) radius by default, so relief at shorter wavelengths is attenuated. Each characterisation condition was recorded once, so the repeatability of the set-up was not quantified. One of the proposed processing steps was automated feature detection, however due to the limited time, this was removed from the scope and is discussed as further work in chapter 10.

Assumptions. The following assumptions were made:

- The factory calibration of the D456 (camera intrinsics and depth-to-colour extrinsics) is accurate, and the camera does not need re-calibration.
- The surface does not change during a capture session, and the AprilTags remain fixed relative to it, so every scan in a session observes the same region.
- The sediment within the analysis region is approximately planar at the scale of the region, with relief superimposed on it.
- The camera is stationary while each scan is captured, so its accelerometer measures gravity alone.
- The 3D-printed reference objects match their computer-aided design (CAD) models closely enough to serve as ground truth. These reference objects were printed using a Bambu lab X1 carbon.

1.5 Plan of development

Chapter 2 reviews the literature on sandprawn bioturbation, microtopography as a proxy for benthic activity, and depth sensing for surface measurement. Chapter 3 presents the theory of stereo depth capture, registration, fusion, evaluation and roughness estimation. Chapter 4 defines the system requirements and describes the rig and software architecture. Chapter 5 characterises the D456 camera across different conditions. Chapter 6 describes the cropping, fusion and roughness estimation pipeline. Chapter 7 validates the complete pipeline on reference objects and laboratory sand. Chapter 8 provides a summary of the results found in the project, chapter 9 draws conclusions against the objectives, and chapter 10 outlines further work.

Chapter 2

Literature review

This chapter reviews the literature behind the project and identifies the gap it addresses. It covers why sand prawn bioturbation matters (section 2.1), whether surface microtopography is a valid proxy for it (section 2.2), how sediment surfaces can be measured (section 2.3), how depth cameras have been characterised (section 2.4) and how multiple depth scans have been fused (section 2.5). Section 2.6 summarises the resulting research gaps.

2.1 Sandprawn bioturbation and its ecological significance

Bioturbation is the reworking of sediment particles and the ventilation of burrows by animals [28]. Burrowing thalassinidean shrimps are among the most intense bioturbators in marine soft-sediment environments [10, 43] and are thus deemed ecosystem engineers, as they modify their physical surroundings affecting their co-occurring ecological community [41]. Excavating burrows and ejecting sediment alters grain size, organic content, porewater chemistry and surface topography Pillay and Branch [41]. At the surface this appears as mounds, depressions and burrow openings (Figure 2.1). Reported mounds are about 3 to 5.4 cm high and 12 to 15 cm wide [41], so a measurement system must resolve centimetre-scale heights over decimetre-scale wavelengths.

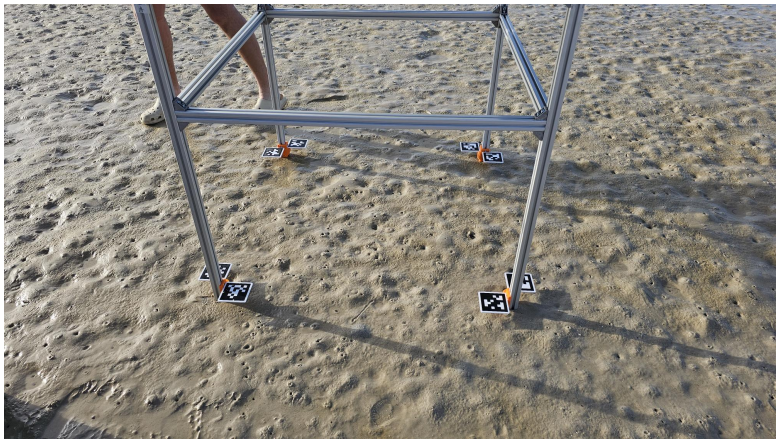


Figure 2.1: Surface Mounds and Burrow Openings Produced by *K. kraussi* on an Intertidal Sandflat. Taken on 14/07/2026 During a Field Trip

On the South African coast the dominant species is the sandprawn *K. kraussi* (*Callianassa kraussi* in older literature), which occupies most of the intertidal area of Langebaan Lagoon [34]. Its effects are substantial:

- Sediment turnover of about $12\,\mathrm{kg\,m^{-2}}$ of wet sediment per day, burying benthic microalgae and altering bacterial and meiofaunal communities [9];
- Increased abundance of surface grazers and of suspension- and deposit-feeding polychaetes and bivalves when prawns were excluded [40];
- Reductions in phytoplankton biomass of about 50 % in experiments and 70 % in prawn-dominated estuar-

ine areas, through pumping water across the burrow walls, which helps buffer coastal ecosystems against eutrophication [56].

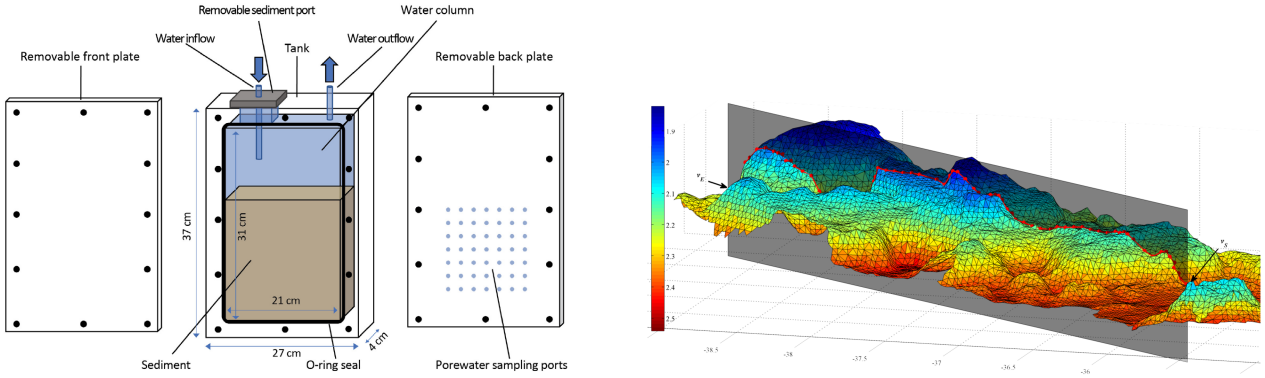
Measuring this activity usually relies on sediment cores, which are destructive and slow, or on counts of burrow openings, which are laborious and capture only one surface feature. Surface structure also matters in its own right, as homogenising it reduces soft-sediment biodiversity [54]. Surface relief is therefore both a product of bioturbation and a habitat variable, which raises the question of whether it can be measured in place of only the animals' presence, in a non-destructive fashion.

2.2 Sediment microtopography as a proxy for benthic activity

In this project, the case for microtopography as a proxy rests mainly on three studies by Schenone and colleagues:

- In a multi-site field study, biogenic surface features predicted ecosystem functioning better than species density [48];
- In flow-through laboratory tanks (Figure 2.2a), rugosity from a single 2D profile imaged through the tank wall explained 35% to 61 % of the variability in oxygen and nutrient fluxes [49];
- In the field, microtopography reconstructed with SfM explained more than half of the variance in environmental variables, benthic fluxes, biodiversity and functional traits [50].

None of these studies involved K. kraussi. The two field studies, one intertidal [48] and one subtidal [50], are correlative and establish microtopography as a surrogate rather than a mechanism. The laboratory study manipulated species composition and therefore supports a causal link [49], but only for two species under controlled conditions, with rugosity taken from a single 2D profile.There is still a knowledge gap on the link between structures produced by sandprawns and ecosystem functioning. Testing this relationship in Langebaan Lagoon is one of the aims of a wider study, that will be supported by accurate enough microtopography measurements that this project will contribute to.



(a) Flow-through Incubation Tank [49].

(b) Chain-and-tape 2D line Compared to 3D Geometry [15].

Figure 2.2: Measuring Microtopography as an Ecological Proxy.

How roughness is quantified matters as much as how it is measured. Traditional chain-and-tape rugosity compares the length of a chain laid along the bed with its straight-line length. It samples a single profile and overestimates rugosity when the chain wanders sideways [15]. Friedman et al. [15] instead computed rugosity from stereo meshes relative to a plane of best fit (Figure 2.2b), which decouples rugosity from slope, and SfM-derived rugosity has proved more powerful than chain-and-tape [53]. ISO 25178-2 standardises these quantities as areal parameters [2, 30], where the developed interfacial area ratio S_{dr} is rugosity expressed as a percentage excess area (chapter 3). Azhar et al. [7] used a comparable set of nine parameters from detrended depth images.

These parameters depend on how the surface is sampled. They vary with scan size and pixel resolution [24], and slope-based parameters such as S_{dq}, S_{dr} and rugosity are dominated by the shortest resolved wavelengths,

where sensor noise and smoothing also act. Rugosity from a depth camera is therefore only interpretable when the noise floor and effective resolution of the measurement are known.

2.3 Non-contact measurement of sediment surfaces

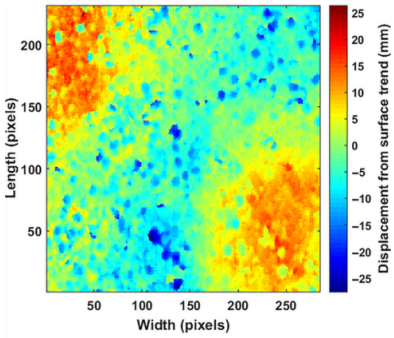
A system for this application must resolve millimetre-scale relief over sediment patches, be portable and fast enough for a low-tide window, leave the surface undisturbed, and work in daylight on dry, wet and waterlogged sand. Coring and contact profiling damage the structures being measured [7], so only non-contact methods are considered (Table 2.1).

Table 2.1: Non-contact Methods for Measuring Sediment Surfaces.

Method	Strengths	Limitations
Terrestrial laser scanning	Accurate; return intensity calibrated to sand moisture [37]	Expensive; cumbersome processing [7]
SfM photogrammetry	Cheap hardware; very fine resolution [53]	Many images, scale reference and offline processing
Structured light	Immediate metric depth; ≤1 mm at 0.5 m [25, 33]	Pattern washed out by sunlight, needs shading [7]
Passive stereo	Tolerates sunlight	Needs a GPU host [45]; fails on textureless surfaces
Active stereo	Tolerates sunlight on textured surfaces; depth computed on board [26]	Field evidence only for other models [57]

The framework this project builds on, Azhar et al. [7], imaged 0.3 m^2 patches of intertidal sediment at seven sites with an Asus Xtion Pro Live inside a semi-opaque container (Figure 2.3a). The container was a necessity as a structured-light camera triangulates against its own projected pattern, which sunlight washes out, so the shading fixed both the size of each scan and its single viewpoint. Azhar et al. [7] also investigated four detrending models, tested on simulated surfaces, and found linear and quadratic models performed best and agreed strongly with field data.

(a) RGB-D Device and Container in the Field [7].



(b) Captured and Detrended Sediment Surface [7].

Figure 2.3: The RGB-D Framework of Azhar et al. [7].

Sunlight tolerance therefore decides the choice of sensor. An active stereo camera matches texture between two infrared imagers, and its projected dots only supplement the scene texture, so on a textured surface in strong light it degrades towards passive stereo rather than failing [17, 26]. Vit and Shani [57]found the active stereo D435 as the most viable of four close-range sensors in outdoor settings. The D456 used here is the IP65-rated variant of the D455 [4], which also suits wet intertidal work.

2.4 Characterisation of active stereo depth cameras

Intel's documents describe the D400 correlation algorithm and its expected performance [26], the choice of resolution, preset, depth unit and laser power [18], the post-processing filters [19], external projectors [17] and the plane-fit test methodology used in this project [1]. None evaluates these settings against ground-truth relief at the millimetre scale relevant to sediment.

Independent studies are summarised in Table 2.2. The closest precedent is Servi et al. [52], who applied ISO 10360-13 to the D415, D455 and L515 and found the D455 best in the standardised tests. The D456 shares the D455 optical module [4], but that study was confined to manufactured artefacts in the laboratory. Results for the D435, which Rustler et al. [45] found best within 1 m, do not transfer, because its 50 mm baseline differs from the 95 mm of the D455 module. Nguyen et al. [36] showed that noise models from distance and angle sweeps improve fusion, and the sweeps in this project follow the same logic.

Table 2.2: Published Depth-camera Characterisations Relevant to this Project. SL: Structured Light; AS: Active Stereo; PS: Passive Stereo; ToF: Time of Flight.

Study	Sensors (technology)	Targets	Environment
Halmetschlager-Funek et al. [21]	Ten sensors (SL, AS, ToF)	Planar targets, several materials	Indoor
Carfagni et al. [11]	D415 (AS)	VDI/VDE 2634 artefacts, 0.1–1 m	Laboratory
Servi et al. [52]	D415, D455 (AS); L515 (ToF lidar)	ISO 10360-13 artefacts, flat and 3D objects, 0.1–1.5 m	Laboratory
Rustler et al. [45]	D435, D455, OAK-D Pro (AS); ZED 2 (PS)	Plane, doll, household objects, up to 4 m	Indoor
Vit and Shani [57]	Kinect v2 (ToF), Astra S (SL), SR300 (SL), D435 (AS)	Maize plants, close range	Outdoor, varied light
Azhar et al. [7]	Xtion Pro Live (SL)	Plane; intertidal sediment	Outdoor, shaded

No study was found that characterises any active stereo camera on wet or waterlogged sediment. Nolet et al. [37] found that sand reflectance falls non-linearly with moisture from 350 to 2500 nm (Figure 2.4), so wet sand is darker in the near-infrared and offers less pattern return and contrast for matching. Standing water adds specular reflection and refraction [33], and some sensors fail on reflective materials [21]. The behaviour of the D456 on wet sand must therefore be established experimentally.

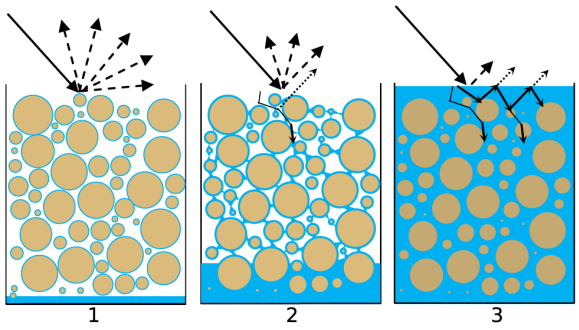


Figure 2.4: Reflectance of Sand Decreasing Non-linearly as Moisture Content Increases [37].

2.5 Registration and fusion of multi-view depth scans

Fusing aligned range images into a weighted signed distance function averages noise, fills gaps and weights measurements by reliability [13]. KinectFusion applied this in real time with a consumer depth camera and showed that the fused model contains detail absent from any single frame (Figure 2.5) [35]. These methods were developed for objects and rooms, and judged by geometric accuracy rather than by roughness parameters.

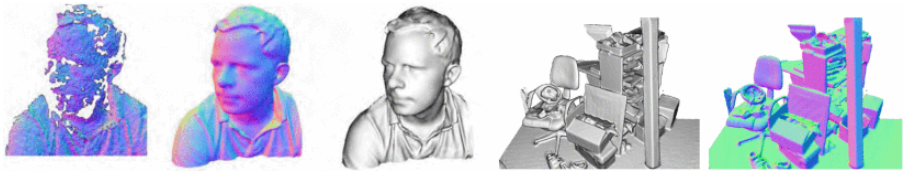


Figure 2.5: A Single Noisy Depth Frame (Left) Compared With the Surface Fused From Many Frames [35].

Two results bear on sediment. First, nearly flat surfaces are degenerate for registration, since iterative closest point (ICP) cannot constrain sliding within a plane or rotation about its normal [16]. A near-planar bed therefore needs external constraints such as AprilTags [38, 58] or inertial measurements. Second, benthic fusion is normally done at survey scale using vehicle navigation [15], not by fusing repeated close-range views of one patch. Azhar et al. [7] used a single viewpoint, and the inherited system analysed each repeated scan individually. No study was found that fuses multi-view scans of a sediment patch and quantifies how the choice of views affects reconstruction accuracy and roughness.

2.6 Summary and research gap

K. kraussi is a dominant ecosystem engineer of the Langebaan Lagoon intertidal space, and sediment microtopography is a credible proxy candidate for its bioturbation activity. Roughness parameters, however, depend on the noise and resolution of the measurement. Active stereo is the best-supported low-cost sensor for outdoor use, but it has not been tested in this setting. Four gaps remain, each addressed by one objective in section 1.3 (Table 2.3).

Table 2.3: Research Gaps and the Objectives that Address them.

Gap	Objective
The D455 module has been characterised only in the laboratory [52]. Its noise, bias and fill rate at the rig's distances, tilts and outdoor lighting are unknown.	1: Planar characterisation
Manufacturer guidance on resolution, depth unit, preset and filters is not validated against relief of the scale of sandprawn mounds.	2: Reference-object characterisation
Multi-view fusion has not been applied to close-range sediment scans, and near-flat beds defeat purely geometric registration.	3: Cropping and fusion pipeline
Rugosity from RGB-D data has not been validated against surfaces of known geometry.	4: Roughness pipeline and validation

Chapter 3

Theoretical Background

This chapter outlines the theory behind the project, separated by each stage: depth measurement, registration, fusion, evaluation and roughness estimation. The main aim of this section is to provide a high level description of some of the fundamentals. Implementation details and parameter choices are given in chapter 4 and chapter 5.

3.1 Depth Capture

Seeing Double Vision Can Be Good

The Intel RealSense D456 is an IP65-rated version of the D455, built from the same D450 optical module and D4 vision processor [4]. It contains two global-shutter imagers separated by a baseline of 95 mm, an IR laser projector, a global-shutter red, green, blue (RGB) camera and an inertial measurement unit (IMU). The Camera features the D4 processor, which computes depth on the camera, so the host receives depth images rather than stereo image pairs.

3.1.1 Camera Model

Each imager is modelled as a pinhole camera [22]. A point $\mathbf{X}_w$, in a world frame is mapped to the pixel (u, v) by

$$\lambda\,(u,\,v,\,1)^\top = \mathbf{K}\,[\mathbf{R} \mid \mathbf{t}]\,(\mathbf{X}_w^\top,\,1)^\top, \qquad \mathbf{K} = \begin{bmatrix} f_x & 0 & c_x \\ 0 & f_y & c_y \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}, \tag{3.1}$$

where $\mathbf{X}_w = (X_w, Y_w, Z_w)^\top$ is the point in the world frame, and $(X, Y, Z)^\top = \mathbf{R}\mathbf{X}_w + \mathbf{t}$ is the same point in the camera frame, whose depth Z equals the homogeneous scale factor λ. The intrinsic matrix $\mathbf{K}$ holds the focal lengths f_x,f_y in pixels and the principal point (c_x, c_y). The extrinsic parameters $\mathbf{R}$ and $\mathbf{t}$ give the pose of the camera relative to another frame, such as the world or a second sensor. Real lenses add radial and tangential distortion, and calibration estimates all of these parameters, typically from images of a known planar target [59]. The D456 is factory calibrated, and because its stereo images are rectified on the camera, the depth stream is described by a distortion-free pinhole model while the colour stream has its own distortion coefficients.

Projection discards depth, since all points along a ray through the camera centre map to the same pixel. A single image therefore cannot recover $\mathbf{X}$. The depth Z is instead supplied by stereo matching (subsection 3.1.2). Inverting Equation 3.1 for a pixel with given measured depth Z gives the corresponding point in the camera frame,

$$X = \frac{(u - c_x)\,Z}{f_x}, \qquad Y = \frac{(v - c_y)\,Z}{f_y}, \tag{3.2}$$

which is how a depth image becomes a point cloud. Depth is aligned to the colour image by back-projecting each pixel, transforming it with the depth-to-colour extrinsics and projecting it with the colour intrinsics.

3.1.2 Stereo Triangulation

After rectification the image rows of the two cameras are aligned, so a scene point appears on the same row in both images and the search for its match is one-dimensional [22]. In the geometry of Figure 3.1, a point P at depth Z projects to horizontal image coordinates x_L and x_R, measured from each principal point, and similar triangles give

$$Z = \frac{fB}{d}, \qquad d = x_L - x_R, \tag{3.3}$$

where f is the focal length in pixels, B the baseline and d the disparity. The camera finds d for each pixel by comparing small image patches along the row, and interpolates the best match to a fraction of a pixel [26].

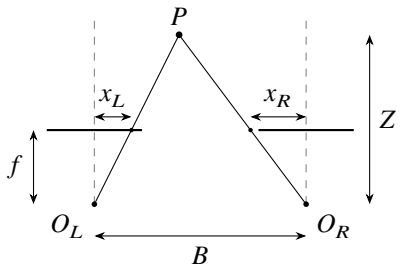


Figure 3.1: Rectified stereo geometry: camera centres O_L, O_R, baseline B, focal length f and the projections x_L, x_R of a point P at depth Z.

Differentiating Equation 3.3 gives the depth uncertainty caused by an uncertainty σ_d in disparity,

$$\sigma_Z = \frac{Z^2}{fB}\,\sigma_d. \tag{3.4}$$

For a fixed matching error, depth noise grows with the square of the range and falls with a longer baseline or focal length [26]. Since f in pixels is proportional to the horizontal resolution, a lower resolution also increases the noise. A constant σ_d is optimistic since it depends on the contrast of the matched texture, which falls as the projected pattern dims with distance or is washed out by ambient light.

The disparity search also has a finite range. The D4 processor searches 126 disparities [20], so the minimum measurable depth is $Z_{\min} = \frac{fB}{126}$. At 1280×720, $f \approx \frac{640}{\tan(87^\circ/2)} \approx 674\,\text{px}$, giving $Z_{\min} \approx 0.51\,\text{m}$, consistent with the specified 0.52 m [4]. Equation 3.4 and $Z_{\min}$ together set the working-distance trade-off characterised in chapter 6. the camera should be as close as $Z_{\min}$ and the required field of view allow.

3.1.3 Passive Stereo, Structured Light and Active Stereo

Passive stereo matches natural texture between two cameras, and fails where the surface is uniform because many patches along a row look alike. Structured light, used by the Asus Xtion in the system of [7], projects a known pattern and triangulates between the projector and a single camera, so the pattern itself must be known and calibrated. Active stereo, the principle of the D456, combines a stereo pair with a projector of a semi-random dot pattern, which can be seen in Appendix B, [17, 26]. Matching is still performed between the two cameras, so the pattern does not need to be known, the main purpose is to add additional texture onto the surface. On a featureless surface, such as the white board of chapter 6, depth therefore depends entirely on the dots and fails when sunlight, whose near-infrared component can outshine them, washes them out. On a naturally textured surface in sunlight the camera behaves as a passive stereo camera and still returns dense depth. Both behaviours were observed in chapter 6. The RGB camera has an IR-cut filter, so the dots do not appear in the colour image.

3.2 Registration

Each scan is expressed in the frame of the camera at the moment of capture, so the same point on the sediment has different coordinates in scans taken at different rotations and tilts. Registration finds the rigid transformation that maps one scan into the frame of another, and is needed both for fusion (section 5.2) and for comparison with a reference model (section 4.5).

3.2.1 Rigid Transformations and Closed-Form Alignment

A rigid transformation maps a point $\mathbf{p}$ to $\mathbf{R}\mathbf{p} + \mathbf{t}$, where $\mathbf{R}$ is a rotation matrix ($\mathbf{R}^\top\mathbf{R} = \mathbf{I}$, $\det\mathbf{R} = +1$) and $\mathbf{t}$ a translation, giving six degrees of freedom. If N corresponding point pairs $(\mathbf{p}_i, \mathbf{q}_i)$ are known, the transformation that minimises $\sum_i \|\mathbf{R}\mathbf{p}_i + \mathbf{t} - \mathbf{q}_i\|^2$ has a closed-form solution [6, 55]. With centroids $\bar{\mathbf{p}}$ and $\bar{\mathbf{q}}$, and the singular value decomposition $\mathbf{H} = \sum_i (\mathbf{p}_i - \bar{\mathbf{p}})(\mathbf{q}_i - \bar{\mathbf{q}})^\top = \mathbf{U}\mathbf{\Sigma}\mathbf{V}^\top$,

$$\mathbf{R} = \mathbf{V}\,\mathrm{diag}(1, 1, \det(\mathbf{V}\mathbf{U}^\top))\,\mathbf{U}^\top, \qquad \mathbf{t} = \bar{\mathbf{q}} - \mathbf{R}\bar{\mathbf{p}}. \tag{3.5}$$

The determinant term ensures a proper rotation rather than a reflection when the data are noisy [55]. At least three non-collinear pairs are needed because if the points lie close to a line, rotation about that line is poorly determined, which is why the tag-based alignment in section 5.2 takes the tilt from the IMU when the visible tags are nearly collinear. A stationary accelerometer measures only gravity, which fixes the two tilt angles but not the rotation about the vertical axis, which can be determined from tag identification or surface geometry.

3.2.2 Fiducial Markers

AprilTags are square black-and-white markers that encode an identifier in a binary grid. The codes are chosen to keep a large minimum Hamming distance between all identifiers in all four rotations, so a tag is rarely misidentified even when some bits are read incorrectly [38]. The detector fits quadrilaterals to the boundaries between light and dark regions, decodes the bits inside each candidate, and returns each tag's identifier and the sub-pixel positions of its four corners [58].

The corners of a planar tag of known size are related to their image positions by a homography $\mathbf{H} \simeq \mathbf{K}[\mathbf{r}_1\ \mathbf{r}_2\ \mathbf{t}]$, where $\mathbf{r}_1$ and $\mathbf{r}_2$ are the first two columns of the tag's rotation matrix [22, 59]. Given $\mathbf{K}$, the pose follows from $\mathbf{K}^{-1}\mathbf{H}$ with $\mathbf{r}_3 = \mathbf{r}_1 \times \mathbf{r}_2$. This monocular estimate rests on four closely spaced points and is sensitive to corner noise. For a small or nearly fronto-parallel tag, two different orientations can fit the corners almost equally well [51]. The pipeline instead uses the depth data, intersecting the corner pixel rays with a plane fitted to the measured depth of each tag (section 5.1). This gives 3D corners in every scan, so aligning two scans becomes a 3D-to-3D problem solved with Equation 3.5.

3.2.3 Feature-Based Coarse Alignment

When no prior pose is available, correspondences must be found from the shape of the surface. fast point feature histograms (FPFH) describe the geometry around each point by the angles between its surface normal and those of its neighbours, expressed in a local coordinate frame. Three angular features are each binned into 11 bins and concatenated into a 33-element histogram [46]. Because only relative angles are used, the descriptor does not change under rigid motion. Candidate correspondences are formed by pairing points with similar descriptors, and many of these pairs are wrong.

Random sample consensus (RANSAC) estimates the transformation in the presence of these outliers [14]. It repeatedly selects three correspondences at random, computes their transformation with Equation 3.5, and counts the inliers (correspondences brought within a distance threshold), keeping the transformation with the most inliers. If a fraction w of the correspondences is correct, drawing at least one all-inlier sample with probability p takes $N = \log(1-p)\,/\,\log(1-w^3)$ trials, or about 4600 for $w = 0.1$ and $p = 0.99$. On flat or smoothly undulating

sediment most points have nearly identical descriptors, so w is small and an incorrect transformation can gather as many inliers as the correct one. This is why feature matching is only a fallback in this pipeline (section 5.2).

3.2.4 Iterative Closest Point

ICP refines an approximate alignment by alternately pairing each source point with its nearest target point and solving for the transformation that minimises the distance between the pairs. The point-to-point form [8] minimises Euclidean distance and is solved with Equation 3.5. The point-to-plane form [12] minimises the distance from each source point to the tangent plane at its paired target point,

$$E(\mathbf{R}, \mathbf{t}) = \sum_i \Big((\mathbf{R}\mathbf{p}_i + \mathbf{t} - \mathbf{q}_i) \cdot \mathbf{n}_i \Big)^2, \tag{3.6}$$

where $\mathbf{n}_i$ is the target normal. This has no closed-form solution, but for the small rotations of a refinement step it can be linearised and solved as a six-parameter linear least-squares problem [32].

Two scans never sample exactly the same points. Point-to-point ICP penalises the resulting tangential offsets, which slows convergence, whereas point-to-plane ICP lets points slide along the surface and on smooth surfaces usually converges in far fewer iterations and to a more accurate pose, at the cost of requiring normals [44]. Both forms are local, descending to the nearest minimum of the cost, so the initial pose must already be close, and both are limited by the geometry of the surface rather than by the error metric. On a plane, translation within the plane and rotation about its normal leave the point-to-plane cost unchanged and change the point-to-point cost only slightly, so these motions are effectively unconstrained [16]. A nearly flat sediment bed is close to this degenerate case, so its in-plane pose must be fixed by the tags or the coarse stages, with ICP refining the remaining degrees of freedom.

3.3 Fusion

Putting Bits Together

Volumetric methods divide space into a voxel grid in which each voxel stores its signed distance to the surface. Each registered scan updates these values through a weighted running average, and the fused surface is extracted where the distance is zero [13, 35]. For a nearly flat bed, a 2.5D height field $z(x, y)$ on a grid aligned with the mean plane is a simpler equivalent in which each cell collects the heights from all scans (section 5.2). One consideration with this method, is that it cannot represent overhangs and sharp features, such as burrow walls.

First all scans points are weighted. When measurements have independent errors with different variances σ_k^2, the combination with the lowest variance is the weighted mean with weights $w_k \propto 1/\sigma_k^2$. Depth error grows with range (Equation 3.4) and with obliquity, therefore a surface seen at a grazing angle is foreshortened and its depth varies across each matching window, and the axial noise of depth sensors has been observed to rise sharply as the angle between the surface normal and the viewing direction approaches 90° [36]. Measurements are therefore down-weighted with both, in the spirit of the angle-based weights of [13].

A misregistered scan or stray point produces errors that are neither small nor normally distributed. One such value can move the mean arbitrarily far, while the median tolerates up to half the data being bad but discards much of the information in good data. The trimmed mean, which discards a fixed fraction of the lowest and highest values (by cumulative weight, in a weighted version) before averaging, lies between the two [23].

MLS fits a low-order polynomial surface to the neighbours of each point within a radius h, with weights that decrease with distance, and projects the point onto it [5, 31]. This removes noise and residual layer offsets on scales below h, but it is a low-pass filter that also attenuates relief with wavelengths comparable to or shorter than h, so h sets a lower bound on the scale of roughness the fused surface can represent.

3.4 Evaluation

Are We Winning?

Each reconstruction is first registered to the reference model (section 4.5). For each reconstructed point $\mathbf{s}_i$ lying over the part, d_i is its signed distance to the closest point on the reference surface, positive on the side of the outward surface normal. Points on the table or other surroundings are excluded from the accuracy statistics. Distances are computed to the reference triangles rather than to its vertices, which avoids any dependence on how densely the reference is sampled.

Over N points the bias μ, standard deviation σ and root-mean-square error (RMSE) are

$$\mu = \frac{1}{N}\sum_i d_i, \qquad \sigma^2 = \frac{1}{N}\sum_i (d_i - \mu)^2, \qquad \mathrm{RMSE} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N}\sum_i d_i^2} = \sqrt{\mu^2 + \sigma^2}. \tag{3.7}$$

The bias measures systematic offset, σ random spread, and the RMSE combines both. Because registration chooses the pose that best fits the reference, part of any systematic error, such as a small tilt, is absorbed into the pose, so the metrics measure shape error after the best rigid fit rather than absolute accuracy.

Accuracy metrics are computed only over points that exist, so a reconstruction that covers only the easy parts of an object can still score well. Following [27], the precision $P(\tau)$ is the fraction of reconstructed points within τ of the reference, the completeness $C(\tau)$ is the fraction of points sampled uniformly over the reference surface that lie within τ of the reconstruction, and the F-score $F = 2PC/(P+C)$ is high only when both are high. These are computed at $\tau = 0.5, 1, 2$ and 5 mm.

3.5 Roughness Calculation

Rough Times Ahead

A measured surface combines form, waviness and roughness at progressively shorter wavelengths. ISO 25178-2 defines areal texture parameters on a scale-limited surface, obtained by removing the form and restricting the wavelength band with filters [2, 30]. Here the form is removed by subtracting a fitted low-order polynomial $p(x, y) = \sum_{i+j\le n} a_{ij}\, x_n^i\, y_n^j$, and the band is set implicitly, at the short end by the grid spacing and MLS radius, and at the long end by the polynomial degree and patch size (section 5.3). A higher degree removes more long-wavelength relief, so the degree decides what counts as roughness. [7] found a planar fit the most robust for sediment in the intertidal region.

The parameters, defined in Section section 5.3, fall into three groups. Height parameters (S_a, S_q, S_{sk}, S_{ku}) describe the distribution of residual heights but not their arrangement, so two surfaces can share the same S_q yet have very different feature sizes. Spatial parameters (S_{al}, S_{tr}) describe feature size and directionality. Hybrid parameters combine height and spacing through the slope: S_{dq} is the root-mean-square gradient and S_{dr} the developed interfacial area ratio, the percentage by which the true surface area exceeds the projected area. Rugosity, as used in benthic ecology, is the same quantity expressed as the ratio $A_{\mathrm{true}}/A_{\mathrm{proj}} = 1 + S_{dr}/100$. For gentle slopes the area element $\sqrt{1 + |\nabla z|^2} \approx 1 + \frac{1}{2}|\nabla z|^2$, so $S_{dr} \approx 50\, S_{dq}^2$ % and rugosity is essentially a measure of the mean squared slope.

Scale dependence. Slopes are estimated from height differences between neighbouring grid cells a distance g apart. Natural surfaces have relief over a wide range of scales, often approximately self-affine with a power-law spectrum, so S_{dq}, S_{dr} and rugosity depend on g [24]. Noise makes this worse since uncorrelated height noise σ_n adds a variance of $2\sigma_n^2/g^2$ to a forward-difference slope along each axis. For example, $\sigma_n = 0.5$ mm on a 2 mm grid adds a root-mean-square slope of about 0.35 per axis, which can exceed the true slope of a gently rippled bed. Slope-based parameters are therefore comparable only between surfaces processed with the same grid spacing and smoothing, and the noise contribution must be removed before rugosity is attributed to the sediment. Height parameters are much less sensitive to g.

Chapter 4

System Design

This chapter defines the general requirements of the system as a whole and describes the hardware rig used to capture scans, and the software pipeline built to capture, and process the data to provide useful metrics about the sediment surface. The theory in chapter 3 is applied here, and the sensor characterisation in chapter 6 uses the system as specified below.

4.1 Requirements Definition

The aim of the overarching project is to provide a reliable proxy for sandprawn surficial bioturbation on intertidal sediment, within the Langebaan Lagoon, by measuring surface microtopography and extracting roughness metrics. The initial stages of the project were adapted from the framework of Azhar et al. [7], primarily modified to use the Intel RealSense D456.

This project aims to provide an investigation into the performance of the RealSense D456 camera currently used. The central aim is to precisely characterise the depth camera performance in order to determine the optimal hardware and software configuration for its use in the intertidal space. Scans taken under those configurations will then be used to build a high-quality reconstruction of the sediment. This reconstruction aims at providing reliable data on which analyses (sediment roughness quantification) can be performed. The key output is an analysis of depth noise and reconstruction accuracy under different conditions.

4.2 System Overview

The system has three main operational stages, shown in Figure 4.1, with a fourth evaluation stage used for characterisation.

1. *Capture*: The capture software rs_marker scans the surface at multiple rotations and camera tilts.
2. *Fusion*: multi-angle scans are cropped to the tag-defined region, aligned and merged into a single reconstruction.
3. *Microtopography processing*: the fused surface is detrended, and roughness metrics are extracted

For the purpose of characterisation, a fourth evaluation stage is used to gauge the reconstruction and metrics performance of the system against the relief known target.

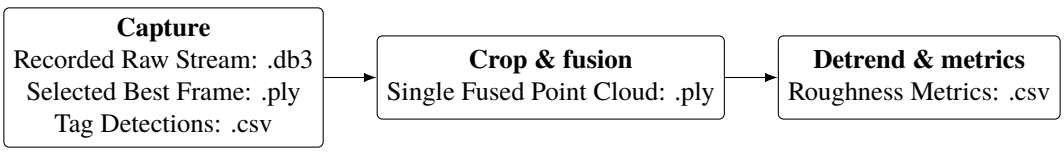


Figure 4.1: System Overview.

Table 4.1: Hardware Summary.

Component	Specification
Depth camera	Intel RealSense D456
Frame	Aluminium extrusion, ≈ 1 m^3, sliding H-frame
Tilt actuation	Servo, $\pm 60^\circ$, Arduino-controlled
Rotation	Manual, 45° increments, 360°
Boundary markers	Four adjustable AprilTags
Ambient light control	Overhead tarp

4.3 Hardware Rig

A summary of the hardware used for the capture rig is shown in Table 4.1.

4.3.1 Frame

The existing rig was built from 3030 aluminium extrusion in a 1 m × 1 m × 1 m frame. The top of the frame has a plastic tarp attached, this allows for the shading of the scan area in the event of direct sunlight degrading the active stereo functionality of the D456. This frame was modified for the purpose of this project, in order to feature an H-shaped cross member that can slide vertically along the four legs. This enables the ability to adjust the camera height, and thus working distance, for purpose of characterisation and easy configuration. It was also modified to feature 3D printed April tag mounts that allow the position to be adjusted

4.3.2 Camera, Tilt and Rotation Mechanism

The Intel RealSense D456 is mounted on the H-frame through a 3D-printed bracket bolted to the extrusion. A servo motor in the bracket tilts the camera by up to $\pm 60^\circ$. The camera clips onto a rotating platform on the tilt stage and can be turned manually through a full 360° in 45° increments. Together, tilt and rotation allow each surface point to be observed from several viewing directions, which reduces occlusion within burrows and mounds. This multi-view scanning additionally averages out view-dependent depth error. The servo is driven by an Arduino microcontroller, connected to and commanded from the operator's laptop, which also runs the capture software.

4.3.3 AprilTag Boundary Markers

Four AprilTags are mounted on brackets on the frame legs, and each bracket can slide inward or outward. The tags' positions define a square region on the sediment surface to be processed and analysed. This gives a repeatable, physically marked analysis region, and its size can be changed to suit the desired scan region or height configuration of the camera. Because the tags are fixed to the frame, their detected positions also provide a geometric cue for aligning scans taken from different tilt and rotation settings.

4.4 Software Architecture and Processing Pipeline

4.4.1 Capture Software

Capture is implemented in C++ utilising the RealSense software development kit (SDK). For each rig pose, it applies a configurable chain of depth post-processing filters and records the stream to a `.db3` file, together with

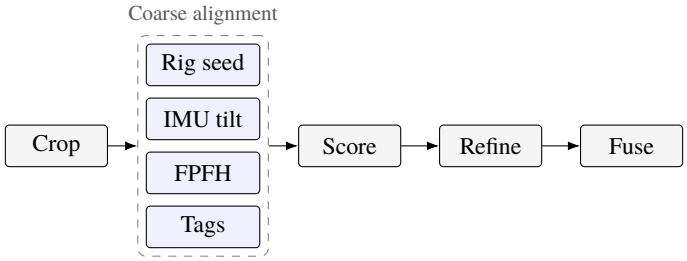


Figure 4.2: System Overview: Cropped Scans Yield Four Coarse-pose Hypotheses (Rig Kinematics, IMU-measured Tilt, FPFH+RANSAC, AprilTags), which are Scored, Refined with Point-to-plane ICP, and Fused.

IMU data. It detects the four AprilTags in the colour image, and the best frame of each pose is exported as a point cloud in Polygon File Format (PLY) format. Tag detection is stored along side captures for use of later processing through cropping and alignment.

4.4.2 Cropping and Multi-Angle Fusion

Each scan is first cropped to the square defined by the four tags. The cropped scans, taken at different tilt and rotation settings, are then fused. Fusion needs a good initial pose before refinement, so the pipeline generates several coarse alignment hypotheses by independent methods:

1. From the detected tag locations;
2. From the known rotation and servo tilt angle set on the rig;
3. From the camera IMU orientation;
4. From RANSAC matching of FPFH features.

Each hypothesis is scored with a common alignment-quality measure, and the highest-scoring one is selected. It is then refined with ICP and the merged surface passes to the microtopography stage. Using four independent seeds makes the fusion robust to the failure mode of any single method (for example, feature matching on a nearly planar surface, or IMU drift).

4.4.3 Microtopography Processing

The fused surface is detrended with a robust polynomial fit, which removes the large-scale slope and leaves the microtopography. Roughness is then quantified with reference-free, ISO 25178-2-style areal height and area parameters, together with spectral and multi-scale descriptors, computed on the gridded residual height map. Mounds and burrow openings are segmented from the microtopography using thresholding and morphological operations.

4.5 Evaluation Framework and Ground Truth

For characterisation and validation, a separate Python tool, `evaluate_scans`, measures the geometric error of any scan, whether a single capture or the fused output, against a known reference. It reuses the structure of the fusion pipeline's alignment stage, but aligns each scan to the reference. The tool then evaluates scan accuracy and coverage against the reference object.

4.5.1 Reference objects and evaluation

Three 3D-printed reference objects were used (chapter C). Each has a 100×100 mm footprint. Two are sinusoidal "egg box" surfaces of the form $z = \sin(x) + \sin(y)$ at a large scale (feature spacing 50 mm, amplitude 20 mm) and a small scale (25 mm, amplitude 15 mm), and the third is a square-based pyramid of 50 mm height. The smooth sinusoidal surfaces are somewhat analogous to the smooth mounds produced by sandprawns, although the amplitudes of these objects far exceed those found in literature. These are predominately used as previous work on this system used them, and so reference with respect to those reconstructions is desired. The pyramid has sharp edges and planar facets, which show whether the filters preserve geometric edges or smooth them.

Scans were evaluated with the evaluate_scans tool described in section 4.5. The tool rigidly aligns each scan to the reference stereolithography (triangle mesh file format) (STL) model, using feature-matching starts followed by point-to-plane ICP, and then computes point-to-surface distances. Scale is not estimated, so any scale error in the camera data appears as geometric error. The metrics used are Accuracy RMSE, signed bias, completeness at 2mm and computed F-score at 2mm. F-score is a combined metric which aims to represent both precision and completeness in a single metric.

$$P(\tau) = \frac{1}{|S|} \sum_{s \in S} \mathbb{1}\Big[\min_{r \in R} \|s - r\| < \tau \Big] \tag{4.1}$$

$$C(\tau) = \frac{1}{|R|} \sum_{r \in R} \mathbb{1}\Big[\min_{s \in S} \|r - s\| < \tau \Big] \tag{4.2}$$

$$F(\tau) = \frac{2\,P(\tau)\,C(\tau)}{P(\tau) + C(\tau)} \tag{4.3}$$

Let S denote the set of scanned points and R the set of points sampled from the reference model. For a distance threshold τ, precision Equation 4.1) is the fraction of scanned points lying within τ of the reference surface, and completeness (Equation 4.2) is the fraction of reference points lying within τ of the scan. The F-score (Equation 4.3) is their harmonic mean, and therefore penalises both spurious points and missing coverage. It is calculated at $\tau = 0.5$, 1, 2 and 5 mm, however for the purposes of this report, all results consider the threshold of $\tau = 2$ mm as this gives a balance of high accuracy representation, whilst still including relatively large bias/point spread.

Chapter 5

Data Processing Pipeline

The capture stage (chapter 4) produces one session per experiment. A session contains multiple individual scans of the same patch of sediment, one per combination of mount rotation and tilt. Each scan stores the single best depth frame as a coloured point cloud (.ply), together with the AprilTag detections for the whole recording, the IMU sample taken with the best frame, the full recording and a text dump of the camera configuration.

A single scan of the surface contains several factors that result in lower quality reconstructions. It contains the rig frame and regions outside bounded area due to the wide field of view of the camera. It is noisy, particularly where the surface is seen at a grazing angle. It also has holes wherever relief hides part of the surface from that viewpoint. The processing pipeline turns a session of multiple of such scans into a single, clean reconstruction of the region of interest and then into numbers that describe its roughness. There are three main stages in the data processing pipeline.

1. **Cropping** (section 5.1) cuts every scan down to the square of sediment bounded by the four corner AprilTags.
2. **Fusion** (section 5.2) registers the cropped scans into one common coordinate frame and merges their overlapping regions into a single, lower-noise surface with fewer holes.
3. **Roughness estimation** (section 5.3) levels and detrends the fused surface and computes standardised surface-texture parameters, including rugosity.

Each stage is a separate program that reads the previous stage's output files, so any stage can be rerun or inspected on its own. The language of each program was chosen for its workload. Cropping is mostly file management and image geometry, so it is written in Python with Open3D and NumPy. Fusion runs nearest-neighbour searches, feature matching and iterative registration on millions of points, so it is written in C++ with the Point Cloud Library (PCL). The roughness metrics are array operations on a regular grid and are written in Python with NumPy and SciPy. A small Python script (bulk_process.py) chains cropping and fusion over many sessions without user interaction.

5.1 Point Cloud Cropping

In Too Deep

The raw point clouds have three problems that make them unsuitable for direct use.

1. **The field of view is larger than the region of interest.** The Intel RealSense D456 has a wide field of view, so even with the camera pointed straight down it records depth well outside the patch of sediment inside the experimental rig.

2. **The view changes with every scan.** Because the camera is carried on a rotating and tilting mount, tilted scans look past the edge of the rig and often capture the rig frame itself. These points do not belong to the surface and would corrupt both registration and the roughness statistics.

3. **Large scans are expensive and overlap poorly.** Fusion compares every scan with every other scan already placed. Points outside the shared region add computation without adding information.

The cropping step therefore reduces every scan to the same physical region: the square on the sediment bed whose corners are marked by four AprilTags. Because the tags are fixed in the world, this region is the same in every scan regardless of how the camera was rotated or tilted. This gives fusion a consistent, well-overlapping input. The step is implemented in crop_pointclouds.py, which processes an entire session at once. It crops automatically wherever it can and falls back to a manual crop when it cannot.

5.1.1 Finding the tags in each scan

AprilTag detection is performed during capture on the colour image, and every detection is written to a csv file together with the frame number, the tag ID and the pixel coordinates of the tag's centre and four corners. Squares that look like tags but whose ID could not be decoded are also logged, with an ID of -1.

The point cloud of a scan comes from one particular frame of the recording. The cropper reads that frame number from the scan's IMU file, which was written at the same moment as the point cloud. It then collects the detections from that frame, however tag detections are accepted from ± 15 frames around the best frame, since each scan is taken from a static position. This allows for some redundancy against frames where detections momentarily failed. Decoded tags are always preferred, for region identification, however undecoded squares are used to fill corners where no identified tags are visible, and only when they lie close to where the missing tag is expected.

5.1.2 Learning the tag layout of a session

Not every tag will be detected, or visible in each scan within a session. Glare, shadow or a steep tilt often hide tags. Therefore, in order to maintain the ability to automatically crop each scan to the correct region, the program first learns the layout of the tags from the scans in the session where all four were detected. From those frames it records the order in which the four tag IDs go around the square, which says which tags share a side and which are diagonal, the ratio of the square's side length to a tag's side length and the aspect ratio of the square, i.e. how each side compares to its neighbours.

The median of each quantity over all four-tag frames is used, which makes the layout robust to a few poor detections. With this layout, missing corners can be predicted from the tags that were seen. With three tags, the fourth is placed to complete a parallelogram, $\mathbf{p}_4 = \mathbf{p}_1 + \mathbf{p}_3 - \mathbf{p}_2$. With two tags on the same side, the square is completed by stepping perpendicular to that side by the learned aspect ratio. With two diagonal tags, the side vector is solved from the diagonal and the aspect ratio before stepping out in the same way.

The crop region is then defined by the inner corner of each tag, i.e. the corner nearest the centre of the square region of sediment. This places the crop boundary just inside the tags, so the tags themselves are removed along with everything outside them.

5.1.3 Relating 3D points to image pixels

The tag positions are known in the 2D colour image, but the crop has to be applied to 3D points. The two are linked through the camera model. During capture the depth image is aligned to the colour image before the point cloud is exported, so every 3D point originates from one integer pixel of the colour image sensor. The cropper

reads the colour camera intrinsics (focal lengths f_x,f_y, principal point (c_x, c_y) and distortion coefficients) directly from the scan's recording file and projects every 3D point back into the RGB image plane. A 3D point (X, Y, Z) in the camera frame maps to

$$u = f_x\, x_d + c_x, \qquad v = f_y\, y_d + c_y, \tag{5.1}$$

where (x_d, y_d) are the normalised coordinates $(X/Z,\ Y/Z)$ after lens distortion has been applied. The distortion is computed exactly as the RealSense SDK computes it. Using the SDK's form reprojects the cloud onto the pixel grid to within about 10^{-5} pixels.

This property also provides a self-check. If the intrinsics really belong to this cloud, every reprojected point should land almost exactly on an integer pixel. The cropper measures the root-mean-square distance of the reprojected points from the nearest integer pixel centre,

$$\rho = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N} \left\|\mathbf{u}_i - \mathrm{round}(\mathbf{u}_i)\right\|^2}, \tag{5.2}$$

and rejects the automatic crop if ρ exceeds 0.15 pixels. The same test is used to choose how the distortion coefficients should be applied, since the stored coefficients can describe either the forward or the inverse distortion. The interpretation with the smallest ρ is kept. This guards against silently cropping a scan with the wrong camera model, for example if a recording was captured with a different resolution.

5.1.4 Building the crop volume

The simplest crop would keep every point whose pixel falls inside the tag-bounded quadrilateral. This is equivalent to cutting the cloud with a pyramid whose apex is at the camera. The walls of that pyramid follow the camera's lines of sight, so a tilted scan would be cut along a different boundary on the sediment than an untilted scan, and the scans would no longer cover the same region.

Instead, the cropper builds a vertical prism through the tag corners, so that the crop boundary is the same physical line on the bed for every scan:

1. **Fit the bed surface.** A plane is fitted to the points in a narrow band (25 pixels) just inside the crop edge. The band is used rather the whole region so that the test object or sediment relief in the middle of the square does not influence the fit. The fit uses RANSAC: planes through three randomly chosen points are tried 500 times, and the plane with the most points within 5 mm of it is kept. RANSAC is used because it ignores outliers entirely instead of averaging them in, which matters near the edge of the crop where stray points from the rig may remain.

2. **Fit the tag plane.** A second RANSAC plane is fitted to the points lying on the tags themselves. The tags can sit slightly above the sediment, so the 3D corners of the crop region are placed where the pixel rays through the inner tag corners meet this plane. For a pixel ray with direction $\mathbf{r}$ and a plane with normal $\mathbf{n}$ and offset d, the intersection is
$$\mathbf{X} = \frac{-d}{\mathbf{n}\cdot\mathbf{r}}\,\mathbf{r}. \tag{5.3}$$

3. **Extrude along the surface normal.** All points are projected onto the bed plane, and a point is kept if its projection falls inside the four 3D corners. The result is a column whose walls are perpendicular to the bed and pass through the inner tag corners, independent of the camera's viewing angle.

If no bed plane can be found, the cropper falls back to the pyramid crop described above and notes this in its output. A crop that keeps fewer than 1000 points is treated as a failure.

5.1.5 Review and manual fallback

Unless run in batch mode, each automatic crop is shown in a preview window with the removed points dimmed and the crop boundary drawn as a wireframe. The user can accept it, keep the original cloud, or switch to a manual crop. The manual crop starts from points the user picks in the viewer and then lets the box be moved and resized with the keyboard. It is also used whenever the automatic crop fails, for example when fewer than two tags were detected. This keeps the user in the loop for the cases where automatic tag detection is least reliable.

5.1.6 Outputs

For each scan the cropper writes:

- **The cropped point cloud**, in the same coordinate frame as the input. It is written with 32-bit floating-point coordinates, because Open3D's default writer produces 64-bit coordinates that the PCL-based fusion program fails to read.
- **A tag sidecar file** giving the 3D positions of the four corners of every visible tag. Cropping removes the tags from the cloud, but fusion can use them for alignment (Section 5.2.3), so their positions are measured on the uncropped cloud before they are discarded. Each tag's pixel corners are taken as the median over every frame of the recording, which removes detector jitter. A plane is fitted by least squares to the depth points on the central 70% of the tag, this central region is selected to exclude the blending of the tag and bed surface. The 3D corners are the intersections of the corner pixel rays with that plane.
- **Copies of the IMU, detection and configuration files**, so that the cropped session has the same folder layout as a raw session and can be passed to fusion unchanged.

5.1.7 Limitations

The automatic crop assumes that the sediment near the edge of the square is roughly flat, so that the band plane represents the bed. If relief reaches the crop edge, the fitted plane, and therefore the prism, can tilt. The layout learned from four-tag frames is pooled across all poses, although perspective changes with tilt, so corners extrapolated from only two tags in a strongly tilted view may be slightly misplaced. The prism also has no height limit, so isolated noisy points directly above or below the square are kept.

5.2 Multi-Scan Fusion

Together is Almost Always Better

A single scan is noisy, has holes where relief hides the surface, and has errors that depend on the viewpoint. Combining registered scans addresses all three. Views from different directions see regions occluded in others, and the mean of n measurements with independent errors of standard deviation σ has a standard deviation of $\sigma / \sqrt{n}$. This however does not alleviate errors shared by all scans, such as a calibration or scale bias, all of which cannot be reduced through averaging.

Fusion is performed by a C++ program, `fuse_scans`. It runs as a sequence of stages: load and preprocess, estimate initial poses from the rig, coarse alignment, fine registration and reconciliation. The program can stop after coarse and after fine alignment to show every scan in an interactive viewer, colour-coded and listed with its alignment quality. From there the user can exclude a bad scan, nudge one into place by hand, or rerun a stage, before the session is fused. In batch processing these reviews are skipped.

The common frame is that of the first untilted scan, called the *reference*. The remaining scans are processed in order of increasing tilt, so that each new scan is as similar as possible to what has already been placed.

5.2.1 Preprocessing

Each cropped cloud is first thinned with a voxel grid of user defined size, default of 3 mm: space is divided into 3 mm cubes and all points in a cube are replaced by their centroid. This makes the density uniform, which most of the later algorithms assume, and it greatly reduces their cost. It also sets the finest detail the fused result can contain, so the voxel size is chosen close to the noise floor of the sensor. A statistical outlier filter then removes isolated points, defined as points whose mean distance to their 30 nearest neighbours is more than one standard deviation above the average.

Finally, a surface normal is estimated at every point from the principal axes of its neighbourhood within 15 mm. All normals are oriented to point towards the camera. This matters later as normals from several scans are averaged, and a normal and its opposite would cancel. The normals are computed once here and carried through every later transformation, because re-estimating them inside registration accounted for most of the program's run time.

5.2.2 Initial poses from the rig and IMU

Registration algorithms only converge when they start close to the right answer. The rig provides a natural starting point, because each scan's folder name records the commanded rotation and tilt. These commanded angles proved to be inaccurate, however. Commanded tilts of 15° produced measured tilts between 13.6° and 17.4°, and individual steps varied from 0.6 to 1.24 times the commanded step. In addition, because the rotating mount sits on top of the tilt stage, the tilt axis appears in a different direction in the camera frame for every rotation position, so a single fixed tilt axis cannot describe the rig.

The tilt is therefore *measured* rather than assumed. When the camera is stationary its accelerometer reads only gravity. The rotation that carries the gravity vector of a scan onto the gravity vector of the flattest scan at the same rotation position is exactly the tilt the mount applied, because the hinge axis is horizontal. Gravity readings with a magnitude outside 9.0–10.6 m/s^2 are rejected, since they indicate the camera was moving.

Two further quantities cannot be read from the IMU and are found by search:

- **The IMU-to-cloud axis convention.** The accelerometer and the exported point cloud use different axis conventions. Four candidate conventions (the identity and a 180° flip about each axis) are tried. For each, a few low-tilt scans are placed using the IMU tilt and compared with the reference scan. The convention with the best agreement is kept. On real data the correct convention gave residuals of 7–18 mm, against 42–76 mm for the wrong one.
- **The tilt pivot.** The IMU gives the angle of tilt but not the point the camera tilts about. The pivot is found by a coarse-to-fine grid search over a 0.12 m range, again scoring how well the placed scans agree with the reference. The convention and the pivot are searched together because an error in either can mask an error in the other.

The rotation direction poses a different problem. Since the rotation stage is performed manually, the capture code names each rotation as a positive 45 °increment, regardless of direction or order. IMU data cannot resolve this issue since the rotation axis is parallel to the gravity axis, and therefore can not be estimated using accelerometer data. The program therefore tries every combination of clockwise and anticlockwise steps, places one representative scan per rotation position accordingly, and keeps the combination under which the scans agree best. A joint search is used rather than deciding each step on its own, because a wrong early step makes all later steps fit worse, which only a joint search can detect. When AprilTag alignment is enabled, the tags measure the rotation angle of each rotation position directly, and the search is needed only for positions where no tags were seen.

5.2.3 Coarse alignment

The coarse stage places each scan to within a few millimetres of its final position. Scans are added one at a time, and each is aligned against a map built from every scan placed so far, rather than against only the previous scan. This reduces the accumulation of error along the sequence. Up to three candidate poses, or hypotheses, are generated for each scan:

1. **The rig seed**: the pose predicted by the measured tilt and inferred rotation of Section 5.2.2
2. **The AprilTag pose**, if tag alignment is enabled. Each tag contributes four 3D corners from the sidecar file, which are matched against the same tag corners already placed in the common frame. The best rigid transformation between the matched corners is found in closed form with the method of Umeyama [55], which uses a singular value decomposition of the corners' cross-covariance matrix. No scale term is estimated, because both point sets are already in metres. When gravity is available, a constrained version is used instead: the tilt is taken from the IMU and only the turn about the vertical axis and the translation are solved from the tags. The tags a scan sees often lie nearly in a line, so the tilt about that line would otherwise rest on depth noise across a single 80 mm tag, whereas the IMU measures tilt well. On one test session this reduced the disagreement between tag poses and the final registered poses from 1–2.5° to 0.2–0.6°.
3. **A feature-based pose**, computed only if the rig seed overlaps the map poorly. FPFH describe the local shape around every point. Points with similar descriptors in the scan and the map are paired, and a RANSAC variant repeatedly picks three pairs, rejects them early if the triangles they form have different shapes, and keeps the transformation that brings the most points into agreement. This method needs no initial guess, but it is unreliable on smooth, nearly flat sediment with few distinctive shapes, which is why it is only a fallback.

To choose between hypotheses, each is scored by comparing the transformed scan with the map. A sample of scan points is matched to the nearest map point. Points within 10 mm are counted as overlapping, and the score is the root-mean-square distance of the overlapping points divided by the fraction of points that overlap, and the lowest resulting value is chosen. Dividing by the overlap fraction prevents a hypothesis from scoring well by fitting a small sliver of the scan very tightly.

For nearly flat scenes such as the sediment bed, this nearest-neighbour score has a blind spot. If a scan is slid or spun within the plane of the bed, every point still has a nearby neighbour on the flat map, so the score hardly changes. In that case the program instead compares heights. Both clouds are expressed in the frame of the bed plane, binned onto a 10 mm grid, and the score is computed from the differences in mean height between corresponding cells. A 5 mm in-plane slide raised this height-field score by 36%, but the nearest-neighbour score by only 16%. Whether a scene counts as flat is decided once from the reference scan.

The rig seed is accepted directly if at least 15% of the scan overlaps the map. Only if it fails is FPFH tried, and the better of the two is kept. A tag hypothesis competes with the result on the same score. If the tag pose and the geometric pose disagree by more than 10°, a warning is printed, because a disagreement that large means that one of them is wrong, not merely imprecise.

5.2.4 Fine registration

The fine stage refines each coarse pose with the ICP algorithm [8]. ICP alternates between pairing every scan point with its nearest map point and solving for the rigid transformation that minimises the distance between the pairs, until the pose stops changing. The point-to-plane form of ICP [12] is used, which minimises the distance of each scan point from the tangent plane at its paired map point rather than from the map point itself:

$$E(\mathbf{R}, \mathbf{t}) = \sum_{(i,j)} \left((\mathbf{R}\mathbf{p}_i + \mathbf{t} - \mathbf{q}_j) \cdot \mathbf{n}_j \right)^2, \tag{5.4}$$

where $\mathbf{p}_i$ is a scan point, $\mathbf{q}_j$ its paired map point, $\mathbf{n}_j$ the map normal, and $\mathbf{R}$, $\mathbf{t}$ the rotation and translation being solved for. Because of the voxel grid, a scan point and its true counterpart on the map are generally not the same physical point, only points on the same surface. Point-to-plane ICP lets points slide along the surface instead of penalising this offset, so it converges faster and more accurately on continuous surfaces than point-to-point ICP. Each step is solved with the linear least-squares approximation of Low [32]. Pairs further apart than 20 mm are ignored, so a coarse pose must be within roughly this distance for ICP to recover it, and at most 60 iterations are run.

As in the coarse stage, each scan is registered against a map of all scans placed so far. The map is stored as a voxel grid in which each voxel keeps running sums of the positions and normals of every scan that falls into it. Every scan therefore carries equal weight in the map.

After the stage, a scan is flagged for review if ICP failed to converge, hit its iteration limit, or scored more than 1.4 times worse than the median scan of the session. The threshold is relative because what counts as a good score depends on the voxel size, the sensor noise and the relief of the surface. A scan whose refinement fails keeps its coarse pose, so that it remains visible in the review instead of silently disappearing.

5.2.5 Reconciling the overlapping scans

Once registered, the scans could simply be combined into one cloud and thinned with a voxel grid. This was the original approach, and it gives a poor result. The remaining registration error (a few millimetres) is larger than the output voxel, so where scans overlap, their surfaces land in neighbouring voxels and survive as two or three slightly offset sheets. A statistical outlier filter cannot remove a duplicate sheet, because the duplicate is just as dense as the real surface. The fusion step therefore reconciles the scans.

Weighting each measurement. Not all measurements are equally reliable, so each point i is given a weight

$$w_i = c_{s(i)} \cdot \max(0.05,\ |\hat{\mathbf{n}}_i \cdot \hat{\mathbf{v}}_i|) \cdot \min\left(1,\ \frac{r_0^2}{r_i^2}\right). \tag{5.5}$$

The first factor, $c_{s(i)}$, is the registration confidence of the scan the point came from, based on how much of the scan overlapped the map and how closely. The second factor is the cosine of the angle between the surface normal $\hat{\mathbf{n}}_i$ and the direction to the camera $\hat{\mathbf{v}}_i$. This factor is included as stereo depth error rises sharply when the surface is seen at a grazing angle, so such points are down-weighted. The third factor reflects the range r_i from the camera. This factor is included as the depth error of a stereo camera generally grows with the square of the range, so points beyond the reference range r_0 are down-weighted accordingly.

Grouping measurements into cells. For a nearly flat scene the points are expressed in the frame of the bed plane and binned into the user defined sized cells in the plane, each holding the heights of all points that fall into it. This *height-field* mode is chosen automatically when the scene is flat, which applies to the sediment bed. Scenes with strong relief use a volumetric mode instead, in which points are binned into 3D voxels and reconciled along the local surface normal.

Choosing one value per cell. Within each cell, the measurements are combined with a *trimmed weighted mean*. The samples are sorted by height, and the lowest and highest 25% of the total weight are discarded before the weighted mean of the remainder is taken. A plain weighted mean would let a single misregistered scan

drag the surface towards it, while a weighted median discards most of the information. The trimmed mean lies between the two. Trimming by weight rather than by count means that a single high-confidence measurement cannot be outvoted by several poor ones. On a synthetic test with one of four scans misregistered by 8 mm, the error of the fused surface was 2.00 mm with a plain weighted mean and 0.35 mm with the trimmed mean. Overall, reconciliation halved the error of the original merge-and-thin approach, from 0.96 mm to 0.45 mm RMS.

Removing off-surface outliers. Points that still lie off the surface are then removed. For each point a plane is fitted to its 31 nearest neighbours, and the point is discarded if its distance from that plane is more than three standard deviations above the average. This replaced the statistical outlier filter used earlier, which judges points by local density. That filter removed genuine but sparsely sampled parts of the surface and punched holes in the fused result, whereas the plane test only removes points that are actually off the surface.

Smoothing. Finally, the surface is smoothed with MLS [5, 31]. Around each point, MLS fits a quadratic surface to the neighbours within 10 mm and moves the point onto it, which also yields a clean normal. Because the fitting radius is larger than the residual misregistration, this removes the last traces of offset sheets and sensor noise along the surface normal while keeping features larger than the radius. It is, however, a low-pass filter and so relief with a wavelength comparable to or smaller than the 10 mm radius is attenuated. This must be kept in mind when interpreting the small-scale roughness parameters of section 5.3.

The result is a single point cloud per session, in the frame of the reference scan, with one point per occupied cell and a normal at every point. The program also reports the thickness of the overlapping surface, i.e. the spread of heights within a cell, before and after reconciliation.

5.2.6 Limitations

Registration is sequential: each scan is aligned against the scans before it, and no global optimisation revisits earlier poses afterwards, so an early error can propagate. The rig seed is accepted whenever it overlaps the map by 15% or more. On a flat bed even a pose with a wrong rotation can overlap that much, in which case only the tag hypothesis can correct it, so tag alignment should be enabled for sediment scans. The pivot of the rotation stage is not estimated, so an offset between the turntable axis and the camera must be absorbed by the tags or by ICP. The height-field mode assumes the surface has a single height at every point, so overhangs and vertical faces, such as the inside walls of a burrow, are averaged away.

5.3 Surface Roughness Estimation

It's Not Flat?

The roughness program, `roughness_scans.py`, takes a fused point cloud and describes the roughness of the surface it represents. It runs five steps: level the scan, crop it, remove large-scale trends, resample it onto a regular grid, and compute the metrics. Most of the metrics follow the areal surface-texture parameters of ISO 25178-2 [2], so that results can be compared with other surface-metrology studies. Internally all units are in metres with reported units being millimetres.

5.3.1 Levelling

The fused scan is in the frame of the reference camera, so the sediment bed is generally tilted relative to the coordinate axes. Roughness parameters measure heights relative to a mean surface, so the scan is first levelled. This involves rotating scan so that the mean plane of the bed is horizontal and height is measured along the

z axis. The mean plane is found by principal component analysis. The plane passes through the centroid of the points, and its normal is the direction in which the points vary least. To prevent large features from tilting the plane, the fit is repeated with sigma clipping, where points further than three times the spread estimate are dropped and the plane is refitted, this is then repeated up to five times. The spread is estimated with the median absolute deviation (MAD), scaled by 1.4826 so that it equals the standard deviation for normally distributed data. The reason for using MAD instead of normal standard deviation, is that MAD is less susceptible to the changes that result from discarded samples.

The levelled frame has its origin at the centroid, $+z$ along the plane normal pointing towards the camera, and x along the camera's original x axis projected onto the plane. Keeping the camera's horizontal direction means that the direction of ripples or other features reads the same in the results as in the images. The scan can then optionally be cropped to a region of interest or trimmed by a fixed margin around its border, where fused data are usually the sparsest.

5.3.2 Detrending

Although the surface has been levelled, there are still some sediment features forms that are not related to the roughness of said sediment. For example, a concave section of sediment, or residual tilt from the levelling stage. Removing these forms from the surface results in the isolated sediment texture surface, called the residual. For detrending, these non-textural forms are modelled as a 3D polynomial surface:

$$p(x, y) = \sum_{i+j \leq n} a_{ij} x^i y^j, \tag{5.6}$$

of degree n from 1 (planar) to 4 (quartic), and the residual $z - p(x, y)$ is kept as the roughness surface. The coordinates are scaled to the range $[-1, 1]$ before fitting so that the fit remains numerically stable at higher degrees, and the same sigma clipping as in levelling stops ripple crests, troughs or burrow mounds from dragging the trend.

The choice of degree is a trade-off. A low degree may leave some non-texture form in the residual and overestimate roughness. A high degree may capture more complex forms but can also remove features of interest. A polynomial of degree n can follow roughly $n/2$ wavelengths, so on a small patch it can remove relief that is part of the texture being measured. The program therefore computes the metrics for every degree requested, using the same levelling, crop and grid for each so that the results are directly comparable, and raises a warning if a higher-order fit removes much more height variance than the planar fit while the patch spans fewer than n dominant wavelengths.

5.3.3 Gridding

Most roughness parameters are defined on a regular grid of heights, so the residual surface is resampled onto a square grid. By default the cell size is twice the median spacing between neighbouring points, so that most cells contain several points. The height of a cell is the mean of its points. Averaging c points with independent noise of standard deviation σ reduces the noise to $\sigma / \sqrt{c}$, so the gridding also acts as a mild low-pass filter at the scale of one cell.

Some cells contain no points, therefore any small enclosed holes, no larger than two cells across, are filled by linear interpolation from the surrounding cells. Larger holes and gaps at the border are left empty and excluded from every metric, because interpolating across them would result in inaccurate metrics..

5.3.4 Height parameters

With z_k being the gridded heights relative to their mean and N being the number of valid cells, the height parameters are:

$$S_a = \frac{1}{N}\sum_k |z_k|, \qquad S_q = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N}\sum_k z_k^2}, \tag{5.7}$$

$$S_{sk} = \frac{1}{S_q^3}\frac{1}{N}\sum_k z_k^3, \qquad S_{ku} = \frac{1}{S_q^4}\frac{1}{N}\sum_k z_k^4, \tag{5.8}$$

together with the highest peak S_p, the deepest valley S_v and the total height $S_z = S_p + S_v$. S_a and S_q are the arithmetic and root-mean-square heights and are the most common single measures of roughness. The skewness S_{sk} indicates whether the surface is dominated by peaks ($S_{sk} > 0$) or by pits ($S_{sk} < 0$). A bed riddled with burrow openings would be expected to have negative skewness. The kurtosis S_{ku} indicates how sharp the features are, a surface with normally distributed heights has $S_{ku} = 3$, while isolated sharp peaks or pits raise it.

5.3.5 Rugosity and slope

Rugosity is the ratio of the true area of a surface to the area of its projection onto the horizontal plane. It is the areal equivalent of the chain-and-tape method used in benthic ecology, in which a chain is laid along the contours of the bed and its length compared with the straight-line distance. A perfectly flat surface has a rugosity of exactly 1, and any relief raises it.

To compute the true area, each square of four neighbouring grid cells is split along a diagonal into two triangles, and the area of each triangle is computed from the cross product of its edges. Summing over all squares whose corners are valid gives

$$\text{rugosity} = \frac{\sum A_{\text{triangles}}}{N_q\, g^2}, \tag{5.9}$$

where N_q is the number of valid squares and g the grid spacing. The ISO 25178 developed interfacial area ratio is the same quantity expressed as a percentage excess, $S_{dr} = (\text{rugosity} - 1) \times 100\%$. The root-mean-square slope of the surface, S_{dq}, is computed from the same squares.

Rugosity, S_{dr} and S_{dq} all depend strongly on the grid spacing. Measurement noise adds small random slopes to every cell, and the finer the grid, the steeper those slopes become, so these parameters grow as the grid is refined even if the surface is unchanged. Results computed with different grid spacings are therefore not comparable, and all scans in this work are processed with the same spacing of 2mm.

5.3.6 Spatial and spectral parameters

The height parameters describe how tall features are, but not how large or how far apart they are. Two further groups of parameters capture this.

Autocorrelation. The autocorrelation function measures how similar the surface is to a copy of itself shifted horizontally. It equals 1 at zero shift and decays as the shift grows. The autocorrelation length S_{al} is the shortest shift at which it falls below 0.2, and gives the typical horizontal size of the features. The texture aspect ratio S_{tr} is the ratio of the shortest to the longest such distance over all directions: it is close to 1 for a surface that looks the same in every direction, such as a randomly burrowed bed, and close to 0 for a strongly directional one, such as a rippled bed. The autocorrelation is computed with the fast Fourier transform, counting only pairs of valid cells.

Power spectrum. power spectral density (PSD) breaks the surface down into sinusoidal components and shows how much height variance each wavelength contributes. A Hann window is applied before the transform to reduce artefacts from the edges of the patch. The strongest peak of the PSD gives the dominant wavelength and direction of any regular pattern, such as ripples, and the texture direction S_{td} is reported as the direction of the crests. Many natural surfaces are *self-affine*: their PSD follows a power law $C(q) \propto q^{-2(1+H)}$ in wavenumber q over a wide range of scales [39]. Fitting a straight line to the log-log PSD gives the Hurst exponent H, which describes how roughness changes with scale, and the fractal dimension $D_f = 3 - H$. The fit is restricted to wavelengths between four grid cells, below which gridding distorts the spectrum, and a quarter of the patch width, above which there are too few repetitions to estimate the power reliably.

5.3.7 Additional measures and uncertainty

Several further outputs support the interpretation of the main parameters:

- **Multi-scale roughness.** S_q and rugosity are computed in square windows of increasing size, each with its own plane removed, to show how roughness depends on the scale of observation.
- **Confidence intervals.** 95% confidence intervals for S_q, S_{dr} and S_{al} are estimated with a block bootstrap: the surface is divided into square windows, which are resampled with replacement 1000 times. Neighbouring windows are correlated, so these intervals are likely to be somewhat optimistic.
- **Terrain ruggedness.** The Terrain Ruggedness Index [42] and the Vector Ruggedness Measure [47], widely used for seabed and landscape habitat analysis, are included for comparison with the ecological literature.
- **Noise correction.** Given an estimate of the sensor noise,either as a per-point standard deviation or from a scan of a flat plate processed in the same way, the noise contribution is subtracted from S_q and S_{dq}, assuming the noise adds independently to the true surface. A warning is raised if noise accounts for more than half of the measured slope, since rugosity then mainly measures noise.

All random choices use a fixed seed, so repeated runs give identical results, and every run records the hash of the code and of the input scan.

5.3.8 Validation

The program was checked in two ways. A test suite generates synthetic surfaces with known answers, such as sinusoids, for which S_q, S_a, the wavelength and even the exact rugosity follow in closed form, and random fractal surfaces with a prescribed Hurst exponent. Each metric is confirmed to recover the expected value, including when trends, noise, holes and a tilted camera are added. Secondly, a scan of a test object can be compared directly with its analytic definition: the reference surface is sampled, passed through exactly the same levelling, detrending and gridding, and the two sets of metrics are compared. This measures the error of the complete capture, fusion and roughness chain, and is used in chapter 7.

5.3.9 Limitations

The parameters follow ISO 25178-2 definitions but are not fully ISO-conformant. The standard defines them on a surface that has been band-limited with Gaussian filters, whereas here the band is set implicitly by the grid cell, the MLS smoothing in fusion, the polynomial degree and the size of the patch. The values are therefore directly comparable between scans processed in this pipeline with the same settings, but should be compared with values from commercial surface-metrology software with care.

Chapter 6

Intel RealSense Characterisation

The accuracy of extracted depth metrics is limited by the depth data they are computed from, so the Intel RealSense D456 was characterised before the capture and processing pipeline was finalised. The characterisation answers four practical questions about how the camera and rig should be operated in situ.

The characterisation was performed in two stages. In the first stage the camera was tested against flat planar targets. A plane has an exact, easily measured ground truth, which allows the effect of working distance, tilt angle and ambient light to be isolated from the effect of surface shape. These tests give a baseline for sensor noise and provide the operating envelope used in the second stage. In the second stage the camera was tested against 3D-printed reference objects with known geometry (subsection 4.5.1) These tests identify the camera configuration, post-processing filter settings and combination of viewing directions that give the best reconstruction, using surface relief that is representative of the sediment of interest. Each characterisation below is presented with its method, results and a short discussion.

6.1 Plane Surface Characterisation

As Plain As That

6.1.1 Capture procedure and metrics

All planar characterisation used custom C++ software built on the Intel RealSense SDK, following the plane-fit metrics of Intel's Depth Quality Tool. Details of each trial, such as distance, tilt angle and a lux reading, are entered into the tool and the scan is started. A region of interest (ROI) is then applied whose pixel size is adjusted dynamically with distance so that it always covers a fixed 50×50 cm area of the target. A plane is fitted to the ROI points of every frame and compared with the ground-truth plane. Several metrics are reported by the tool, however there are four main metrics that will be discussed here to represent the general performance, each averaged over the valid frames of a trial.

- **Median depth error** (mm): the median signed difference between the measured and ground-truth depth, which measures systematic bias.
- **Depth RMSE** (mm): the root mean square representing depth noise from camera to plane.
- **Plane-fit RMS** (mm): the root-mean-square distance of the ROI points from the best-fit plane. This measures spatial noise and is independent of any constant offset in the depth.
- **Valid Pixels** (%): the proportion of ROI pixels that returned a valid depth value.

The distinction between precision and bias matters for this project. A smooth, systematic bias is removed when the fused surface is detrended to extract microtopography, whereas random noise adds directly to the measured

roughness. Plane-fit RMS and fill rate are therefore treated as the primary metric, with depth error and depth RMSE treated as secondary indicators. Each condition was recorded as a single trial. The frames within a trial capture temporal variation but not the repeatability of re-setting the experiment.

6.1.2 Planar Characterisation Methodology

Working distance

The camera was mounted on a tripod and pointed at a white, featureless wall, as recommended by Intel for depth-quality testing. This forces the camera to depend on its own projected infrared pattern. The tripod was used instead of the experimental rig because the rig's mounting brackets could not hold the camera sufficiently parallel to the floor. The camera angle varied with every scan and consistently exceeded 1.5°, which would have contaminated a distance sweep. The camera was positioned at eight distances between 604 mm and 903 mm, and the angle between the camera and the wall was minimised by hand at each position. The fitted-plane angle confirmed that the residual pitch and roll stayed below 0.5°in all trials. The ground-truth distance was measured between the wall and the cameras glass front using a tape measure.

Camera tilt

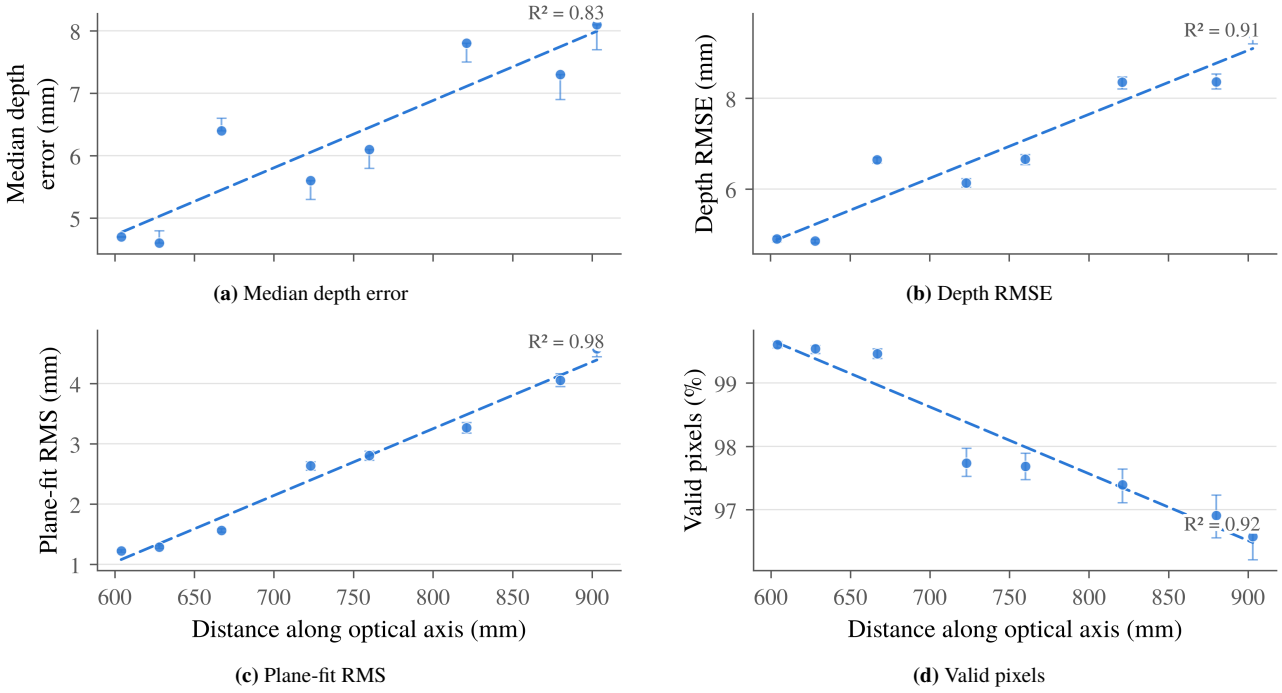
The camera was mounted on the experimental rig so that its angle could be set with the tilt servo. A large flat white foam board was placed on the floor and re-centred in the field of view (FOV) after each change of angle. Two rotations were tested independently. The pitch axis is parallel to the line through the two IR imagers, and the roll axis is perpendicular to both the pitch axis and the optical axis. The angle was changed in steps of approximately 2°, covering pitch angles from $-27°$ to $-2°$ and roll angles from $+3°$ to $+25°$ for 26 trials in total. The camera mount height was kept fixed. For each trial the vertical height of the left IR imager, which is the centre of the resulting depth image, above the board was measured, and the axial ground-truth distance was calculated from that height and the tilt angle. This axial distance varied between 657 mm and 743 mm over the sweep. The angle of the fitted plane agreed with the set angle to within 1° in every trial (mean 0.4°), which verifies the angle settings.

Ambient lighting

The same foam board was scanned at a camera height of 902 mm under a range of lighting conditions, with the camera exposure left on automatic. Indoor conditions ranged from a dark room in the evening (blinds closed, lights off) to an afternoon room with the blinds open and the lights on. Outdoor trials were performed around midday, in direct sun, shaded sun and completely shaded. The outdoor trials were taken twice per condition, one with the foam board, and one without the foam board. This was done as the effects of the high ambient light resulted in exposure settings that were unable to detect the cameras built in projected pattern, and thus the featureless white surface lost detection. The brick flooring was able to be detected in this condition, thus the results for the outdoor trials provide relational performance compare to the rest of the trials. Illuminance was read with a smartphone running the Physics Toolbox Suite application [3], which uses the front camera as a lux meter. Such readings are uncalibrated and are used here to indicate the order of magnitude and ranking of conditions, not precise values. The lux was recorded as 0 in the darkest condition and 24 400 in full sun.

6.1.3 Planar testing Results

Results for planar height, angle and lighting characterisation can be found in Figure 6.1, Figure 6.2 and Figure 6.3 respectively. For light characterisation environmental conditions with corresponding illumination values are shown in Table 6.1



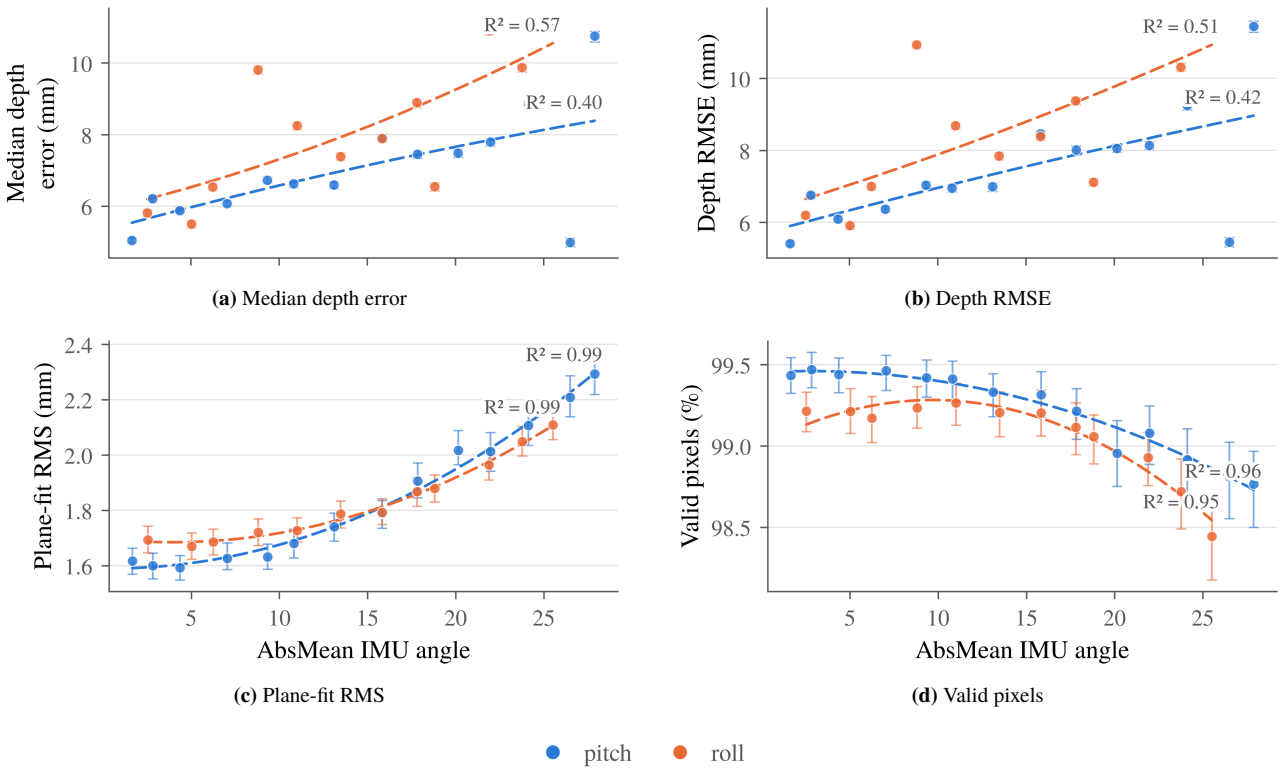
(a) Median depth error

(b) Depth RMSE

(c) Plane-fit RMS

(d) Valid pixels

Figure 6.1: Plots Showing Planar Reconstruction Quality Against Height. Per-trial Median with IQR Over n = 385–552 Frames. Plot Data in Table D.1



(a) Median depth error

(b) Depth RMSE

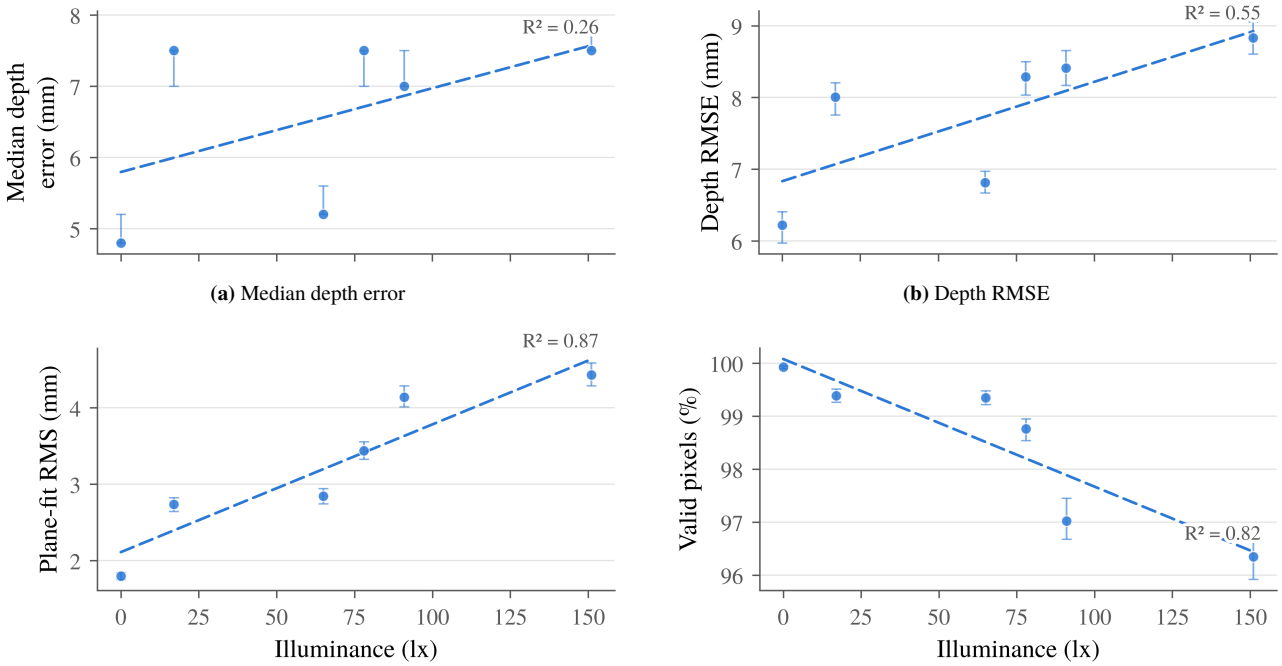
(c) Plane-fit RMS

(d) Valid pixels

Figure 6.2: Plots Showing Planar Reconstruction Quality Against Scan Angle. Per-trial Median with IQR Over n = 527–574 Frames. Plot Data in Table D.2

Table 6.1: Planar Characterisation Under Different Lighting Conditions at a Height of 902 mm. Lux Values are Indicative (Smartphone Sensor).

Surface	Condition	Lux
Indoor foam board	Evening, blinds closed, Florescent lights off	0
	Afternoon, blinds closed, Florescent lights off	17
	Evening, blinds closed, Florescent lights on	65
	Afternoon, blinds closed, Florescent lights on	78
	Afternoon, blinds open, Florescent lights off	91
	Afternoon, blinds open, Florescent lights on	151
Outdoor foam board	Shade	388
	Direct sun, under shade	2 650
	Direct sun	24 400



(a) Median depth error

(b) Depth RMSE

(c) Plane-fit RMS

(d) Valid pixels

Figure 6.3: Plots Showing Planar Reconstruction Quality Against Light Intensity, for Indoor Conditions with Foam Board. Per-trial Median with IQR Over n = 592–599 Frames. Plot Data in Table D.3

6.1.4 Discussion

Working Distance

Stereo theory predicts that depth noise grows with the square of the range, yet the data in Figure 6.1 follow closer to linear trend. Two factors likely contribute, firstly the ambient light was not constant as the trials were taken between 15:40 and 17:35, and the auto-exposure value fell from about 5300 for the three closest distances to between 1700 and 2050 for the rest. Second, the 604 to 903 mm range is narrow, so only a short, locally near-linear section of the quadratic curve is sampled. The practical trend is nonetheless clear. Plane-fit RMS (Figure 6.1c) increases with working distance while the proportion of valid pixels (Figure 6.1d) decreases, so the camera should be operated as close to the surface as the required field of view allows. Expressed as a percentage of distance, the median depth error rises only slightly, from 0.77% to 0.90%, with a weak fit (R^2 = 0.18). This approximately constant relative error is consistent with a fixed bias or scale error rather than a distance-dependent effect, and is removed by detrending.

Camera Tilt

Depth noise is expected to rise with tilt angle, as the surface is foreshortened and its depth varies across each matching window. A similar relationship is visible in the plane-fit RMS and valid pixels (Figure 6.2c and Figure 6.2d), which both degrade as the tilt increases, with the steepest change beyond about 15°. Although the trend should follow a sinusoidal shape, a quadratic trend wa fitted to avoid overfitting with higher-order polynomials. Despite this mismatch, the trends describe both metrics well ($R^2 \geq 0.95$). The median depth error and depth RMSE (Figure 6.2a and Figure 6.2b) show only weak trends, and neighbouring angles differ by up to 6 mm, which points to the repeatability of re-positioning the board and measuring its height as the dominant uncertainty in these metrics. Because the camera pivots at a fixed mount height, tilting it also increases the axial distance to the board, so these results combine the effects of angle and range, which does not isolate angle alone. This is accepted here, since the mount height is also fixed when scanning sediment, so the results reflect in situ conditions.

Ambient Lighting

Two conclusions follow. First, ambient light degrades active stereo depth even well within the sensor's range, because the projected infrared pattern must compete with ambient light for contrast. Daylight appears more damaging per lux than artificial light (Figure 6.3c and Figure 6.3d): 91 lx of daylight gave 4.14 mm RMS and 97.0% valid pixels, against 2.84 mm and 99.3% at 65 lx of fluorescent light. This is consistent with the greater near-infrared content of sunlight, so illuminance in lux is only a rough predictor of performance. Second, the surface matters as much as the illumination. The board failed completely at 2 650 lx in sun-exposed conditions, whereas the textured ground returned complete, low-noise data at 9 800 lx, so the failure cannot be attributed to light level alone. A bright, featureless white surface is a worst case for stereo matching, and the planar results should therefore be read as pessimistic bounds on the noise expected on naturally textured sediment. Wet or glossy sediment, which is more specular, was not tested outdoors and may behave worse. These results support keeping the shading tarp on the rig to limit the ambient infrared reaching the scan area.

6.2 3D Reference Characterisation

A Whole New Dimension

The planar tests establish the sensor's noise behaviour but not how accurately it reconstructs three-dimensional relief, which is affected by resolution, filtering, distance and the fusion of several views. These effects were measured against reference objects with known geometry using a modified version of the main capture program, which records scans under controlled software settings and hardware set-ups.

6.2.1 Testing Procedure

Camera configuration

The first sweep fixed the height and tilt of the camera and scanned the large egg carton and the pyramid with different stream configurations. The resolution ranged from 1280×720 to 640×360 pixels, the depth units from 1 mm to 0.1 mm, and all of the built-in visual presets were tested except the Hand preset, which is intended for gesture tracking. The depth unit sets the quantisation step of the 16-bit depth values, and the finest setting (0.1 mm) still provides a maximum range of 6.5 m, well beyond the working distance.

Post-processing filters

With the configuration fixed, five stationary scans of each object were recorded at each of the tested heights, without tilt or rotation. The data were recorded to files so that the RealSense post-processing filters could be applied offline in many combinations to the same scans. The filters investigated were decimation, spatial, temporal and hole-filling, and a sweep was made over their smoothing alpha, smoothing delta and magnitude parameters shown in Table 6.2. Decimation reduces the resolution, the spatial filter performs edge-preserving smoothing, the temporal filter averages depth across frames, and hole filling interpolates invalid pixels. Each combination was evaluated against the reference, and the process was repeated at each height to determine whether the best filter settings depend on the working distance.

Table 6.2: Filter parameter ranges tested (one factor at a time).

Filter	Parameter	Values	Default
Decimation	magnitude	2–6, 8	–
Spatial	magnitude	1–5	2
	α	0.25–1.0	0.5
	δ	1–50	20
	holes fill	0–5	0
Temporal	α	0.05–1.0	0.4
	δ	1–100	20
	persistence	0–8	3
Hole filling	mode	0, 1, 2	–

Tilt and rotation

Finally, a full scan of each object was recorded at rotations of $-45°$, $0°$, $45°$ and $90°$ and at tilts from $-25°$ to $+25°$ in steps of $5°$. This gives 44 views of each object. These views were aligned and fused by the pipeline in chapter 5. Subsets of the views were fused and each fusion was evaluated against the reference, which shows how the reconstruction accuracy depends on the number of views and on the combination of tilt and rotation.

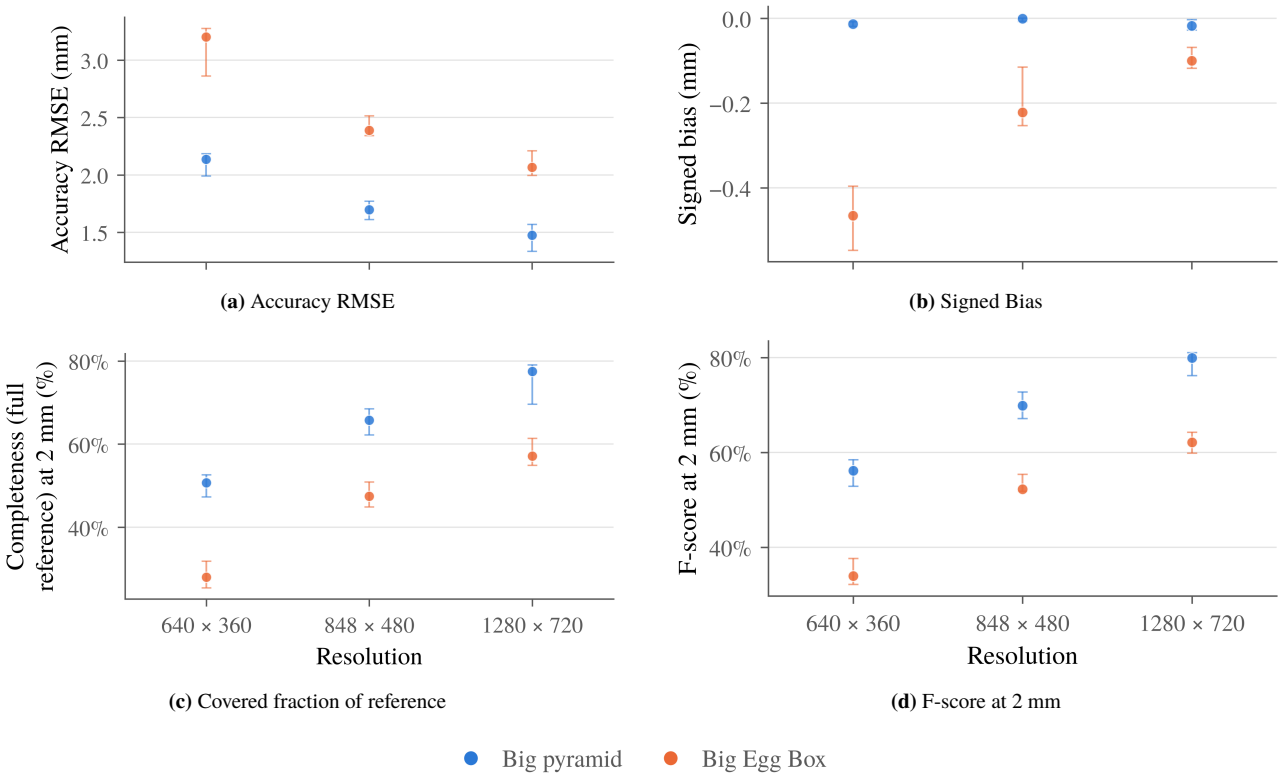
6.2.2 3D Characterisation Results

The camera configuration sweep covered three resolutions, three depth units and five presets on the large egg box and the pyramid. Figure 6.4, Figure 6.5 and Figure 6.6 each vary one of these settings, with every point being the median over all combinations of the other two (n = 15 scans). This isolates the effect of each setting while still reflecting its interaction with the others, section E.3 gives every combination individually.

The filter sweep evaluated 257 filter configurations on five static scans of each egg box at each of six heights. Plotting every parameter against every other is impractical, so Figure 6.7 compares three configurations at each height: the unfiltered baseline, the single configuration that performed best across both objects and all heights (best overall), and the configuration that performed best for that particular object and height. The best overall configuration is the one recommended for use, and the per-case optimum shows the most any filter setting could achieve. The settings of both are listed in Table 6.3, and the gap between these three series and the baseline therefore bounds the benefit of filtering. The effect of each individual filter parameter and combinations of is shown in section E.1.

For the tilt and rotation sweep, the 44 views of each object at each height were fused in many subsets. Figure 6.9 shows the two extremes: a single untilted scan and the fusion of all 44 views. Figure 6.10 then shows how accuracy varies between these extremes, giving the F-score for each combination of rotation set (rows) and tilt set (columns), taken as the median over both objects and all six heights. The corresponding completeness, bias and F-score heatmaps for each object are given in section E.2. Finally, Figure 6.11 and Figure 6.12 show the reconstructed mesh and the signed error map of the small egg box at 701 mm for a single scan and for the full

fusion.



(a) Accuracy RMSE

(b) Signed Bias

(c) Covered fraction of reference

(d) F-score at 2 mm

Figure 6.4: Plots Showing 3D Reconstruction Quality Against Camera Resolution. Median with IQR of n = 15 scans per point, Taken Over Three Depth Units, and Five Presets. Plot Data in Table D.4

A full comparison of all filter parameters is infeasible for the scope of this report. Thus only a comparison between a baseline evaluation, with no filters applied, and the best performing filters is shown in Figure 6.7, with the data shown in Table D.7. The filter settings can be found in Table 6.3

Table 6.3: Post-processing Filter Settings of the Best-performing Configuration for All objects Combined and for Each Object.

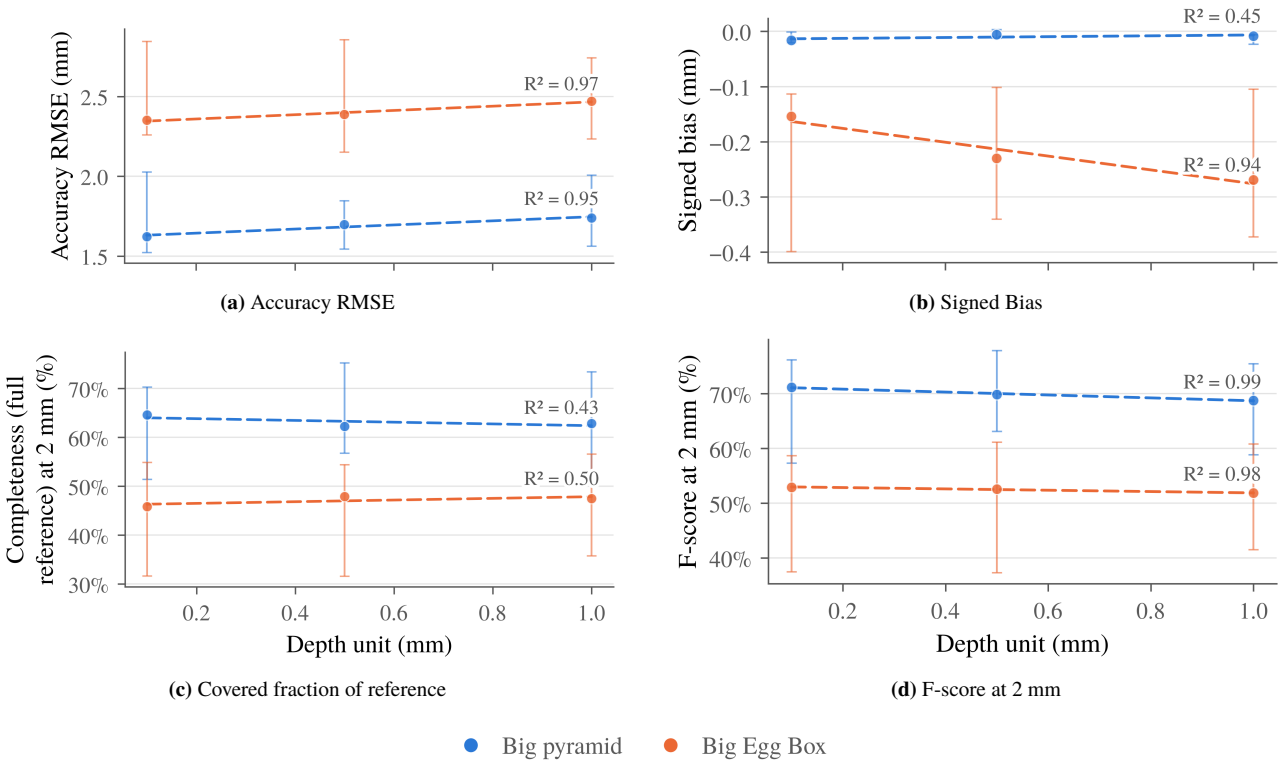
	Decimation	Temporal Filter			Hole Filling	
Object	Magnitude	α	δ	Persistence	Mode	Spatial Filter
All objects	Disabled	0.1	20	Disabled	Fill From Left	Disabled
Big Egg Box	2	0.1	20	Disabled	Fill From left	Disabled
Small Egg Box	Disabled	0.4	20	Valid in 2/8	Disabled	Disabled

6.2.3 Discussion

Camera Configuration

Resolution had the clearest effect of the stream settings (Figure 6.4). For the large egg box, increasing it from the default 848×480 to 1280×720 reduced the RMSE by 0.32 mm (13.4%) and raised completeness by 9.6 percentage points. This is expected, since depth precision scales with the focal length in pixels. Unexpectedly, the pyramid outperformed the large egg box at every resolution. Sharp edges are usually smoothed more than gentle curves, but the egg box packs more features into its footprint, so more of its surface lies near curvature the camera cannot resolve.

The depth unit had only a small effect (Figure 6.5), even on the inclined facets of the pyramid, which were



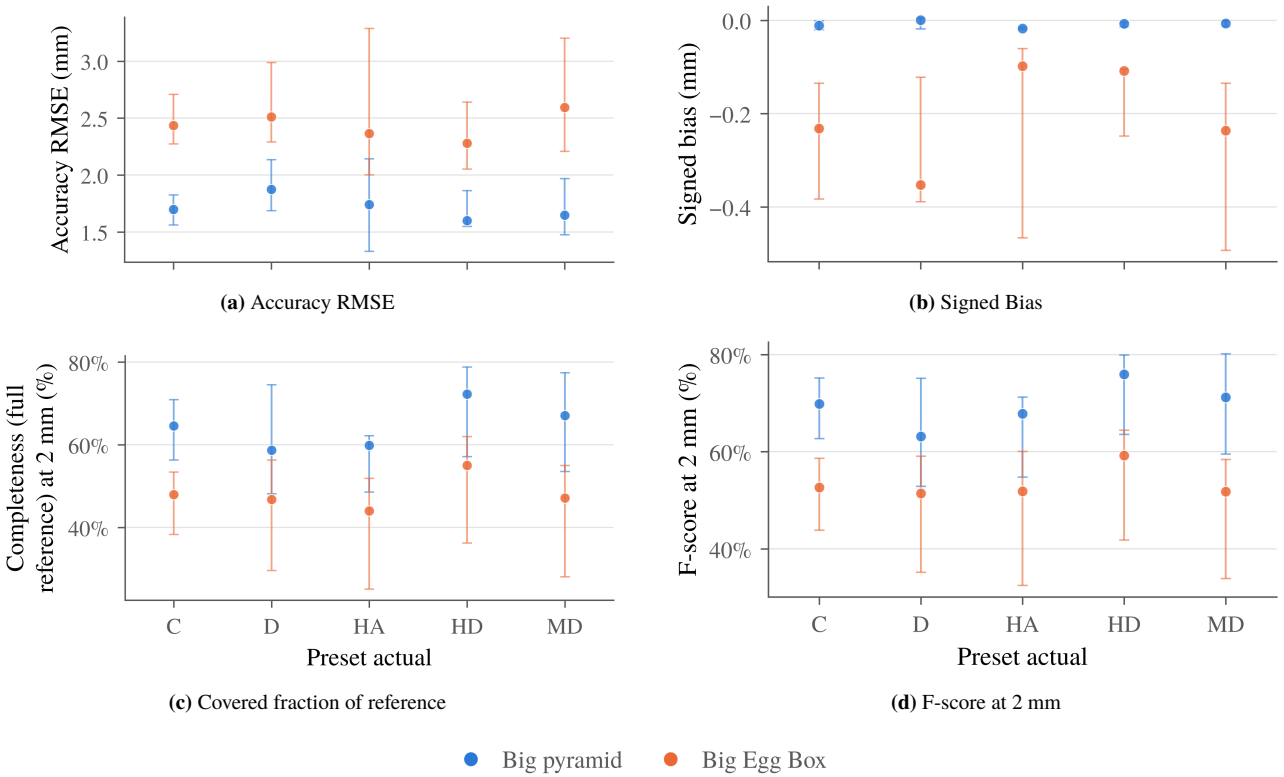
(a) Accuracy RMSE

(b) Signed Bias

(c) Covered fraction of reference

(d) F-score at 2 mm

Figure 6.5: Plots Showing 3D Reconstruction Quality Against Depth Units. Median with IQR of n = 15 scans per point, Taken Over Three Resolutions, and Five Presets. Plot Data in Table D.5



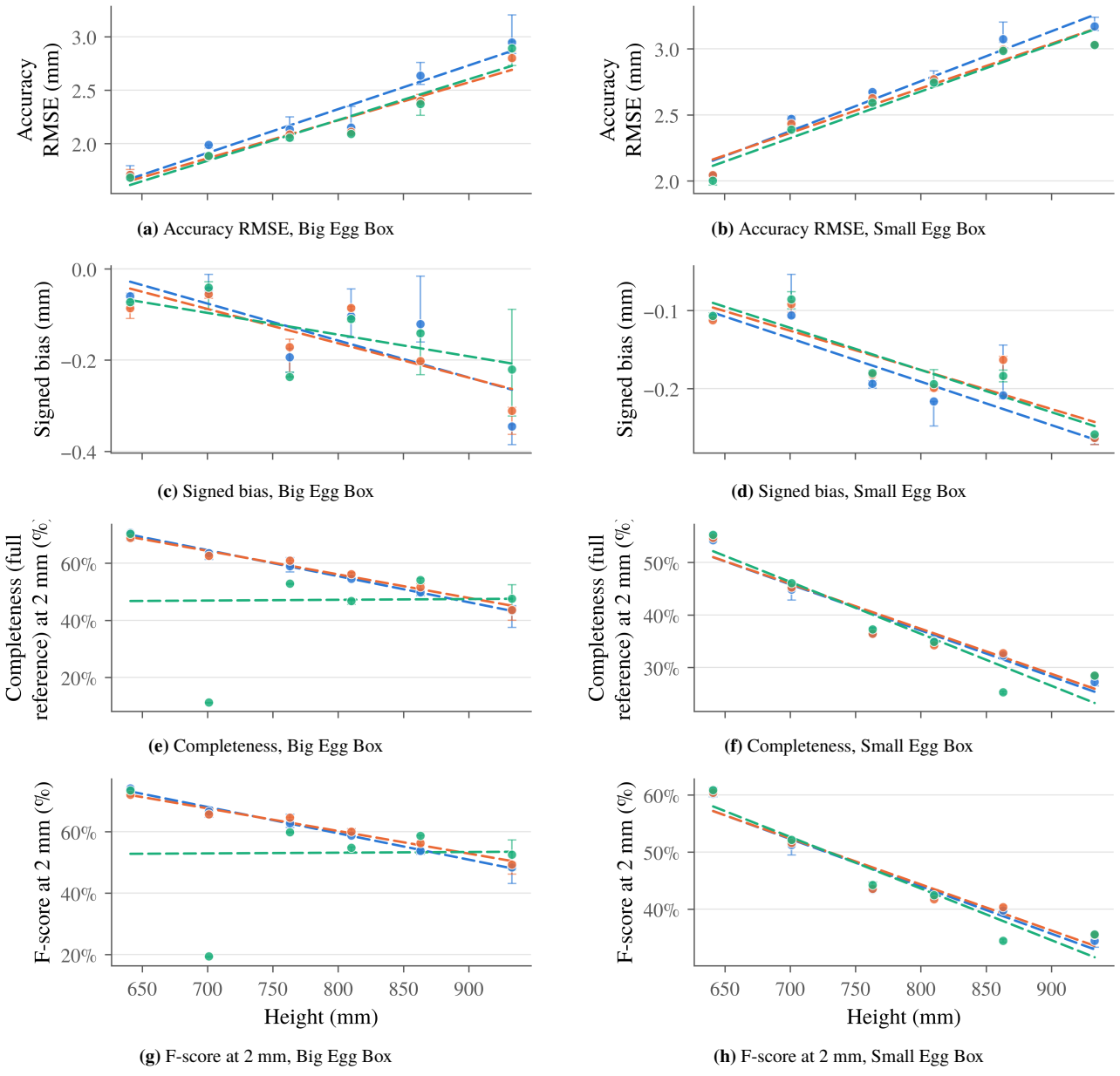
(a) Accuracy RMSE

(b) Signed Bias

(c) Covered fraction of reference

(d) F-score at 2 mm

Figure 6.6: Plots Showing 3D Reconstruction Quality Against Camera Preset. Median with IQR of n = 6 scans per point, Taken Over Three Depth Units, and Three Resolutions. C, D, HA, HD, MD stand for Custom, Default, High Accuracy, High Density and Medium Density Respectively. Plot Data in Table D.6



(a) Accuracy RMSE, Big Egg Box

(b) Accuracy RMSE, Small Egg Box

(c) Signed bias, Big Egg Box

(d) Signed bias, Small Egg Box

(e) Completeness, Big Egg Box

(f) Completeness, Small Egg Box

(g) F-score at 2 mm, Big Egg Box

(h) F-score at 2 mm, Small Egg Box

Figure 6.7: Plots Showing 3D Reconstruction Quality Comparison Between No Filter and Best Performing Filter, Best Fit (R^2 0.00 to 1.00). Median with IQR of n = 4–5 Scans Per Point. Plot Data in Table D.7

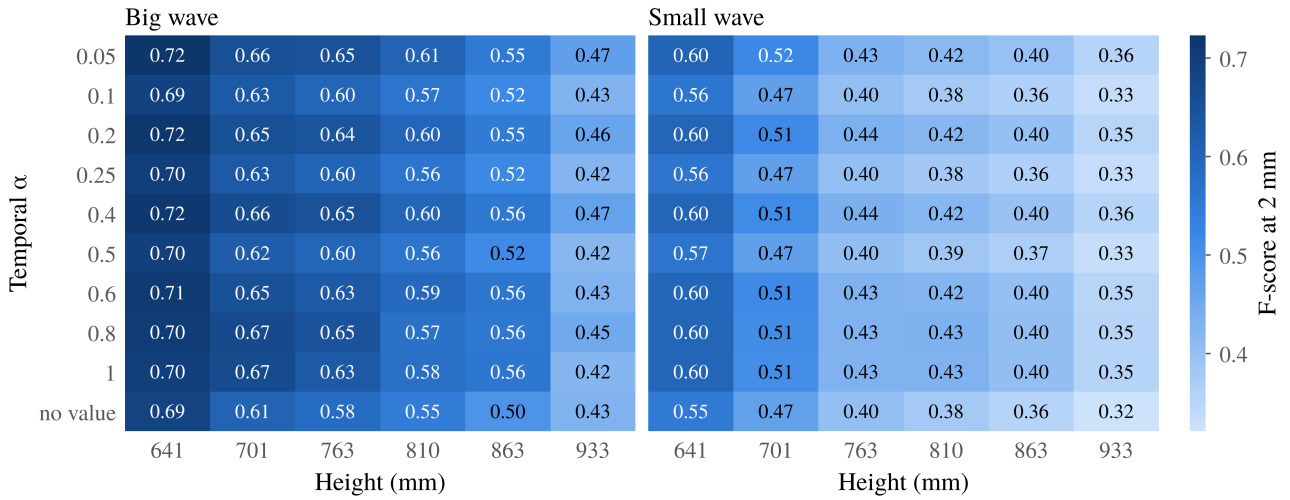


Figure 6.8: Heatmap Showing 3D Reconstruction Quality F-Score Across Different Temporal Alpha Values. Values Taken As Median Across Different Filter Combinations

expected to benefit most from finer quantisation. Accuracy is therefore limited by sensor noise rather than quantisation. The 0.1 mm unit performed best and costs nothing within the working range, although coarser units perform almost as well.

The High Density preset performed best on both objects (Figure 6.6), consistent with its aim of maximising valid pixels and so reducing holes. High Accuracy gave a low RMSE but poor completeness, and may perform better once fusion fills its holes (chapter 10).

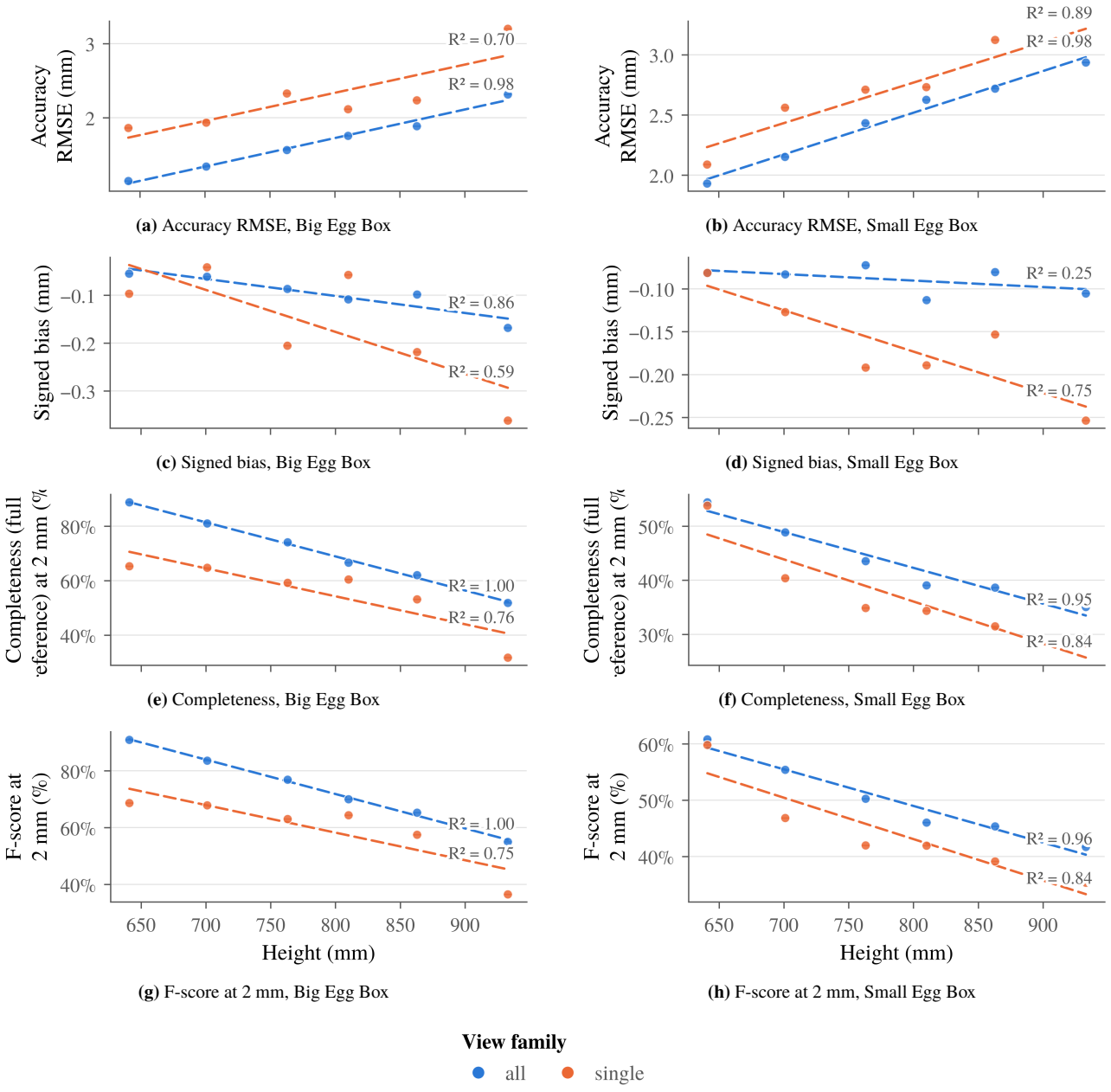
Filters

The post-processing filters gave only a small benefit (Figure 6.7; settings in Table 6.3). Stronger temporal smoothing generally improved reconstruction (Figure 6.8), while spatial filtering degraded it. Both effects are smaller than the effect of height: accuracy varies less across filter settings at one height than between heights. Since each scan is static, temporal averaging was expected to help more. A likely explanation is that the remaining error on a small object is dominated by spatially correlated error, which averaging over time cannot remove. Decimation cost little accuracy and could reduce processing time after capture. It is not recommended, however, because the loss of detail is likely to be larger on large-area scans with finer relief.

Tilt and Rotation

Multi-view fusion improved every metric at every height (Figure 6.9). Fusing all viewpoints raised the F-score by an average of 14.0 percentage points for the large egg box and 5.8 points for the small egg box, with no change to the hardware. The error maps (Figure 6.11b and Figure 6.12b) show that the largest errors, around ± 4 mm, remain after fusion. The noise, however, is substantially smoothed and the error is more uniformly distributed Figure E.12. For this project that matters more than absolute accuracy, because random noise adds directly to the measured slope, and so a single scan will report a rougher surface than a fused surface. This is visible on the flat floor around the object, which undulates in the single scan but is flat in the fused scan (Figure 6.11a and Figure 6.12a).

Figure 6.10 shows that the benefit comes mainly from the range of tilts rather than the number of views. Fusing tilts of only 0 and $\pm 25^\circ$ matched the full 44-view sweep, with an F-score of 0.73 against 0.73 on the large egg box and 0.50 against 0.48 on the small one. In contrast, the same number of views at 0 and $\pm 5^\circ$ reached only 0.65 and 0.44. Widely spread viewpoints therefore capture most of the benefit of fusion with lower capture time.



(a) Accuracy RMSE, Big Egg Box

(b) Accuracy RMSE, Small Egg Box

(c) Signed bias, Big Egg Box

(d) Signed bias, Small Egg Box

(e) Completeness, Big Egg Box

(f) Completeness, Small Egg Box

(g) F-score at 2 mm, Big Egg Box

(h) F-score at 2 mm, Small Egg Box

Figure 6.9: Plots Showing 3D Reconstruction Quality Between No Fusion and All View-Point Fusion. Median with IQR of One Point Clouds Per Point. Plot Data in Table D.8

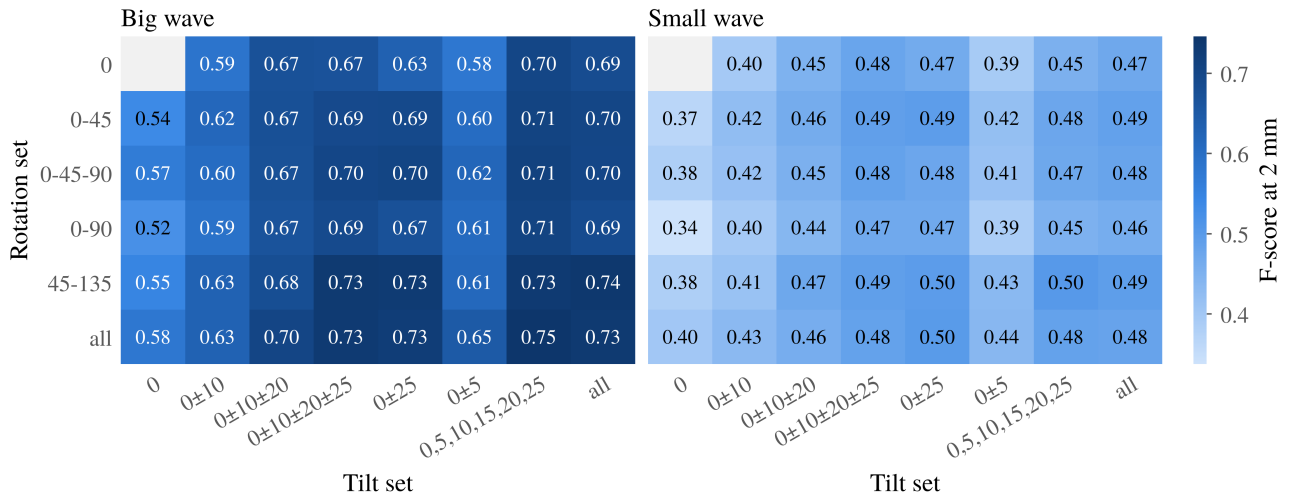
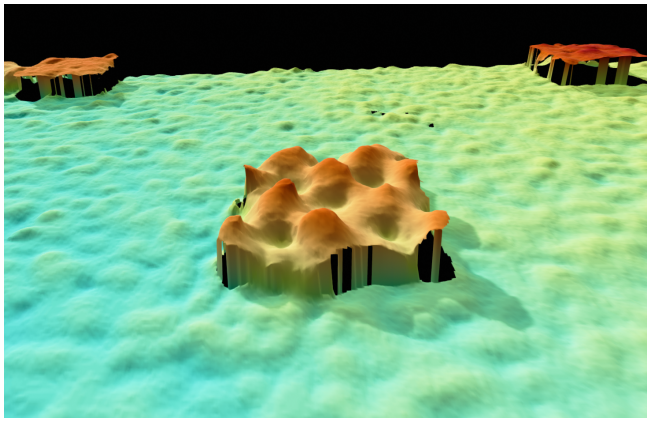
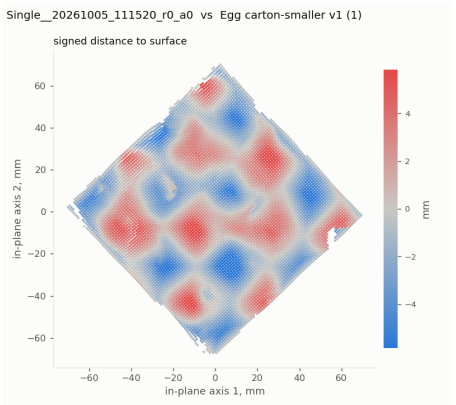


Figure 6.10: Heatmap Showing 3D Reconstruction Quality F-Score Across Different Tilt and Rotation Combinations. Fusion Cell = 0.0005, Scan Voxel = 0.0005. Values taken as Median

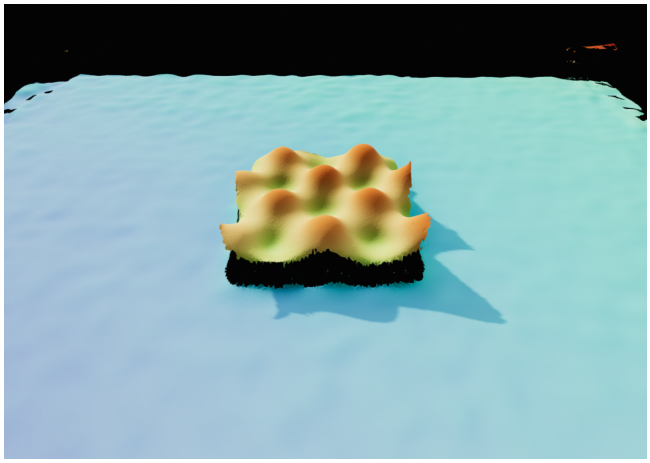


(a) 3D Mesh of Single Scan Viewed From Side

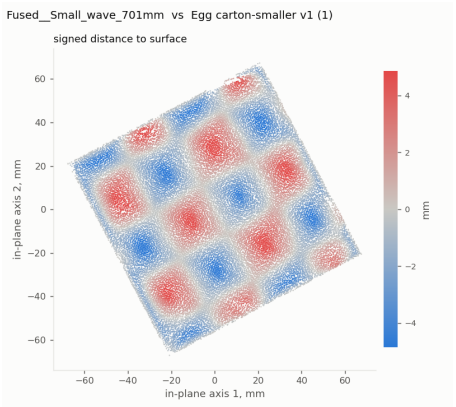


(b) Evaluation Showing Error Map of Single Scan Compared Against Reference Object

Figure 6.11: Visual Representation of Single Scan Performance Using Small Egg Box Surface



(a) 3D Mesh of Fused Scan Viewed From Side



(b) Evaluation Showing Error Map of Fused Scan Compared Against Reference Object

Figure 6.12: Visual Representation of Fused Scan Performance Using Small Egg Box Surface

Chapter 7

Experimental Validation

The complete pipeline, from capture through cropping and fusion to roughness estimation, was validated in two ways. First, it was applied to scans of the 3D-printed reference objects recorded during characterisation. These objects do not resemble sediment in situ, but their geometry is known exactly, so the measured rugosity can be compared against a true value.

Second, sand taken from the Langebaan Lagoon was placed in a plastic tub and scanned in dry, wet and water-logged states, both flattened and shaped. These surfaces have no exact ground truth, so the results are mainly qualitative, but they show how the pipeline behaves on the material and moisture conditions it is intended for.

7.1 Controlled Targets

7.1.1 Process

The roughness pipeline was applied to the two smooth reference objects, the large and small egg boxes (chapter C), using scans recorded at a height of 701 mm during characterisation. The best-performing filters identified in chapter 6 were applied, and each session was cropped and fused. The fused surface was then cropped to the footprint of the reference object, and rugosity was computed for both the fused surface and a single untilted scan, using each of the four detrending degrees (planar, quadratic, cubic and quartic). The reference surface was sampled from its .stl model and passed through the same levelling, detrending and gridding, so that the measured and reference values are directly comparable.

7.1.2 Results

The rugosity of each reconstruction and of its reference is given in Table 7.1 and Table 7.2, and plotted in Figure 7.1 and Figure 7.2. Two results stand out: the effect of the detrending degree, and the apparent advantage of single scans over fused scans.

Because the reference is detrended in the same way, its rugosity shows what each degree removes. For the large egg box it falls from 1.34 with planar and quadratic detrending to 1.27 with cubic and quartic detrending (Figure 7.1). Its relief spans about one wavelength across the patch, which a cubic or quartic surface can follow, so these fits remove part of the egg box shape itself (chapter F). The relief of the small egg box spans about two wavelengths, which none of the polynomials followed, so its reference rugosity is 1.69 at every degree (Figure 7.2). Planar detrending is therefore used below.

With planar detrending, the single scan of the large egg box measured 1.31 and the fused scan 1.25, against a reference of 1.34. On the small egg box they measured 1.31 and 1.26, against 1.69. This appears to contradict chapter 6, where fusion improved every accuracy metric, but the single scan is not more accurate. Instead, two separate errors partly cancel in it.

The first error is shared by every reconstruction. The reconstructions carry some scale error and under-represent the amplitude of the reference waveforms, so they report a lower rugosity than the true surface. Since rugosity scales approximately with the squared slope, a 10% loss of amplitude removes about 19% of the excess area. The fused reconstruction recovers about three quarters of the reference excess area on the large egg box, but under 40% on the small one, whose features approach the resolution of the camera and the 10 mm MLS radius.

The second error affects single scans only. Their higher depth noise adds spurious slope to every grid cell, which artificially increases the measured roughness. This is visible on the flat floor around the small egg box, which undulates in the single scan (Figure 6.11a) but is flat in the fused scan (Figure 6.12a). The single scan lands closer to the reference only because its noise offsets part of the lost amplitude, and the fused value remains the more faithful measurement of the surface.

Table 7.1: Fused and Single Scan Rugosity Measurements for Big Egg Box Surface.

Detrend Method	Scan	Rugosity mean	Ref rugosity mean
Cubic	Big Egg Box Fused	1.19	1.27
	Big Egg Box Single	1.26	1.26
Planar	Big Egg Box Fused	1.25	1.34
	Big Egg Box Single	1.31	1.34
Quadratic	Big Egg Box Fused	1.25	1.34
	Big Egg Box Single	1.31	1.34
Quartic	Big Egg Box Fused	1.19	1.27
	Big Egg Box Single	1.26	1.26

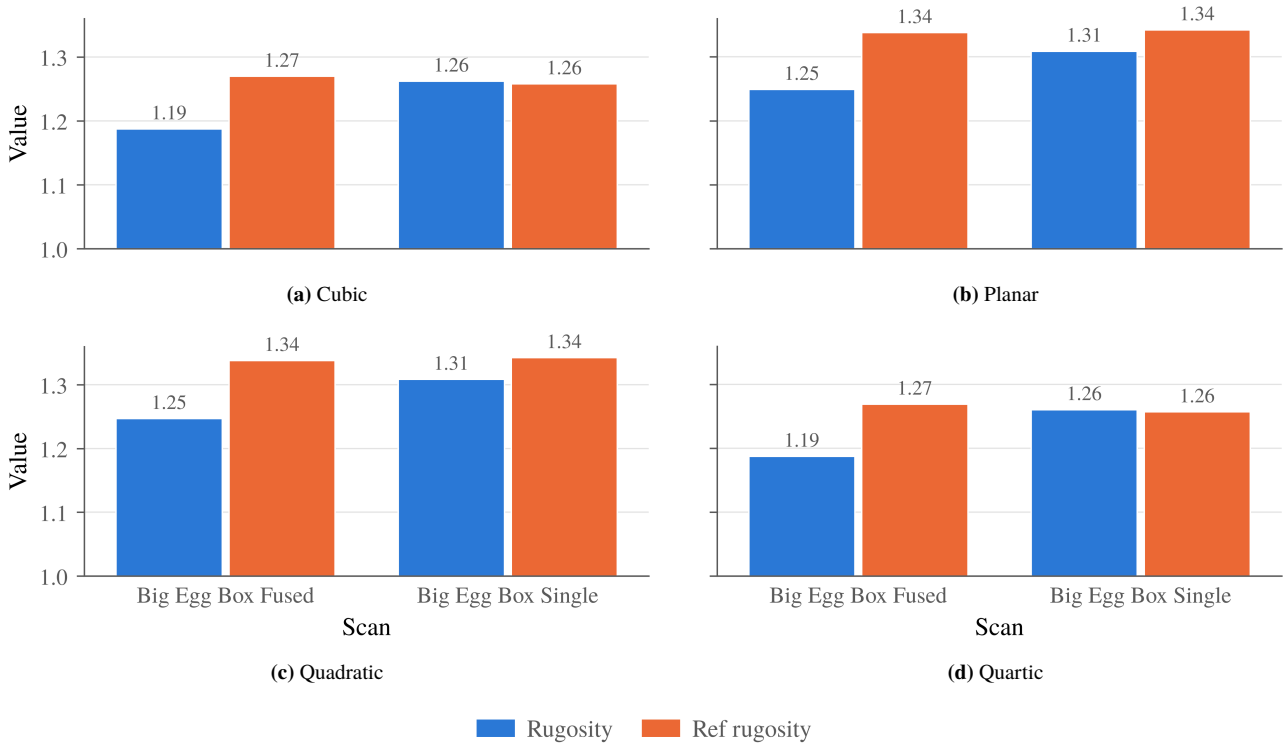
Table 7.2: Fused and Single Scan Rugosity Measurements for Small Egg Box Surface.

Detrend Method	Scan	Rugosity mean	Ref rugosity mean
cubic	Small Egg Box Fused	1.26	1.69
	Small Egg Box Single	1.31	1.69
planar	Small Egg Box Fused	1.26	1.69
	Small Egg Box Single	1.31	1.69
quadratic	Small Egg Box Fused	1.26	1.69
	Small Egg Box Single	1.31	1.69
quartic	Small Egg Box Fused	1.25	1.69
	Small Egg Box Single	1.31	1.69

7.2 Controlled Laboratory Sand

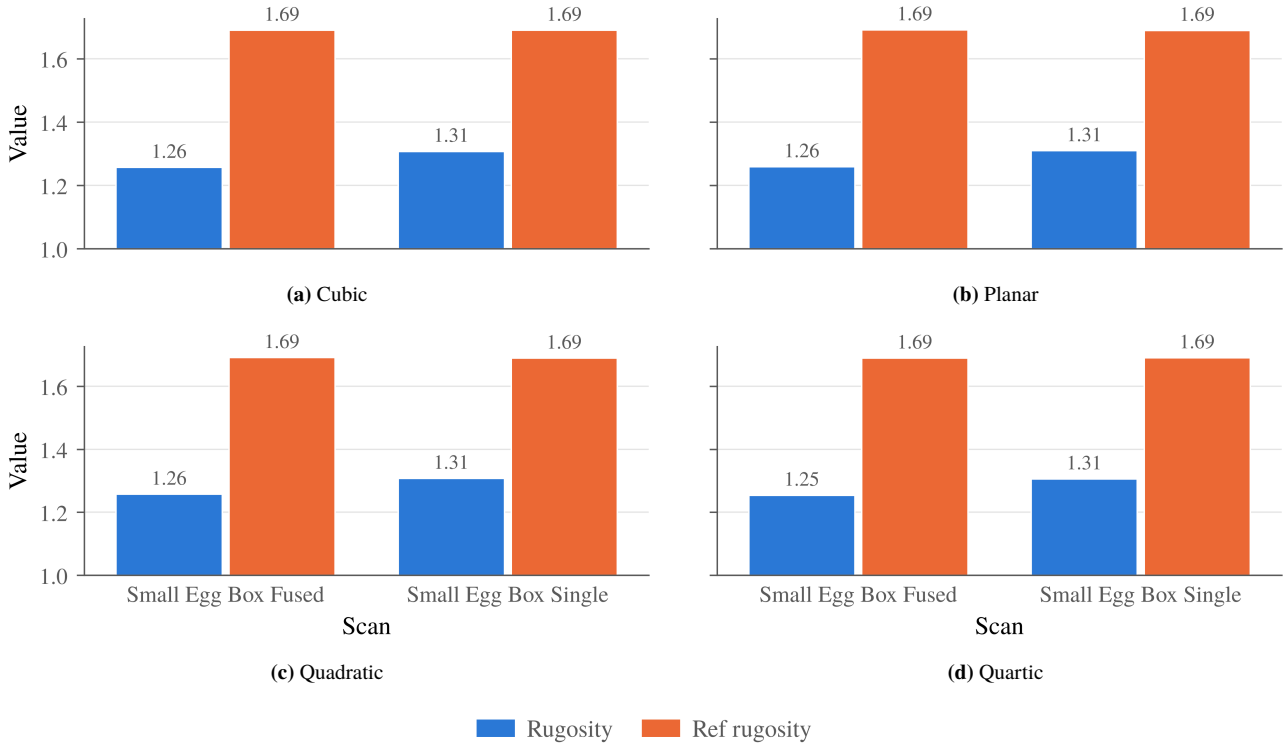
Bringing the Beach to the Lab

The reference objects allow an analytical comparison, but they are not sediment. Field deployment was not possible within the time available, so about 13 kg of dry sand from the Langebaan Lagoon was placed in a 10 L plastic tub, flattened by hand so that its rugosity should be close to 1, and scanned. It was then indented with the reference objects and scanned again. Next, 2 kg of water (about 15% of the dry mass) was added to approximate wet intertidal sediment, and the flattened and indented scans were repeated. Finally, more water was added until it pooled on the surface, and the sand was shaped by hand into an approximately natural texture and scanned once more. Each session was processed both as a fused reconstruction and as a single scan.



(a) Cubic **(b)** Planar **(c)** Quadratic **(d)** Quartic

Figure 7.1: Plots Showing Rugosity of the Large Egg Box Reconstructions Against the Reference, for Each Detrending Degree. One Point Cloud Per Bar, Captured at 701 mm. Plot Data in Table 7.1



(a) Cubic **(b)** Planar **(c)** Quadratic **(d)** Quartic

Figure 7.2: Plots Showing Rugosity of the Small Egg Box Reconstructions Against the Reference, for Each Detrending Degree. One Point Cloud Per Bar, Captured at 701 mm, Grid Fixed at $n_x = 45$. Plot Data in Table 7.2

Table 7.3: Fused and Single Scan Rugosity Measurements for Sand Sediment.

Label	Rugosity mean ± SD
Dry Flat	1.00340 ± 0.00021
Dry Flat Single	1.01933 ± 0.00018
Dry Shaped	1.05806 ± 0.00037
Dry Shaped Single	1.07912 ± 0.00036
Soaked	1.02659 ± 0.00104
Soaked Single	1.02922 ± 0.00077
Wet Flat	1.00931 ± 0.00013
Wet Flat Single	1.02429 ± 0.00014
Wet Shaped	1.05924 ± 0.00023
Wet Shaped Single	1.08549 ± 0.00011

7.2.1 Results

The rugosity of each surface is given in Table 7.3 and Figure 7.3, and the flat and soaked reconstructions are shown in Figure 7.4. These surfaces have no exact ground truth, but they behave as expected. Flattened surfaces measured close to 1, indented surfaces well above it, and the hand-shaped soaked surface between the two. The spread across the four detrending degrees was at most 0.001.

The flattened surfaces give the clearest result. With almost no relief whose amplitude could be lost, the noise effect dominates and the expected ordering appears. Dry flat sand measured 1.0034 fused, against 1.0193 as a single scan. Since a flattened surface cannot have a rugosity below 1, these values bound the contribution of noise, at under 0.34% excess area for a fused scan against up to 1.9% for a single scan. The single-scan noise is visible as a fine texture across the surface (Figure 7.4a) that fusion largely removes (Figure 7.4d). Wet flat sand followed the same pattern, at 1.0093 fused and 1.0243 single.

On the indented surfaces, single scans added 2.1 (dry) and 2.6 (wet) percentage points of excess area over the fused scans, slightly more than on flat sand, which is consistent with noise rising with obliquity (chapter 6). Against the 5.8 to 5.9% excess area of the fused scans, this is an error of a third to nearly half of the relief signal itself.

On the wet flat surface, a large region of high noise appears in the centre of the scan (Figure 7.4b,Figure 7.4e). It is attributed to specular reflection of the infrared projector from the water film, which returns the pattern directly into the imagers where the bed faces the camera, directly beneath it. The rig tilts and rotates the camera about an almost fixed position, so this point is the same in every view and fusion is not expected to remove it. This is consistent with the fused wet flat surface measuring almost three times the excess area of the dry flat surface (0.93% against 0.34%). Multi-view capture alone therefore does not prevent this artefact, and such reflections must be avoided on wet, flat sediment.

The soaked surface is the closest to waterlogged sediment in situ. Despite the pooled water, the fused reconstruction still follows the hand-shaped texture (Figure 7.4f), so the system remains usable on saturated sediment. Here, however, the single and fused scans differed by only 0.26 percentage points, either because the single scan was less noisy on this surface or because its errors over the pooled water were common to every view and so survived fusion.

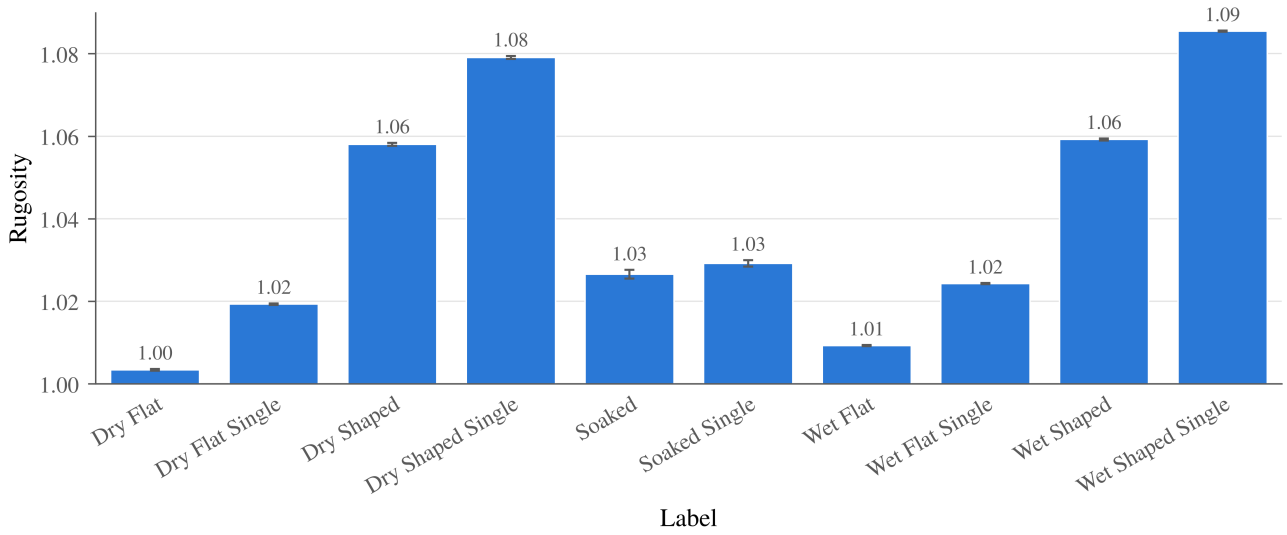
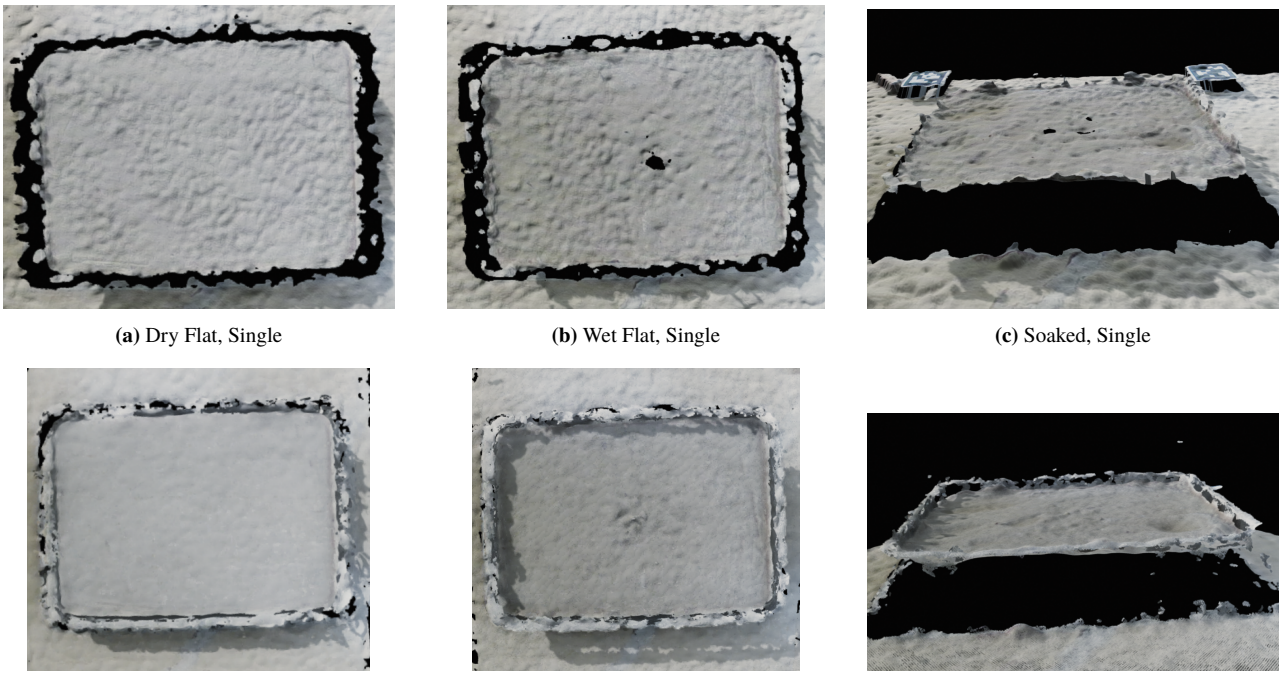


Figure 7.3: Plot Showing Rugosity of Fused and Single Scans of Laboratory Sand Under Dry, Wet and Soaked Conditions. Mean ± SD Over the Four Detrending Degrees (n = 4) Per Bar. Plot Data in Table 7.3



(a) Dry Flat, Single

(b) Wet Flat, Single

(c) Soaked, Single

(d) Dry Flat, Fused

(e) Wet Flat, Fused

(f) Soaked, Fused

Figure 7.4: Visual Representation of Single (Top) and Fused (Bottom) Reconstructions of Dry Flat, Wet Flat and Soaked Laboratory Sand. Reference Images In section F.2

Chapter 8

Discussion

This chapter summarises the key findings of chapter 6 and chapter 7, and relates them to the overarching project and the literature. Two findings recur throughout. First, reconstruction accuracy is set far more by geometry, meaning the working distance and the spread of viewpoints, than by the camera's software settings. Second, a single scan systematically overstates surface roughness, because its depth noise is measured as relief.

8.1 Camera Configuration

Of the stream settings, resolution had by far the largest effect (Figure 6.4). Moving from the default 848×480 to 1280×720 reduced the RMSE of the large egg box from 2.39 mm to 2.07 mm (13.4 %) and raised completeness at 2 mm from 47.5 % to 57.1 %. This follows from Equation 3.4, since the focal length in pixels scales with resolution. The cost is a larger minimum depth, $Z_{\min} = fB/126 \approx 0.52$ m at 1280×720 [4].

The High Density preset performed best overall, with an egg box F-score of 59.2 % against 51.4 % for Default (Figure 6.6). High Accuracy gave among the lowest RMSE values (1.52 to 1.67 mm) but much lower completeness, so its combination with fusion warrants testing (chapter 10). The depth unit changed RMSE by at most 0.12 mm (Figure 6.5), as expected, since even a 1 mm step adds only $1/\sqrt{12} \approx 0.29$ mm of quantisation noise, small against the 1.2 to 4.6 mm of sensor noise measured on planes. The 0.1 mm unit costs nothing within the working range and is still recommended.

Post-processing filters improved RMSE by at most 0.24 mm (Figure 6.7), whereas raising the camera from 641 mm to 933 mm worsened it by 1.13 to 1.24 mm. Strong spatial smoothing was harmful, because it flattens the relief being measured. Since filters can be applied offline, recording unfiltered data in the field keeps every option open and reduces the processing load on the capture computer.

8.2 Working Distance, Viewing Angle and Lighting

Working distance gave the most consistent trend in the report. Between 604 mm and 903 mm, the plane-fit RMS rose from 1.22 mm to 4.58 mm and the valid pixels fell from 99.6 % to 96.6 % (Figure 6.1). The fused large egg box fell from an F-score of 90.9 % at 641 mm to 55.0 % at 933 mm (Figure 6.9). This agrees with the stereo noise model of Keselman et al. [26] and with other depth cameras [33, 36], although over this narrow range the trend is near linear rather than quadratic.

Height therefore trades directly against coverage, since the footprint grows with the square of height: moving from 700 mm to 933 mm gives about 1.8 times the area. The camera also cannot be lowered freely. Its 95 mm baseline is designed for longer range [4, 45], and tilting brings part of the view closer than the mount height, with depth anomalies appearing at 687 mm and tilts of around 17°. A height of about 700 mm is therefore recommended for accuracy, and the maximum height where area is needed, with at least one patch scanned at both heights to quantify the difference.

Tilt degraded planar accuracy, with the plane-fit RMS rising from 1.62 mm to 2.29 mm at 28° pitch (Figure 6.2). On the 3D objects, by contrast, RMSE and completeness were generally best at the extreme tilts (Figure E.9 and Figure E.10). The two results are consistent. On a plane, tilt only increases obliquity, which raises noise [36], whereas on relief it turns some slopes towards the camera, so each view sees a different part of the surface well.

Ambient light raised the plane-fit RMS from 1.80 mm in darkness to 4.43 mm at 151 lx (Figure 6.3), with daylight more damaging per lux than artificial light. The featureless board failed in sunlight, whereas textured ground returned complete data at 9 800 lx. This is the expected behaviour of active stereo, which degrades towards passive stereo on textured surfaces [26]. It agrees with outdoor tests of the D435 [57] and extends the indoor-only evaluation of [21]. Specular noise on wet flat sand (section 5.3) shows that water films remain a risk, so the shading tarp should be kept.

8.3 Fusion and Roughness Estimation

Fusing all views improved every metric at every height (Figure 6.9). For the large egg box, RMSE fell by 0.61 mm on average and the F-score rose by 14.0 percentage points. For the small egg box, the gains were 0.25 mm and 5.8 points, limited because its 25 mm features approach the camera's resolution and the 10 mm MLS radius. This extends the established benefits of fusion [13, 35] to close-range sediment-like relief, one of the gaps identified in section 2.6. The spread of viewpoints mattered more than their number. Four rotations at 0° and ±25° (12 scans) matched the F-score of 0.73 of the full 44-view sweep (Figure 6.10), which makes multi-view capture feasible within a low-tide window.

On the reference objects, single scans gave rugosity closer to the reference than fused scans. With planar detrending, the large egg box gave 1.31 single and 1.25 fused, against 1.34 for the reference (Table 7.1). This is misleading. Every reconstruction under-represents relief amplitude, as the negative signed bias shows, and because rugosity scales with the squared slope ($S_{dr} \approx 50\, S_{dq}^2$ %), the loss is amplified, most strongly on the steep small egg box (1.26 against 1.69). The single scan scores higher only because its noise adds slope variance that partly offsets the lost amplitude.

The laboratory sand confirms this. Flat dry sand, which should have a rugosity of 1, gave 1.0034 fused and 1.0193 single (Table 7.3). On shaped sand, single scans added 2.1 to 2.6 percentage points of excess area, roughly a third of the excess area the fused scans measured. The ± values reflect processing options rather than repeat captures, so repeatability remains unknown. Planar and quadratic detrending preserved the reference relief, whereas higher orders removed part of it, in agreement with Azhar et al. [7]. As Jacobs et al. [24] caution, rugosity is only comparable between scans with the same height, grid spacing, smoothing, detrending and views, and should be referenced to a flat-surface noise floor.

8.4 Implications for the Overarching Project

Microtopography has explained a substantial share of benthic fluxes and biodiversity [49, 50]. It is only a useful proxy, however, if measured differences come from the sediment rather than the instrument. This project shows that single scans, or changes in height or processing between surveys, introduce instrument differences of the same order as the surface signal.

Fused scans captured with a fixed protocol make these effects small and consistent. That protocol is 1280×720 resolution, the High Density preset, a height of about 700 mm, four rotations at 0° and ±25°, and fixed processing settings. The large egg box, the closest analogue to the 3 to 5 cm high mounds of thalassinidean shrimps [41], was reconstructed best, with a fused F-score of 90.9 %. Finer features such as burrow openings remain near the system's limit. The main limitations are single trials per condition, uncalibrated light readings and the absence of field testing.

Chapter 9

Conclusions

This project set out to improve the system used to scan intertidal sediment for the wider study of sandprawn bioturbation on the Langebaan Lagoon. Bioturbators such as *K. kraussi* reshape the sediment surface with mounds, depressions and burrow openings. Sediment microtopography, and rugosity in particular, has been shown to explain a substantial share of the variability in benthic fluxes and biodiversity [49, 50], which makes it a promising non-destructive proxy for prawn activity. That proxy is only useful if the measured roughness reflects the sediment rather than the instrument. The inherited system adapted the RGB-D framework of Azhar et al. [7] to an Intel RealSense D456 active stereo camera. However, its configuration had never been thoroughly evaluated against known relief, and its repeated multi-view scans were each analysed on their own. This project addressed both problems. It characterised the D456 for close-range scanning of sediment-like surfaces, and it developed a cropping, fusion and roughness estimation pipeline that was validated on reference objects and on sand from the lagoon.

Characterisation of the D456

The first two objectives were met through planar tests and through scans of 3D-printed reference objects of known geometry. Across both, the results show that reconstruction accuracy is governed far more by geometry than by software settings.

Working distance had the most consistent effect. Between 604 and 903 mm, the planar fit RMS rose from 1.22 to 4.58 mm and the fraction of valid pixels fell from 99.6 to 96.6%. On the large egg box, the F-score at 2 mm of the fused reconstruction fell from 90.9% at 641 mm to 55.0% at 933 mm. Over this range the degradation was close to linear rather than the quadratic trend predicted by stereo theory, most likely because the range tested was narrow. Of the stream settings, resolution mattered most. Increasing it from the default 848×480 to 1280×720 reduced the RMSE of the large egg box by 13.4%, and raised completeness from 47.5 to 57.1%. The High Density preset gave the best overall F-score. The depth unit changed RMSE by at most 0.12 mm, and post-processing filters improved it by at most 0.24 mm. By comparison, raising the camera from 641 to 933 mm worsened RMSE by more than 1.1 mm. Filters therefore do not need to be applied during capture. Recording unfiltered data keeps every option open and lightens the load on the capture computer.

Tilt degraded planar scans, with the planar fit RMS rising from 1.62 to 2.29 mm at 28° of pitch. On the 3D reference objects, by contrast, single scans were often most accurate at the extreme tilts. Tilt increases obliquity on a plane, but on relief it turns some slopes towards the camera, so each tilted view sees part of the surface well. Ambient light also raised noise, from 1.80 mm in darkness to 4.43 mm at 151 lx indoors. Outdoors, the featureless white board failed completely in sunlight, while the textured ground still returned complete data at 9 800 lx. This shows that the D456 can operate in sunlight on textured surfaces, but it does not do so reliably. The shading tarp should therefore be kept, particularly since specular reflections from a water film produced a region of high noise on wet, flat sand.

Processing pipeline

The third objective was met with an automatic cropping tool and a multi-view fusion program. The cropping tool learns the layout of the four AprilTags from the scans of a session in which all four were seen. It then predicts missing corners from as few as two detected tags, and crops each scan with a vertical prism normal to the bed, so that every scan covers the same physical region regardless of tilt. It also records the 3D corners of each tag before removing them from the cloud. The fusion program combines these tag positions with IMU gravity readings for coarse alignment. On one test session, this reduced the disagreement with the final registered poses from 1–2.5° to 0.2–0.6°. The scans are then refined with point-to-plane ICP and reconciled with a confidence-weighted trimmed mean.

Fusing all views improved every metric at every height tested. For the large egg box, RMSE fell by an average of 0.61 mm and the F-score rose by 14.0 percentage points. For the small egg box, the gains were smaller (0.25 mm and 5.8 points), because its 25 mm features approach the resolution of the camera and the 10 mm smoothing radius of the fusion. Fused surfaces were also visibly smoother than single scans, with much less spurious undulation on the flat floor around the objects. The spread of viewpoints mattered more than their number. Four rotations at tilts of 0 and $\pm$25°, 12 scans in total, matched the F-score of 0.73 obtained from the full 44-view sweep. This makes multi-view capture practical within a low-tide window.

Roughness estimation and validation

The fourth objective was met with a roughness program that levels, detrends and grids the fused surface, and computes ISO 25178-2 areal parameters, including rugosity. On the reference objects, planar and quadratic detrending preserved the relief, while cubic and quartic fits removed part of the shape of the large egg box. At first glance, single scans gave rugosity closer to the reference than fused scans. For the large egg box with planar detrending, the single scan gave 1.31 and the fused scan 1.25, against a reference of 1.34. This result is misleading. Every reconstruction under-represents the amplitude of the relief, and because rugosity scales with the squared slope, this loss is amplified. The effect is strongest on the steeper small egg box, where the fused scan measured 1.26 against a reference of 1.69. The single scan scores higher only because its depth noise adds slope that partly offsets the lost amplitude.

The laboratory sand confirms this interpretation. Flat dry sand, which should have a rugosity of 1, measured 1.0034 when fused and 1.0193 as a single scan. On shaped sand, single scans added 2.1 to 2.6 percentage points of excess area, about a third of the excess area that the fused scans measured on the same surfaces. A single scan therefore overstates roughness by an amount comparable to the signal itself. The fused reconstruction also remained usable on soaked sand with standing water.

Implications and limitations

For the wider study, the main conclusion is that rugosity measured with this system is only comparable between surveys if the capture and processing protocol is fixed. The recommended protocol is 1280×720 resolution, the High Density preset, a working height of about 700 mm, four rotations at tilts of 0 and $\pm$25°, unfiltered capture with the shading tarp in place, and fixed fusion and roughness settings. The fused reconstruction of the large egg box, the closest analogue to the 3 to 5 cm mounds of thalassinidean shrimps, achieved an F-score of 90.9%. Finer features such as burrow openings remain near the limit of the system. The main limitations are that each condition was recorded only once, that lighting was measured with an uncalibrated smartphone sensor, that rugosity was not yet validated against a flat-surface noise floor, and that the system has not been tested in the field.

Chapter 10

Further work

The 12-week time frame limited how thoroughly parts of the system could be characterised and validated. This chapter identifies where the results are weakest and the work that would address them.

Luminance was read with an uncalibrated smartphone sensor, and lux does not describe spectral content. Daylight degraded the depth data more per lux than fluorescent light, which is consistent with its larger near-infrared component, so the indoor results do not fully represent conditions in situ. The outdoor trials were also not directly comparable with the indoor ones, since the featureless foam board failed in direct sunlight and the brick floor had to be scanned instead. A repeat characterisation should use a calibrated light meter, ideally with a near-infrared or spectral measurement, and scan both a textureless board and a texture-rich surface under every condition, so that the effects of illumination and texture can be separated.

Ambient light also drifted during the long sweeps. Over the working-distance sweep (15:40 to 17:35) the auto-exposure value fell from about 5300 to between 1700 and 2050, so lighting is confounded with distance. The height and tilt sweeps should be repeated under controlled lighting, or in a randomised order.

Each condition was recorded once, so the repeatability of the set-up is unknown. Repeated captures of key conditions are needed, as is further testing on wet sand, where specular reflection from a water film produced a region of high noise. The system has also not been deployed on the Langebaan intertidal flats. Field trials within a low-tide window are needed to confirm the recommended protocol, and would provide the data on which to develop automated detection of mounds and burrow openings, which was removed from the scope of this project.

On the reference objects, single scans gave rugosity closer to the reference than fused scans, in conflict with every other metric. This is attributed to the reconstructions under-representing relief amplitude while single-scan noise adds slope, but the explanation has not been tested directly. A flat reference plate, processed with the same grid spacing and smoothing, would establish the noise floor and allow the pipeline's noise correction to be applied. Reference objects with lower-amplitude and shorter-wavelength relief would show where amplitude is lost, including the effect of the 10 mm MLS radius. Larger surfaces with verified roughness would give a more representative validation. The High Accuracy preset, which gave low RMSE but poor completeness in single scans, should also be tested in combination with fusion, which can fill its holes.

The D456 has a 95 mm baseline optimised for longer range [4]. Its minimum depth of about 0.52 m at 1280×720, together with the depth anomalies observed at 687 mm with tilts of around 17°, prevents it from operating at the shorter distances where noise is lowest. Shorter-baseline cameras are better suited to close range. The D415 has a minimum range of about 160 mm [11] and gave the best short-range reconstructions of the cameras compared by Servi et al. [52], while the D435 kept errors below 1 cm within 1 m [45]. These should be compared with the D456 on the same reference objects. Finally, an external projector can add texture beyond the camera's internal pattern [17], which may improve reconstruction of featureless or wet surfaces, but this could not be investigated within the time frame.

Appendix A

GitHub repository

This appendix provides a link to the GitHub repository where the code and additional materials for this final year project report can be found.

A.1 Title for appendix A.1

- GitHub Repository: KLPJOA002-4022-Final-Year-Project

Appendix B

Theory

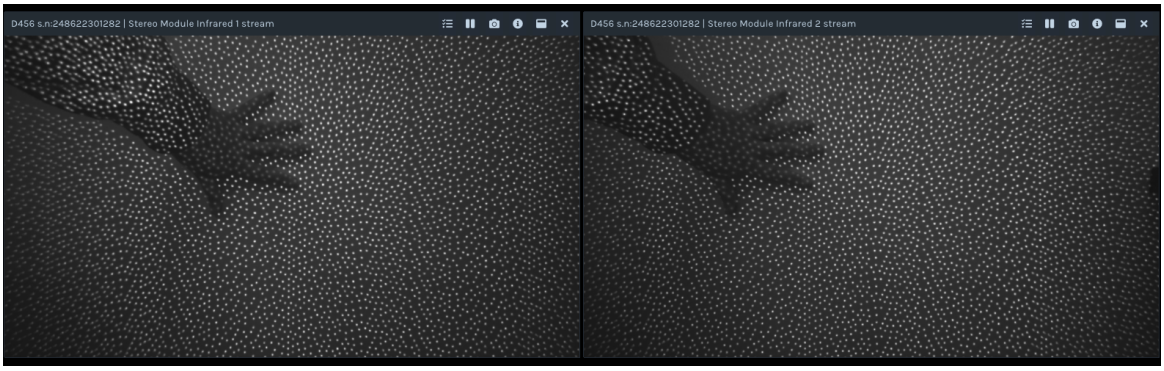


Figure B.1: Image Showing the Semi-Random Infrared Dot Pattern Projected by the Intel RealSense D456 Onto a White Wall, With a Hand in the Foreground

Appendix C

Reference Objects

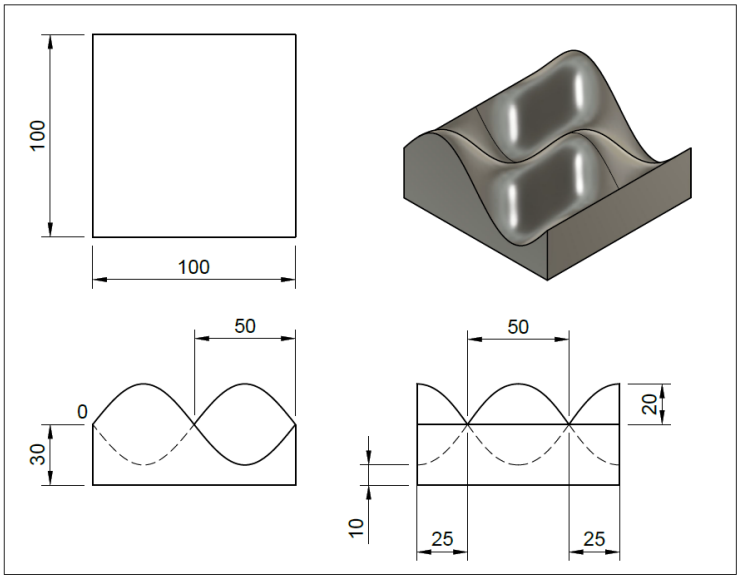


Figure C.1: Large Egg Box Surface Reference Object, With Feature Spacing of 50 mm and Amplitude of 20 mm Over a 100 × 100 mm Footprint

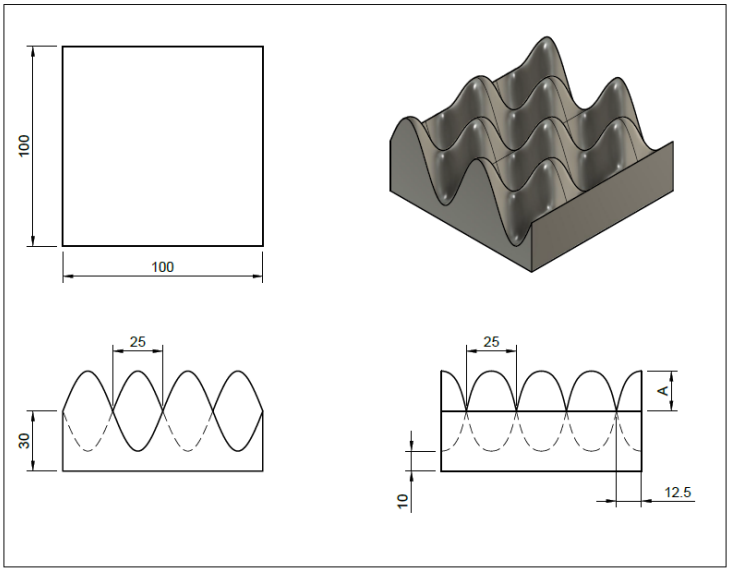


Figure C.2: Small Egg Box Surface Reference Object, With Feature Spacing of 25 mm and Amplitude of 15 mm Over a 100 × 100 mm Footprint

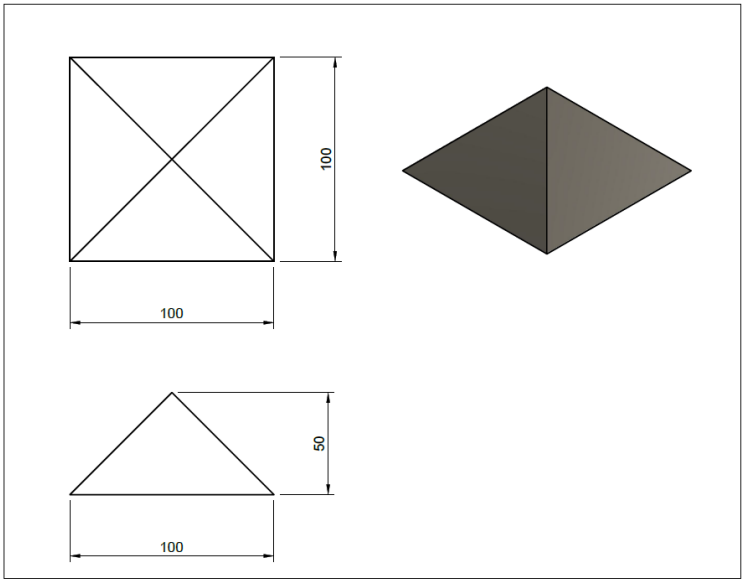


Figure C.3: Large Pyramid Surface Reference Object, With a Height of 50 mm Over a 100 × 100 mm Footprint

Appendix D

Characterisation Results

D.1 Planar Characterisation Results

Table D.1: Planar Reconstruction Quality Against Height. Per-Trial Median with IQR Over n = 385–552 Frames. Plotted in Figure 6.1.

Distance along optical axis (mm)	Median depth error (mm) per-trial median [Q1, Q3]	Depth RMSE (mm) per-trial median [Q1, Q3]	Plane-fit RMS (mm) per-trial median [Q1, Q3]	Valid pixels (%) per-trial median [Q1, Q3]
604	4.70 [4.70, 4.70]	4.90 [4.84, 4.96]	1.22 [1.21, 1.25]	99.6 [99.6, 99.7]
628	4.60 [4.60, 4.80]	4.86 [4.81, 4.90]	1.29 [1.27, 1.31]	99.5 [99.5, 99.6]
667	6.40 [6.40, 6.60]	6.64 [6.58, 6.70]	1.56 [1.53, 1.59]	99.5 [99.4, 99.5]
723	5.60 [5.30, 5.60]	6.13 [6.04, 6.23]	2.64 [2.57, 2.70]	97.7 [97.5, 98.0]
760	6.10 [5.80, 6.10]	6.66 [6.54, 6.76]	2.81 [2.73, 2.88]	97.7 [97.5, 97.9]
821	7.80 [7.50, 7.80]	8.35 [8.21, 8.47]	3.27 [3.18, 3.35]	97.4 [97.1, 97.6]
880	7.30 [6.90, 7.30]	8.37 [8.21, 8.54]	4.05 [3.95, 4.17]	96.9 [96.6, 97.2]
903	8.10 [7.70, 8.10]	9.41 [9.20, 9.62]	4.58 [4.45, 4.70]	96.6 [96.2, 96.9]

Table D.2: Planar Reconstruction Quality Against Scan Angle. Per-Trial Median with IQR Over n = 527–574 Frames. Plotted in Figure 6.2.

AbsMean IMU angle	Axis	Median depth error (mm) per-trial median [Q1, Q3]	Depth RMSE (mm) per-trial median [Q1, Q3]	Plane-fit RMS (mm) per-trial median [Q1, Q3]	Valid pixels (%) per-trial median [Q1, Q3]
1.7	pitch	5.0 [5.0, 5.1]	5.4 [5.3, 5.5]	1.62 [1.57, 1.66]	99.4 [99.3, 99.5]
2.5	roll	5.8 [5.7, 5.9]	6.2 [6.1, 6.3]	1.69 [1.65, 1.74]	99.2 [99.1, 99.3]
2.8	pitch	6.2 [6.1, 6.3]	6.8 [6.7, 6.8]	1.60 [1.55, 1.65]	99.5 [99.4, 99.6]
4.4	pitch	5.9 [5.8, 6.0]	6.1 [6.0, 6.2]	1.59 [1.55, 1.64]	99.4 [99.3, 99.5]
5.0	roll	5.5 [5.4, 5.6]	5.9 [5.8, 6.0]	1.67 [1.62, 1.72]	99.2 [99.1, 99.4]
6.2	roll	6.5 [6.4, 6.6]	7.0 [6.9, 7.1]	1.69 [1.64, 1.73]	99.2 [99.0, 99.3]
7.0	pitch	6.1 [6.0, 6.2]	6.4 [6.3, 6.4]	1.63 [1.59, 1.68]	99.5 [99.3, 99.6]
8.8	roll	9.8 [9.7, 9.9]	10.9 [10.8, 11.0]	1.72 [1.67, 1.77]	99.2 [99.1, 99.4]
9.3	pitch	6.7 [6.6, 6.8]	7.0 [7.0, 7.1]	1.63 [1.59, 1.68]	99.4 [99.3, 99.5]
10.8	pitch	6.6 [6.5, 6.7]	7.0 [6.9, 7.0]	1.68 [1.63, 1.73]	99.4 [99.3, 99.5]
11.0	roll	8.2 [8.1, 8.3]	8.7 [8.6, 8.8]	1.73 [1.69, 1.77]	99.3 [99.1, 99.4]
13.1	pitch	6.6 [6.5, 6.7]	7.0 [6.9, 7.1]	1.74 [1.69, 1.79]	99.3 [99.2, 99.4]
13.5	roll	7.4 [7.3, 7.5]	7.8 [7.7, 7.9]	1.79 [1.74, 1.83]	99.2 [99.1, 99.3]
15.8	roll	7.9 [7.8, 8.0]	8.4 [8.3, 8.5]	1.79 [1.75, 1.84]	99.2 [99.1, 99.3]
15.8	pitch	7.9 [7.8, 8.0]	8.5 [8.4, 8.5]	1.79 [1.74, 1.84]	99.3 [99.2, 99.5]
17.8	roll	8.9 [8.8, 9.0]	9.4 [9.3, 9.5]	1.87 [1.81, 1.92]	99.1 [98.9, 99.3]
17.8	pitch	7.4 [7.3, 7.5]	8.0 [7.9, 8.1]	1.91 [1.85, 1.97]	99.2 [99.0, 99.4]
18.8	roll	6.5 [6.4, 6.6]	7.1 [7.0, 7.2]	1.88 [1.83, 1.93]	99.1 [98.9, 99.2]
20.1	pitch	7.5 [7.4, 7.6]	8.1 [8.0, 8.2]	2.02 [1.96, 2.09]	99.0 [98.8, 99.2]
21.9	roll	10.9 [10.8, 11.0]	11.4 [11.3, 11.5]	1.96 [1.91, 2.02]	98.9 [98.8, 99.1]
22.0	pitch	7.8 [7.7, 7.9]	8.1 [8.0, 8.2]	2.01 [1.94, 2.08]	99.1 [98.9, 99.2]
23.8	roll	9.9 [9.7, 10.0]	10.3 [10.2, 10.4]	2.05 [2.00, 2.10]	98.7 [98.5, 98.9]
24.1	pitch	8.8 [8.7, 8.9]	9.2 [9.1, 9.4]	2.11 [2.03, 2.18]	98.9 [98.7, 99.1]
25.5	roll	11.1 [11.0, 11.2]	11.5 [11.4, 11.6]	2.11 [2.06, 2.18]	98.4 [98.2, 98.7]
26.5	pitch	5.0 [4.9, 5.1]	5.4 [5.3, 5.6]	2.21 [2.14, 2.29]	98.8 [98.6, 99.0]
27.9	pitch	10.8 [10.6, 10.9]	11.4 [11.3, 11.6]	2.29 [2.22, 2.37]	98.8 [98.5, 99.0]

Table D.3: Planar Reconstruction Quality Against Light Intensity, for Indoor Conditions With Foam Board. Per-Trial Median with IQR Over n = 592–599 Frames. Plotted in Figure 6.3.

Illuminance (lx)	Median depth error (mm) per-trial median [Q1, Q3]	Depth RMSE (mm) per-trial median [Q1, Q3]	Plane-fit RMS (mm) per-trial median [Q1, Q3]	Valid pixels (%) per-trial median [Q1, Q3]
0	4.80 [4.80, 5.20]	6.22 [5.97, 6.41]	1.80 [1.75, 1.84]	99.9 [99.9, 100.0]
17	7.50 [7.00, 7.50]	8.01 [7.76, 8.20]	2.74 [2.64, 2.82]	99.4 [99.3, 99.5]
65	5.20 [5.20, 5.60]	6.81 [6.67, 6.97]	2.84 [2.75, 2.94]	99.3 [99.2, 99.5]
78	7.50 [7.00, 7.50]	8.29 [8.04, 8.50]	3.44 [3.33, 3.56]	98.8 [98.5, 98.9]
91	7.00 [7.00, 7.50]	8.41 [8.17, 8.65]	4.14 [4.01, 4.29]	97.0 [96.7, 97.4]
151	7.50 [7.50, 7.90]	8.83 [8.60, 9.06]	4.43 [4.29, 4.59]	96.3 [95.9, 96.8]

D.2 Camera Configuration Results

Table D.4: 3D Reconstruction Quality Against Camera Resolution. Median with IQR of n = 15 Scans Per Value, Taken Over Three Depth Units and Five Presets. Plotted in Figure 6.4.

Resolution	Object	Accuracy RMSE (mm) median [Q1, Q3]	Signed bias (mm) median [Q1, Q3]	Completeness (full reference) at 2 mm (%) median [Q1, Q3]	F-score at 2 mm (%) median [Q1, Q3]
640 × 360	Big pyramid	2.14 [1.99, 2.19]	−0.013 [−0.019, −0.008]	50.7 [47.4, 52.7]	56.1 [52.9, 58.5]
	Big Egg Box	3.20 [2.86, 3.28]	−0.466 [−0.547, −0.396]	28.0 [25.5, 31.9]	33.9 [32.2, 37.6]
848 × 480	Big pyramid	1.70 [1.61, 1.77]	−0.001 [−0.007, 0.001]	65.7 [62.2, 68.5]	69.9 [67.2, 72.7]
	Big Egg Box	2.39 [2.34, 2.52]	−0.222 [−0.253, −0.115]	47.5 [45.0, 50.9]	52.3 [51.8, 55.4]
1280 × 720	Big pyramid	1.47 [1.34, 1.57]	−0.017 [−0.027, −0.002]	77.5 [69.6, 79.1]	79.9 [76.2, 81.0]
	Big Egg Box	2.07 [2.00, 2.21]	−0.100 [−0.118, −0.068]	57.1 [54.9, 61.4]	62.1 [59.8, 64.2]

Table D.5: 3D Reconstruction Quality Against Depth Units. Median with IQR of n = 15 Scans Per Value, Taken Over Three Resolutions and Five Presets. Plotted in Figure 6.5.

Depth unit (mm)	Object	Accuracy RMSE (mm) median [Q1, Q3]	Signed bias (mm) median [Q1, Q3]	Completeness (full reference) at 2 mm (%) median [Q1, Q3]	F-score at 2 mm (%) median [Q1, Q3]
0.1	Big pyramid	1.62 [1.52, 2.03]	−0.016 [−0.021, −0.001]	64.6 [51.5, 70.3]	71.2 [57.3, 76.2]
	Big Egg Box	2.35 [2.26, 2.85]	−0.154 [−0.399, −0.113]	45.8 [31.6, 54.9]	52.9 [37.5, 58.7]
0.5	Big pyramid	1.70 [1.55, 1.85]	−0.006 [−0.012, 0.003]	62.2 [56.8, 75.2]	69.9 [63.2, 77.9]
	Big Egg Box	2.39 [2.15, 2.86]	−0.230 [−0.340, −0.101]	47.9 [31.6, 54.4]	52.6 [37.3, 61.2]
1	Big pyramid	1.74 [1.56, 2.01]	−0.008 [−0.023, −0.006]	62.9 [52.9, 73.4]	68.8 [58.8, 75.5]
	Big Egg Box	2.47 [2.23, 2.74]	−0.269 [−0.372, −0.104]	47.5 [35.8, 56.6]	51.8 [41.5, 60.8]

Table D.6: 3D Reconstruction Quality Against Camera Preset. Median with IQR of n = 8–10 Scans Per Value, Taken Over Three Resolutions and Three Depth Units. Plotted in Figure 6.6.

Preset actual	Object	Accuracy RMSE (mm) median [Q1, Q3]	Signed bias (mm) median [Q1, Q3]	Completeness (full reference) at 2 mm (%) median [Q1, Q3]	F-score at 2 mm (%) median [Q1, Q3]
Custom	Big pyramid	1.70 [1.56, 1.83]	−0.011 [−0.020, −0.001]	64.6 [56.4, 70.9]	69.9 [62.7, 75.2]
	Big Egg Box	2.43 [2.27, 2.71]	−0.232 [−0.383, −0.135]	48.0 [38.3, 53.5]	52.7 [43.8, 58.7]
Default	Big pyramid	1.88 [1.69, 2.14]	0.001 [−0.018, 0.005]	58.7 [48.2, 74.6]	63.2 [52.9, 75.1]
	Big Egg Box	2.51 [2.29, 2.99]	−0.353 [−0.388, −0.122]	46.7 [29.6, 56.3]	51.4 [35.2, 59.1]
High Accuracy	Big pyramid	1.74 [1.33, 2.14]	−0.017 [−0.019, −0.014]	59.9 [48.6, 62.2]	67.8 [54.8, 71.2]
	Big Egg Box	2.36 [2.00, 3.29]	−0.098 [−0.466, −0.060]	44.0 [25.1, 51.9]	51.8 [32.5, 60.1]
High Density	Big pyramid	1.60 [1.55, 1.86]	−0.007 [−0.014, −0.004]	72.3 [57.2, 78.8]	75.9 [63.6, 79.9]
	Big Egg Box	2.28 [2.05, 2.64]	−0.109 [−0.248, −0.104]	55.0 [36.2, 62.0]	59.2 [41.9, 64.4]
Medium density	Big pyramid	1.65 [1.48, 1.97]	−0.007 [−0.013, −0.001]	67.1 [53.6, 77.5]	71.2 [59.5, 80.2]
	Big Egg Box	2.59 [2.21, 3.20]	−0.236 [−0.493, −0.135]	47.1 [28.1, 55.0]	51.8 [33.9, 58.4]

D.3 Filter Configuration Results

Table D.7: 3D Reconstruction Quality With No Filter, the Best Overall Filter and the Best Filter for Each Object and Height. Median with IQR of n = 4–5 Scans Per Value, Taken Over Four Rotations at Zero Tilt. Plotted in Figure 6.7.

Height (mm)	Configuration	Accuracy RMSE (mm) median [Q1, Q3]	Signed bias (mm) median [Q1, Q3]	Completeness (full reference) at 2 mm (%) median [Q1, Q3]	F-score at 2 mm (%) median [Q1, Q3]
Big Egg Box					
641	Baseline (no filters)	1.71 [1.67, 1.80]	−0.060 [−0.073, −0.053]	70.6 [68.0, 70.6]	74.1 [71.5, 74.4]
	Best overall	1.71 [1.70, 1.76]	−0.086 [−0.108, −0.086]	68.9 [68.9, 69.9]	72.0 [72.0, 73.0]
	Best for this shape & height	1.68 [1.66, 1.70]	−0.073 [−0.078, −0.072]	70.3 [69.8, 70.6]	73.5 [73.1, 73.9]
701	Baseline (no filters)	1.99 [1.96, 1.99]	−0.047 [−0.060, −0.012]	63.5 [61.3, 64.0]	66.6 [64.7, 67.3]
	Best overall	1.88 [1.88, 1.89]	−0.055 [−0.064, −0.044]	62.6 [61.9, 62.8]	65.7 [65.4, 66.0]
	Best for this shape & height	1.89 [1.88, 1.91]	−0.041 [−0.089, −0.028]	11.2 [11.1, 11.2]	19.4 [19.1, 19.5]
763	Baseline (no filters)	2.14 [2.12, 2.25]	−0.194 [−0.226, −0.174]	58.9 [57.0, 62.0]	62.8 [61.4, 65.7]
	Best overall	2.09 [2.08, 2.10]	−0.171 [−0.236, −0.154]	60.9 [60.2, 61.0]	64.6 [64.0, 64.8]
	Best for this shape & height	2.06 [2.03, 2.09]	−0.237 [−0.237, −0.226]	52.9 [52.6, 52.9]	59.8 [59.7, 60.0]
810	Baseline (no filters)	2.15 [2.15, 2.35]	−0.103 [−0.150, −0.044]	54.6 [54.5, 56.7]	58.7 [58.6, 60.9]
	Best overall	2.11 [2.10, 2.14]	−0.085 [−0.090, −0.082]	56.1 [55.9, 56.9]	60.0 [60.0, 61.0]
	Best for this shape & height	2.09 [2.08, 2.12]	−0.110 [−0.115, −0.104]	46.7 [45.6, 47.0]	54.8 [53.5, 55.0]
863	Baseline (no filters)	2.64 [2.55, 2.76]	−0.121 [−0.160, −0.016]	49.8 [48.7, 50.7]	53.8 [52.7, 54.5]
	Best overall	2.40 [2.37, 2.46]	−0.202 [−0.202, −0.201]	51.6 [50.1, 52.9]	56.2 [54.5, 56.9]
	Best for this shape & height	2.37 [2.27, 2.42]	−0.141 [−0.232, −0.136]	54.1 [49.1, 54.7]	58.6 [54.2, 58.9]
933	Baseline (no filters)	2.95 [2.84, 3.20]	−0.345 [−0.385, −0.341]	43.3 [37.5, 45.2]	48.4 [43.1, 49.9]
	Best overall	2.80 [2.78, 2.86]	−0.311 [−0.362, −0.303]	43.6 [40.1, 44.6]	49.3 [46.2, 50.0]
	Best for this shape & height	2.89 [2.73, 2.96]	−0.221 [−0.322, −0.088]	47.6 [42.6, 52.5]	52.5 [47.6, 57.3]
Small Egg Box					
641	Baseline (no filters)	2.04 [2.01, 2.05]	−0.109 [−0.113, −0.105]	54.2 [53.9, 55.7]	60.2 [59.7, 61.3]
	Best overall	2.04 [2.01, 2.06]	−0.112 [−0.113, −0.110]	54.7 [54.6, 55.3]	60.4 [60.1, 60.8]
	Best for this shape & height	2.00 [1.97, 2.01]	−0.107 [−0.110, −0.103]	55.3 [53.9, 55.3]	60.8 [59.8, 61.2]
701	Baseline (no filters)	2.47 [2.43, 2.49]	−0.106 [−0.109, −0.053]	44.9 [42.9, 45.4]	51.3 [49.5, 51.9]
	Best overall	2.43 [2.41, 2.44]	−0.092 [−0.102, −0.088]	45.2 [45.2, 45.7]	51.6 [51.5, 52.0]
	Best for this shape & height	2.39 [2.39, 2.41]	−0.085 [−0.097, −0.076]	46.1 [45.4, 46.2]	52.1 [51.9, 52.5]
763	Baseline (no filters)	2.67 [2.67, 2.68]	−0.194 [−0.199, −0.190]	36.5 [36.3, 37.7]	43.4 [43.4, 44.7]
	Best overall	2.63 [2.61, 2.63]	−0.182 [−0.183, −0.182]	36.5 [36.4, 36.7]	43.6 [43.5, 43.9]
	Best for this shape & height	2.59 [2.59, 2.60]	−0.180 [−0.195, −0.177]	37.3 [36.8, 37.5]	44.2 [44.0, 44.8]
810	Baseline (no filters)	2.76 [2.76, 2.83]	−0.216 [−0.248, −0.216]	35.0 [34.3, 35.2]	42.2 [41.7, 42.9]
	Best overall	2.77 [2.77, 2.78]	−0.199 [−0.203, −0.195]	34.3 [33.9, 34.3]	41.7 [41.5, 42.0]
	Best for this shape & height	2.75 [2.74, 2.75]	−0.194 [−0.199, −0.175]	34.9 [34.1, 36.0]	42.4 [41.7, 43.4]
863	Baseline (no filters)	3.07 [3.05, 3.20]	−0.208 [−0.213, −0.144]	32.3 [32.1, 32.4]	39.8 [39.5, 40.0]
	Best overall	2.99 [2.99, 3.01]	−0.163 [−0.186, −0.158]	32.7 [32.3, 33.0]	40.3 [39.8, 40.7]
	Best for this shape & height	2.98 [2.97, 2.99]	−0.184 [−0.191, −0.176]	25.3 [25.0, 25.5]	34.5 [34.2, 34.7]
933	Baseline (no filters)	3.17 [3.14, 3.24]	−0.263 [−0.271, −0.259]	27.3 [26.5, 28.6]	34.4 [33.3, 35.6]
	Best overall	3.03 [3.02, 3.04]	−0.263 [−0.271, −0.260]	28.5 [28.0, 28.6]	35.5 [35.0, 35.8]
	Best for this shape & height	3.03 [3.03, 3.03]	−0.258 [−0.261, −0.257]	28.5 [28.3, 28.5]	35.5 [35.4, 35.7]

D.4 Fusion Combination Results

Table D.8: 3D Reconstruction Quality of a Single Untilted Scan and the Fusion of All 44 Views, for Each Object and Height. One Point Cloud Per Value. Plotted in Figure 6.9.

Height (mm)	View family	Accuracy RMSE (mm) median [Q1, Q3]	Signed bias (mm) median [Q1, Q3]	Completeness (full reference) at 2 mm (%) median [Q1, Q3]	F-score at 2 mm (%) median [Q1, Q3]
Big Egg Box					
641	all	1.15	−0.054	88.8	90.9
	single	1.86	−0.096	65.3	68.7
701	all	1.34	−0.061	81.0	83.6
	single	1.94	−0.041	64.7	67.8
763	all	1.57	−0.087	74.0	76.9
	single	2.33	−0.205	59.2	63.0
810	all	1.76	−0.108	66.6	70.1
	single	2.11	−0.057	60.4	64.4
863	all	1.89	−0.098	62.0	65.3
	single	2.24	−0.219	53.1	57.5
933	all	2.31	−0.168	51.9	55.0
	single	3.20	−0.362	31.8	36.5
Small Egg Box					
641	all	1.93	−0.082	54.4	60.8
	single	2.09	−0.081	53.8	59.8
701	all	2.15	−0.083	48.9	55.4
	single	2.56	−0.127	40.4	46.8
763	all	2.43	−0.072	43.5	50.3
	single	2.71	−0.192	34.9	42.0
810	all	2.63	−0.113	39.1	46.0
	single	2.73	−0.189	34.4	41.9
863	all	2.72	−0.080	38.6	45.4
	single	3.12	−0.153	31.5	39.1
933	all	2.94	−0.105	35.1	41.7
	single	3.09	−0.253	28.4	35.4

Appendix E

Characterisation Plots

E.1 Filter Heatmaps

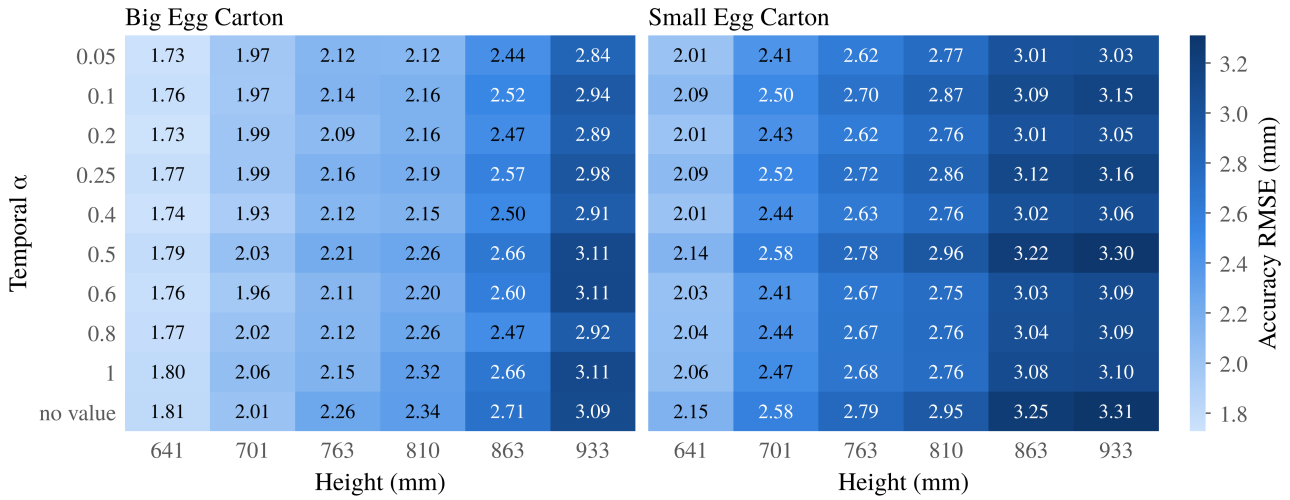


Figure E.1: Heatmap Showing 3D Reconstruction Accuracy RMSE Across Temporal Filter α Values and Heights, for the Large and Small Egg Boxes. Median with IQR of n = 5–295 Scans Per Cell, Taken Over 257 Filter Configurations at Zero Tilt

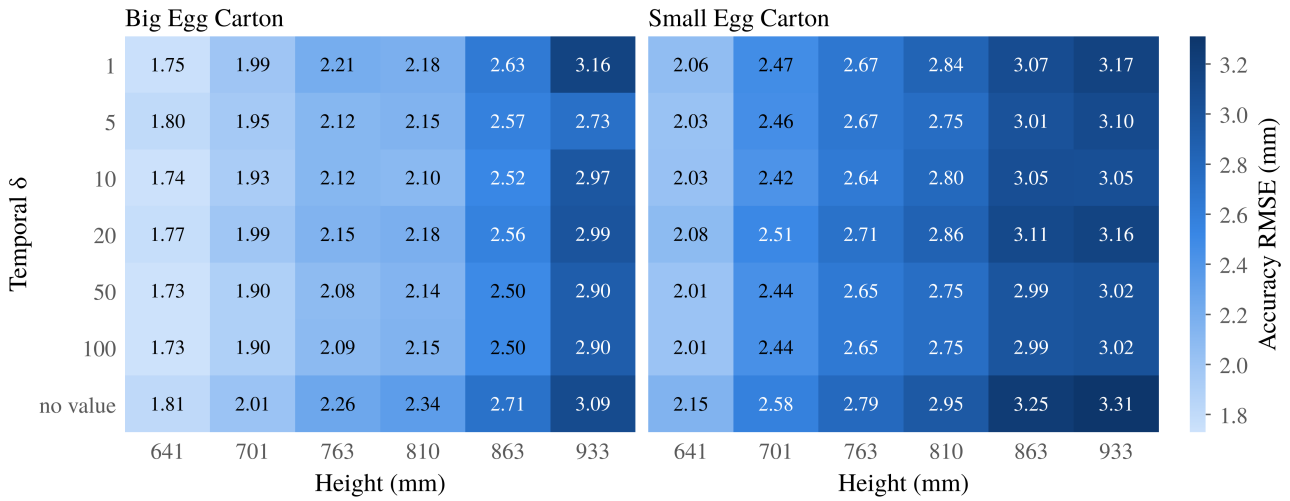


Figure E.2: Heatmap Showing 3D Reconstruction Accuracy RMSE Across Temporal Filter δ Values and Heights, for the Large and Small Egg Boxes. Median with IQR of n = 5–815 Scans Per Cell, Taken Over 257 Filter Configurations at Zero Tilt

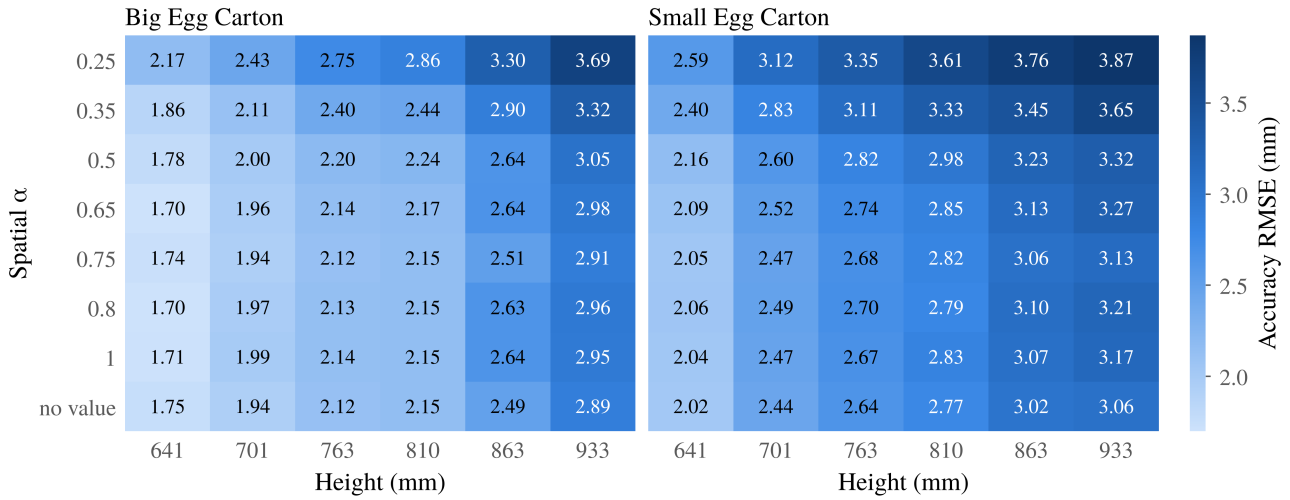


Figure E.3: Heatmap Showing 3D Reconstruction Accuracy RMSE Across Spatial Filter α Values and Heights, for the Large and Small Egg Boxes. Median with IQR of n = 5–315 Scans Per Cell, Taken Over 257 Filter Configurations at Zero Tilt

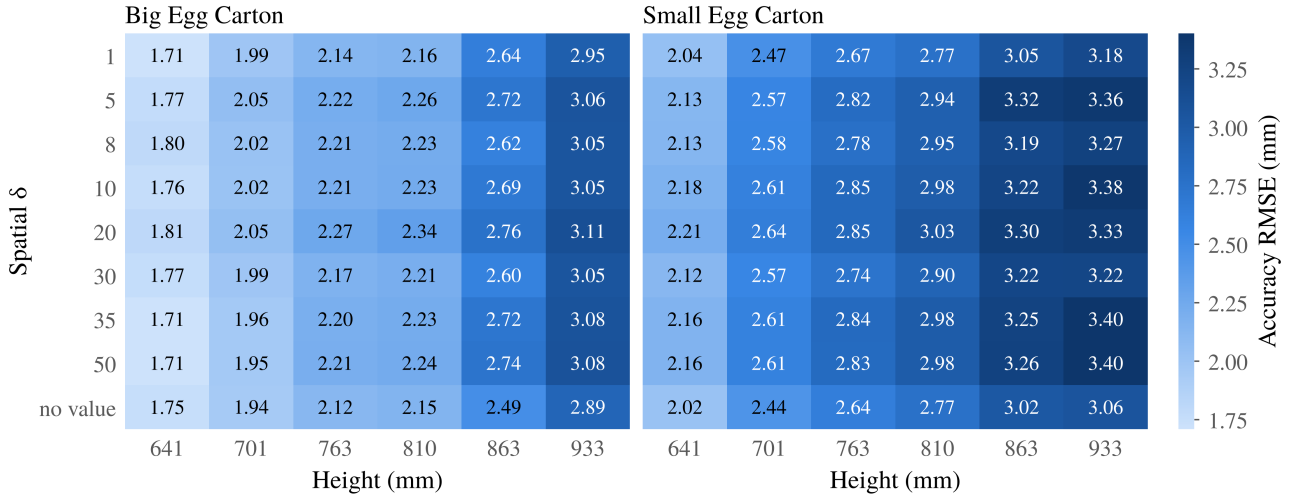


Figure E.4: Heatmap Showing 3D Reconstruction Accuracy RMSE Across Spatial Filter δ Values and Heights, for the Large and Small Egg Boxes. Median with IQR of n = 5–385 Scans Per Cell, Taken Over 257 Filter Configurations at Zero Tilt

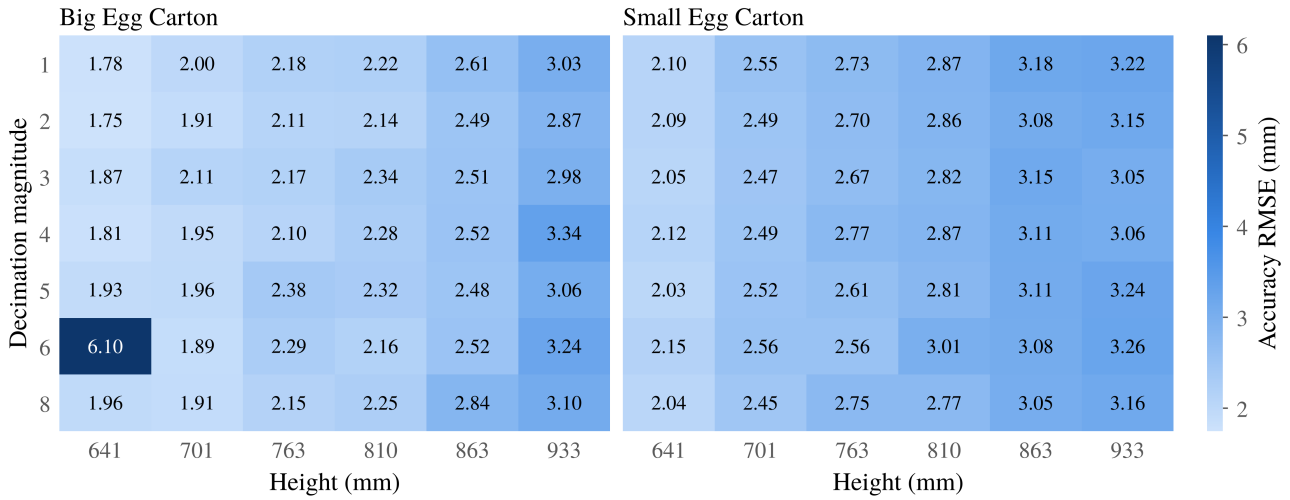


Figure E.5: Heatmap Showing 3D Reconstruction Accuracy RMSE Across Decimation Magnitudes and Heights, for the Large and Small Egg Boxes. Median with IQR of n = 5–950 Scans Per Cell, Taken Over 257 Filter Configurations at Zero Tilt

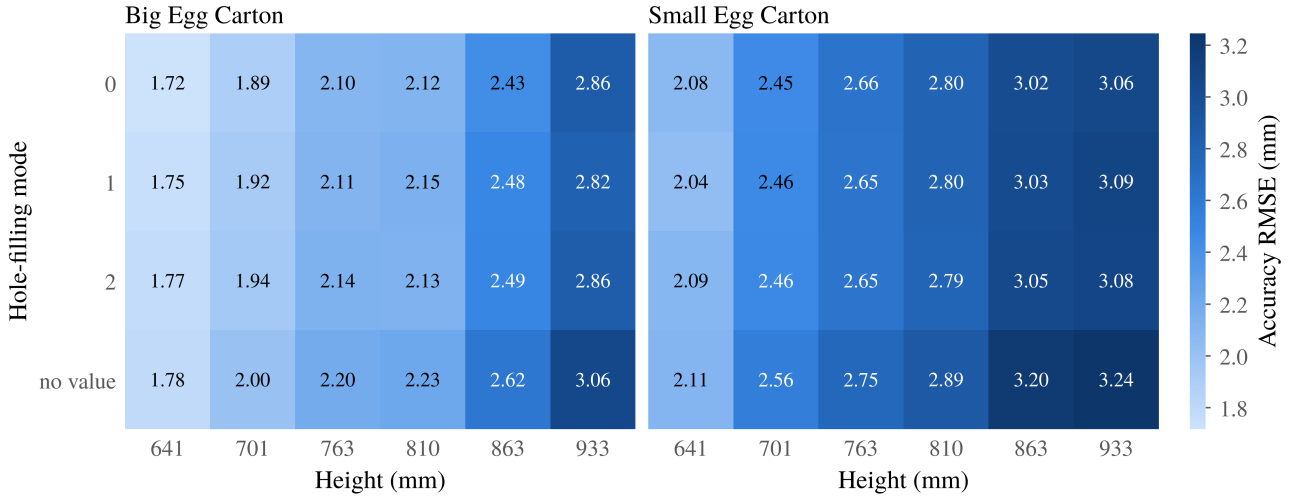


Figure E.6: Heatmap Showing 3D Reconstruction Accuracy RMSE Across Hole Filling Modes and Heights, for the Large and Small Egg Boxes. Median with IQR of n = 55–915 Scans Per Cell, Taken Over 257 Filter Configurations at Zero Tilt

E.2 Combination Heatmaps

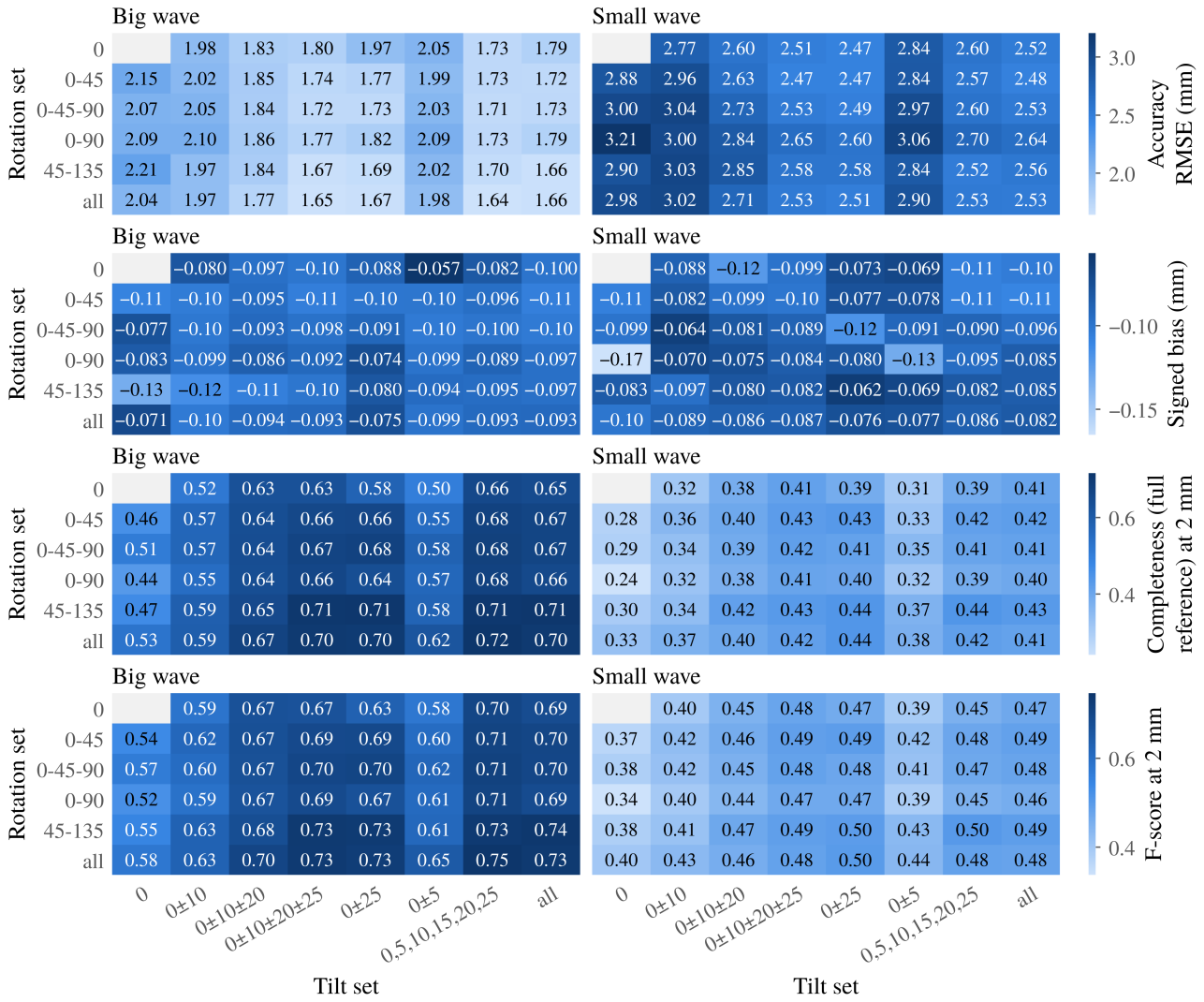
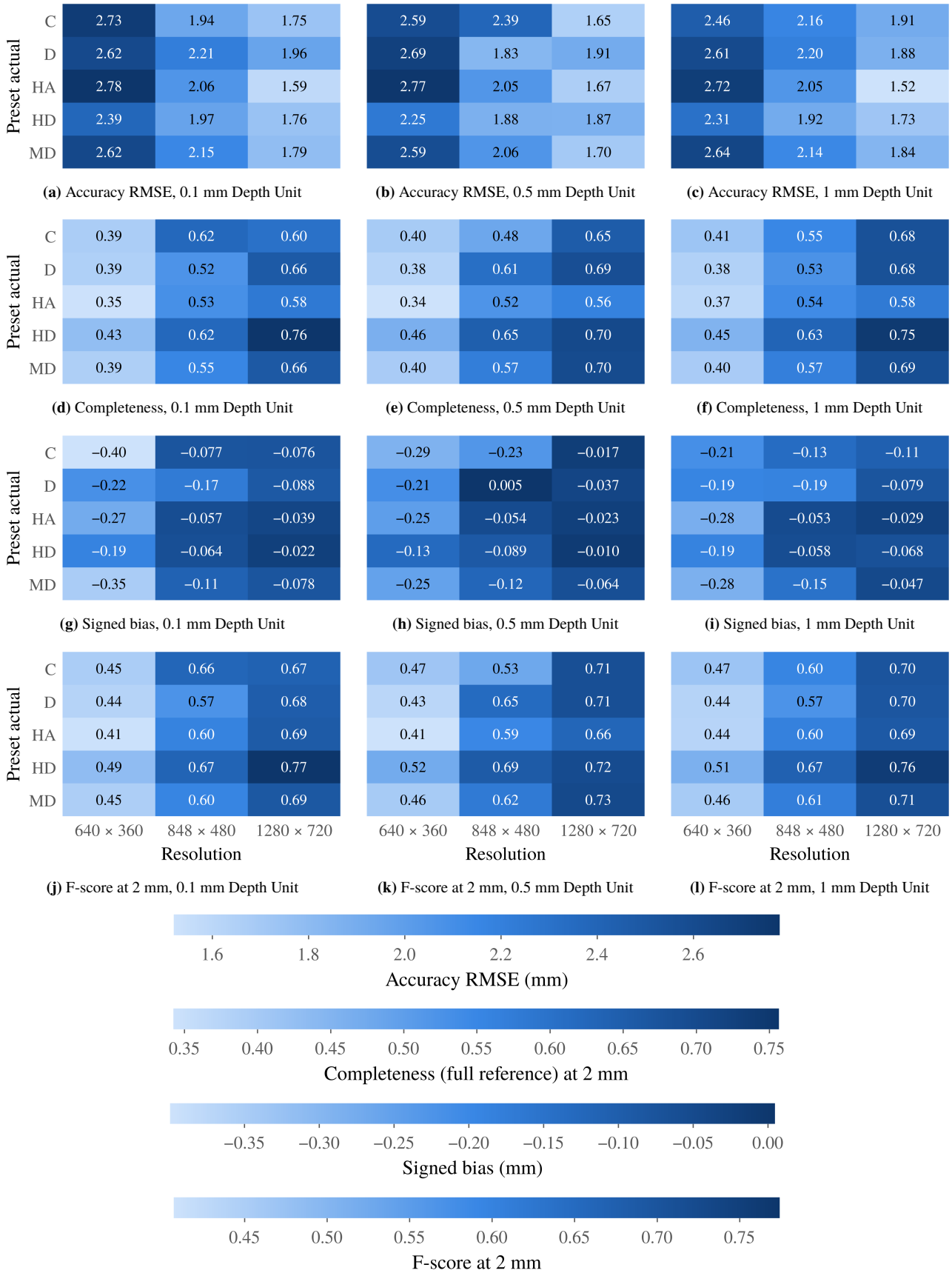


Figure E.7: Heatmaps Showing 3D Reconstruction Quality Across Combinations of Rotation Set (Rows) and Tilt Set (Columns), for the Large and Small Egg Boxes. Median with IQR of n = 6 Point Clouds Per Cell, Taken Over Six Heights. Fusion Cell = 0.5 mm, Scan Voxel = 0.5 mm. Grey Cells Indicate No Data

E.3 Parameter Heatmap



(a) Accuracy RMSE, 0.1 mm Depth Unit **(b)** Accuracy RMSE, 0.5 mm Depth Unit **(c)** Accuracy RMSE, 1 mm Depth Unit

(d) Completeness, 0.1 mm Depth Unit **(e)** Completeness, 0.5 mm Depth Unit **(f)** Completeness, 1 mm Depth Unit

(g) Signed bias, 0.1 mm Depth Unit **(h)** Signed bias, 0.5 mm Depth Unit **(i)** Signed bias, 1 mm Depth Unit

(j) F-score at 2 mm, 0.1 mm Depth Unit **(k)** F-score at 2 mm, 0.5 mm Depth Unit **(l)** F-score at 2 mm, 1 mm Depth Unit

Figure E.8: Heatmaps Showing 3D Reconstruction Quality Across Camera Configuration Combinations, for Each Depth Unit. Median with IQR of n = 1–3 Scans Per Cell, Taken Over Both Objects and Five Presets. Laser Emitter at 150 Power, 30 fps

E.4 Accuracy Vs Tilt

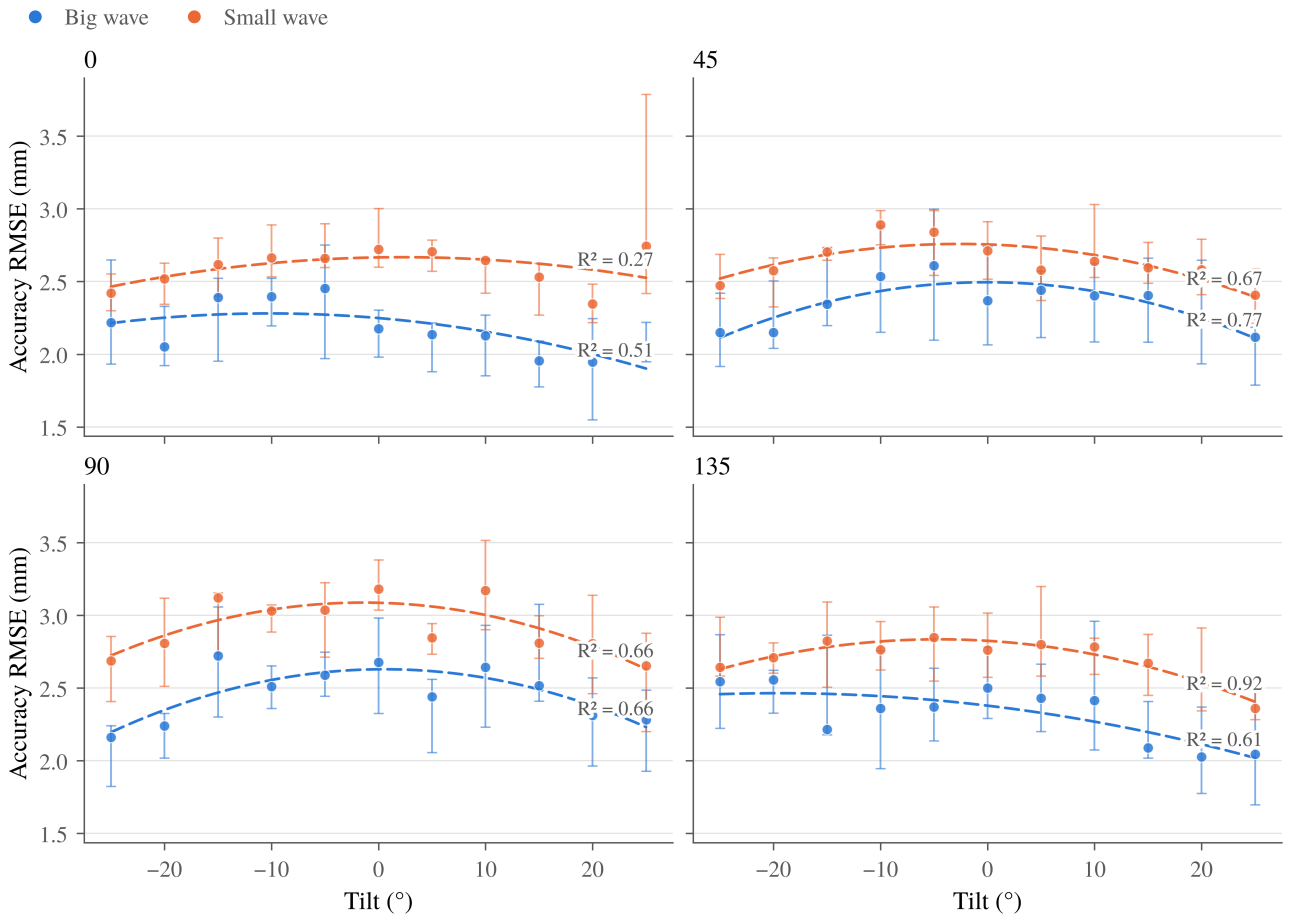


Figure E.9: Plots Showing Single Scan Accuracy RMSE Against Tilt Angle, for Each Rotation, With Quadratic Best Fit (R^2 0.27 to 0.92). Median with IQR of n = 5–6 Point Clouds Per Point, Taken Over Six Heights

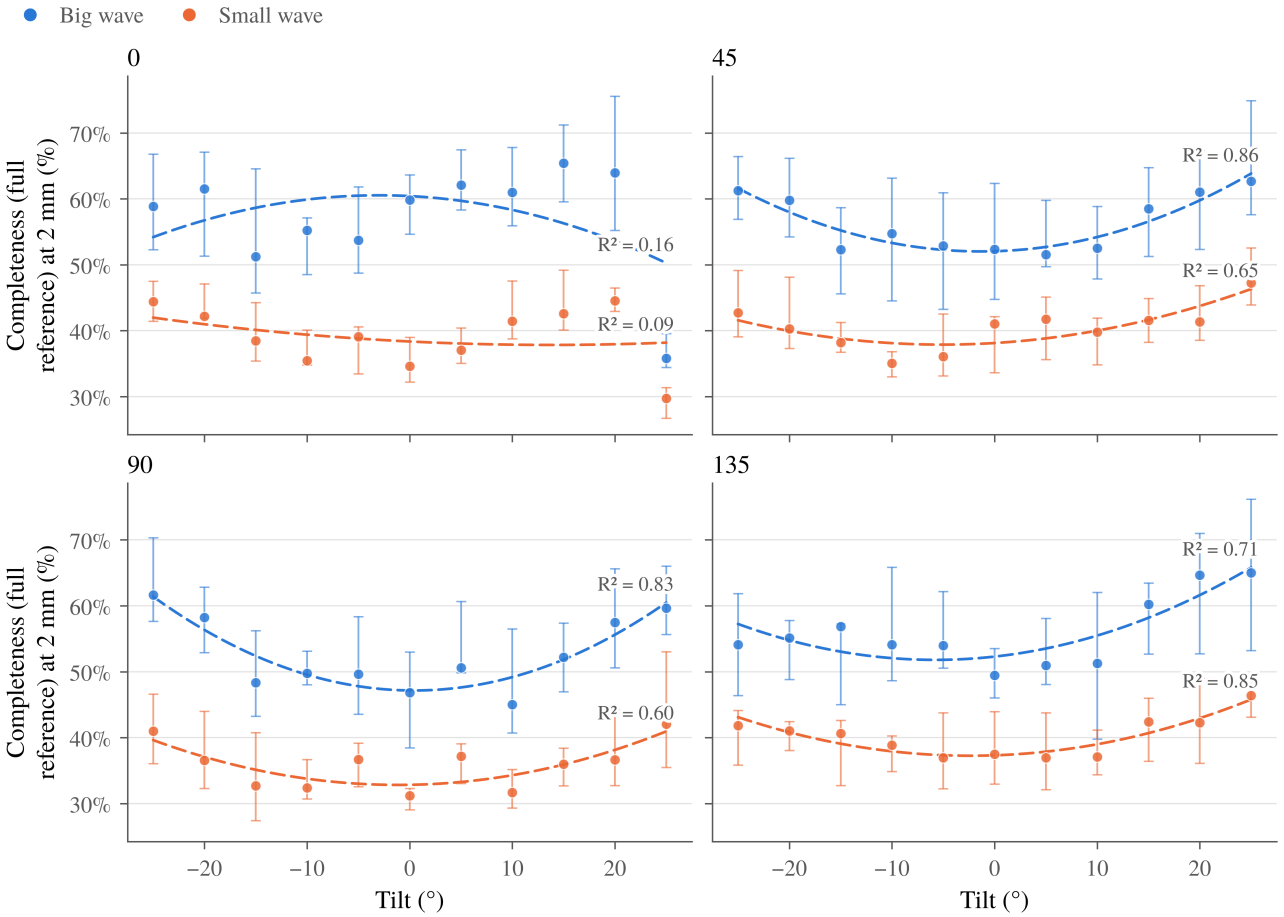


Figure E.10: Plots Showing Single Scan Completeness Against Tilt Angle, for Each Rotation, With Quadratic Best Fit (R^2 0.09 to 0.86). Median with IQR of n = 5–6 Point Clouds Per Point, Taken Over Six Heights

E.5 Single Vs Fused Error Histograms

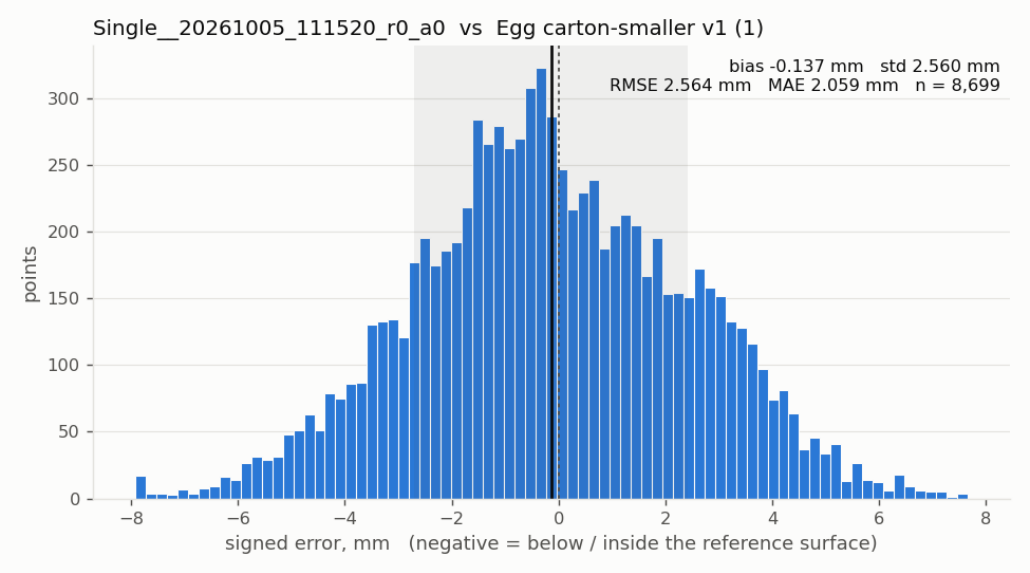


Figure E.11: Histogram Showing Distribution of Signed Error for a Single Scan of the Small Egg Box at 701 mm, Compared Against the Reference Object. Solid Line Marks the Bias. Corresponding Error Map in Figure 6.11b

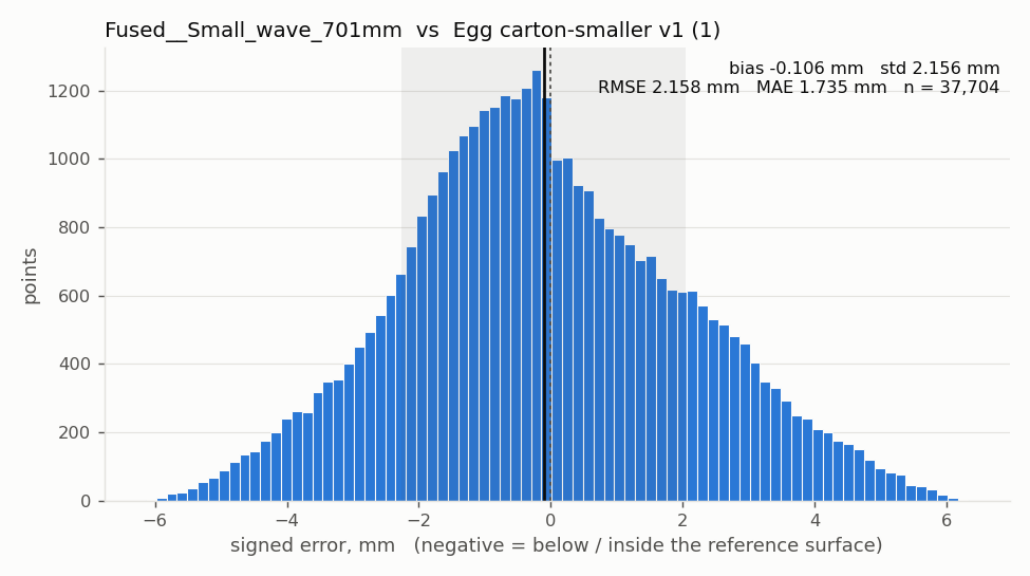


Figure E.12: Histogram Showing Distribution of Signed Error for the Fused Scan of the Small Egg Box at 701 mm, Compared Against the Reference Object. Solid Line Marks the Bias. Corresponding Error Map in Figure 6.12b

Appendix F

Validation Results

F.1 Reference Shapes Rugosity

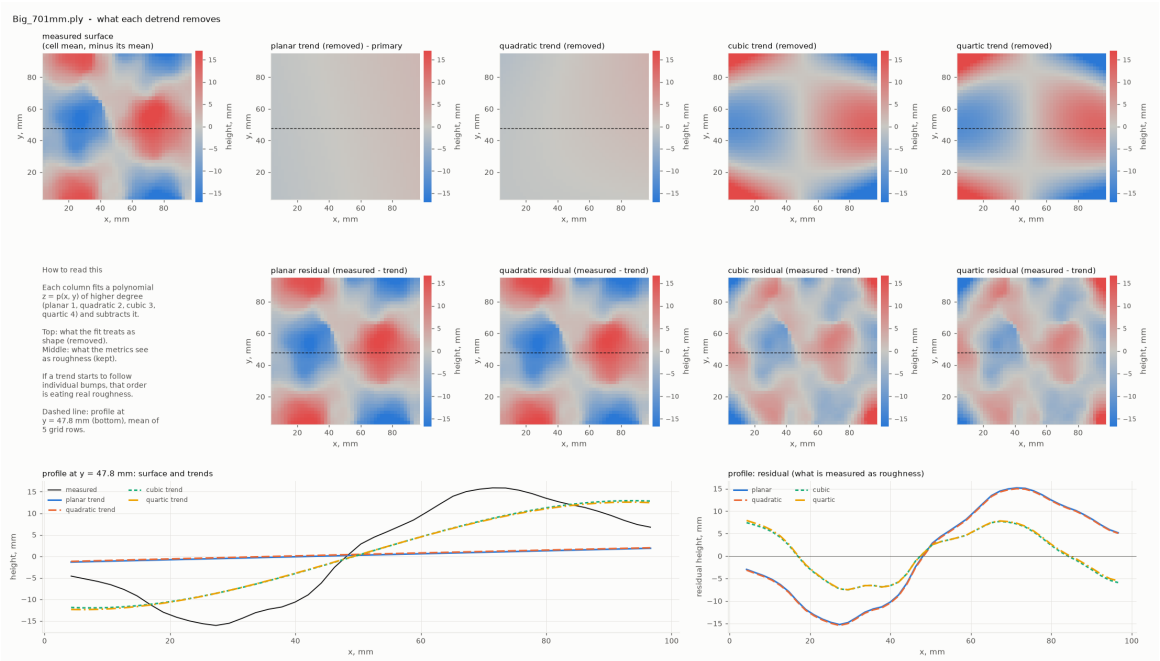


Figure F.1: Visual Representation of Each Detrending Degree Applied to a Single Scan of the Large Egg Box at 701 mm. Top: Fitted Trend (Removed). Middle: Residual (Measured as Roughness). Bottom: Profile Through the Centre of the Patch

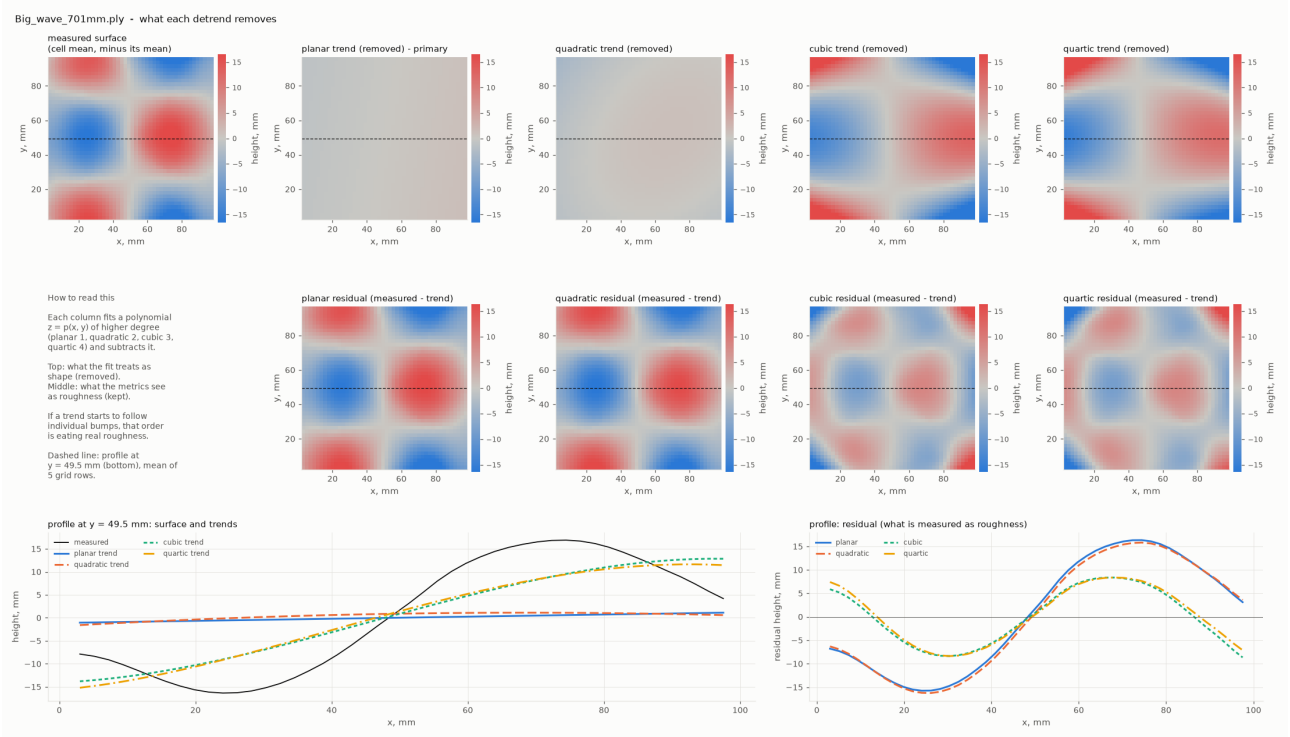


Figure F.2: Visual Representation of Each Detrending Degree Applied to the Fused Scan of the Large Egg Box at 701 mm. Top: Fitted Trend (Removed). Middle: Residual (Measured as Roughness). Bottom: Profile Through the Centre of the Patch

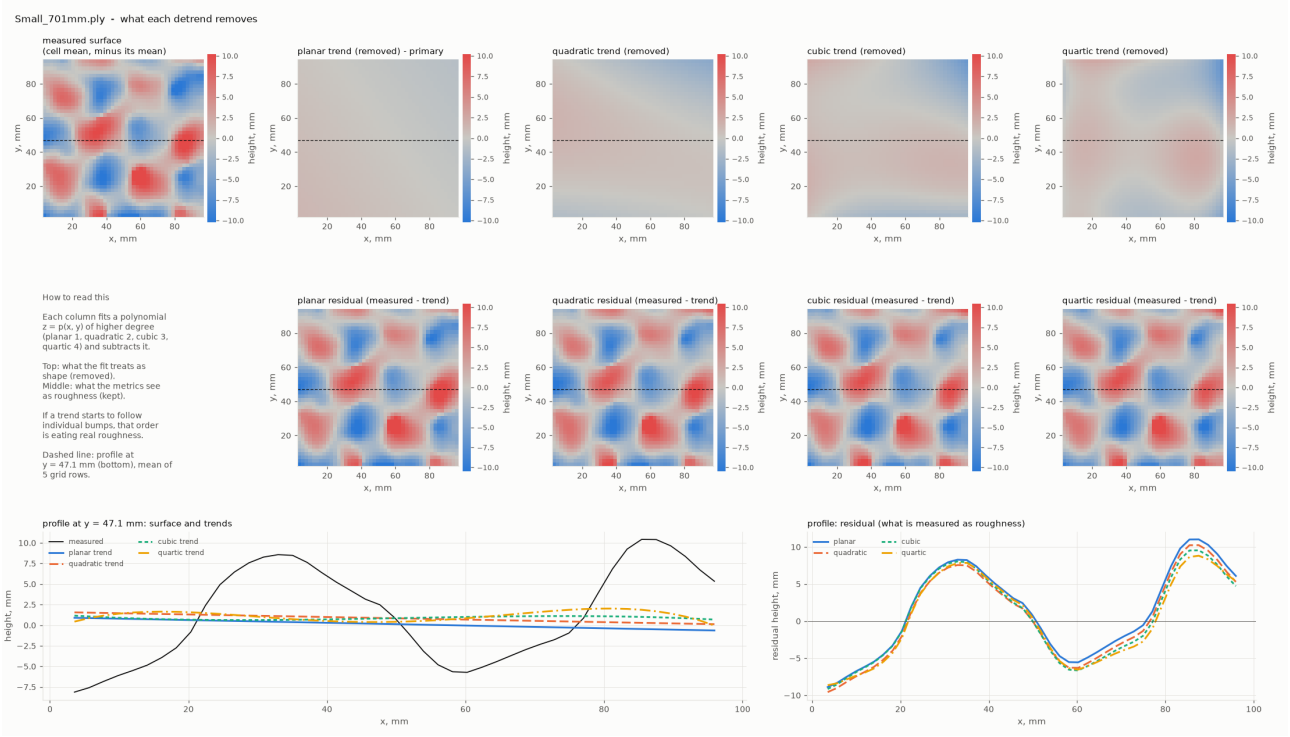


Figure F.3: Visual Representation of Each Detrending Degree Applied to a Single Scan of the Small Egg Box at 701 mm. Top: Fitted Trend (Removed). Middle: Residual (Measured as Roughness). Bottom: Profile Through the Centre of the Patch

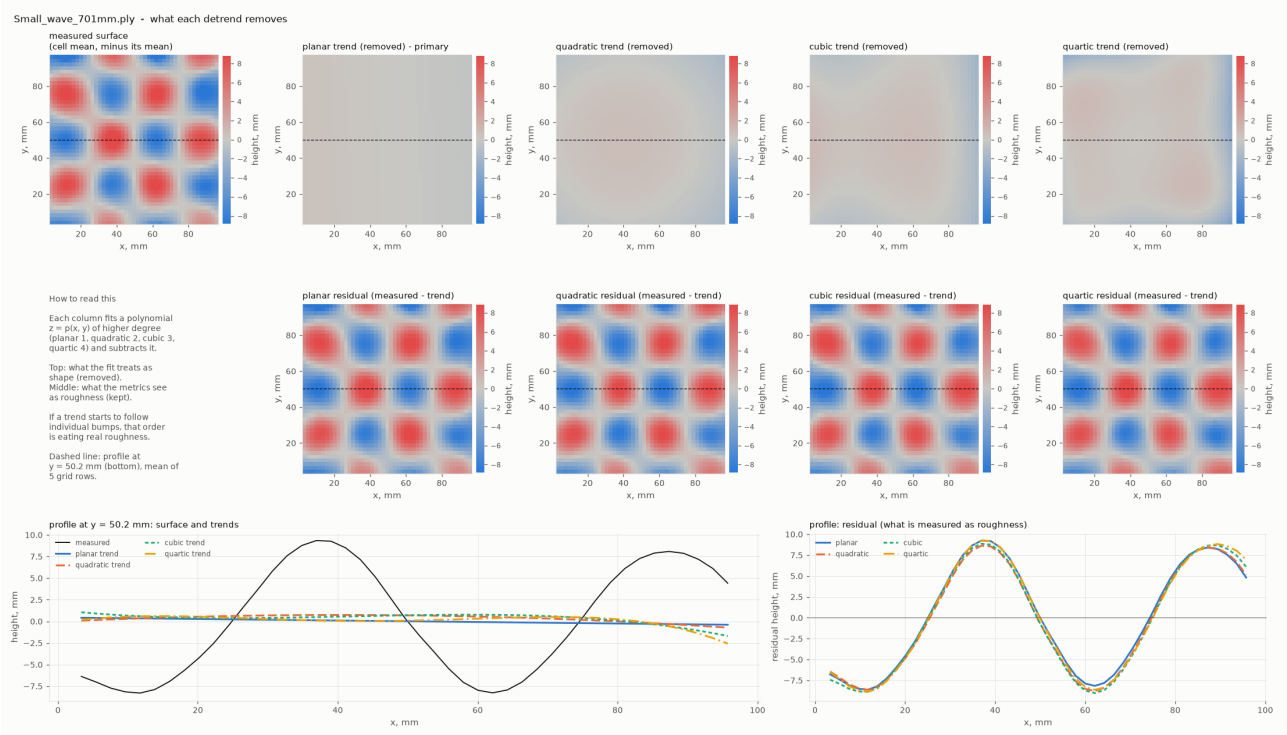


Figure F.4: Visual Representation of Each Detrending Degree Applied to the Fused Scan of the Small Egg Box at 701 mm. Top: Fitted Trend (Removed). Middle: Residual (Measured as Roughness). Bottom: Profile Through the Centre of the Patch

F.2 Sand Reference Images

Figure F.5: Image Showing Dry Laboratory Sand Indented With the Pyramid, Small Egg Box and Large Egg Box Reference Objects (Left to Right), Surrounded by ArUco Markers

Figure F.6: Image Showing Wet Laboratory Sand Flattened by Hand Prior to Scanning, Surrounded by ArUco Markers

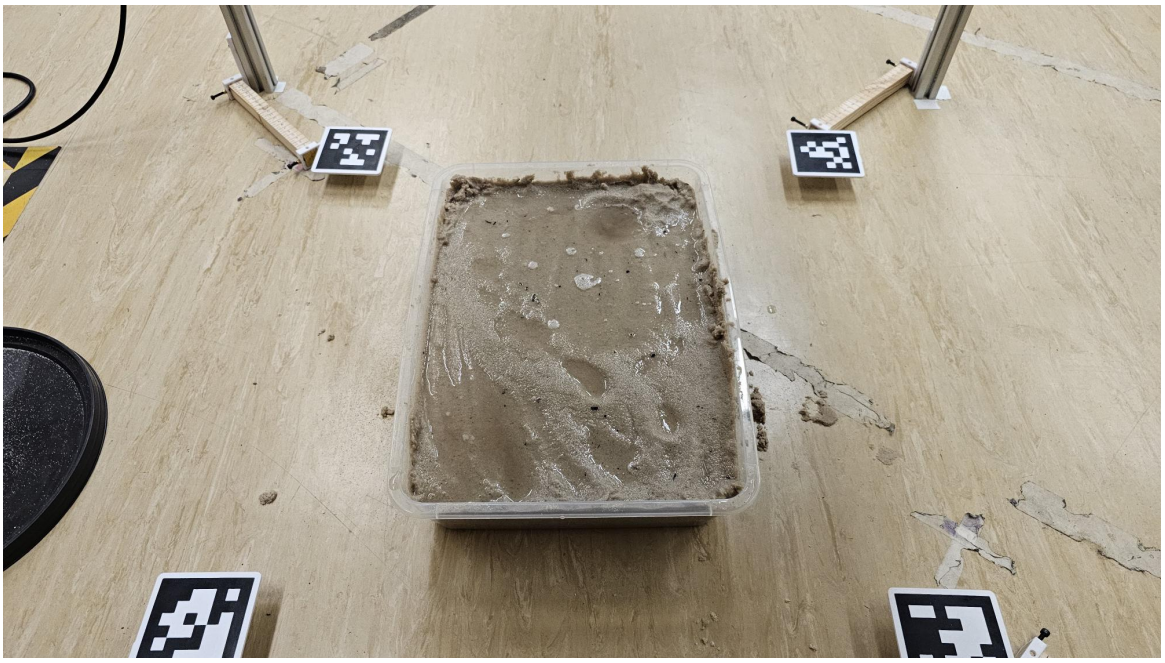


Figure F.7: Image Showing Soaked Laboratory Sand Shaped by Hand, With Water Pooled on the Surface. Corresponding Reconstructions in Figure 7.4

Appendix G

AI Usage Examples

Examples of AI used for the purpose of assisting with final report:

G.1 Appendix Image Captions

Prompt:

Can you please help me neaten up the captions for the plots in my appendix? I Want them to follow the same style as i have in my main report.

Please output the caption you recommend for each image, and i will review them and place them in the report

Response: Here are the recommended captions, written to match the Chapter 5 and 7 conventions: a Title Case lead phrase ("Plots Showing…", "Heatmap Showing…", "Visual Representation of…"), then the statistics sentence, then a pointer to the data or related figure. Like your main captions, they have no trailing full stop.

Appendix A – Theory

latex
captionImage Showing the Semi-Random Infrared Dot Pattern Projected by the Intel RealSense D456 Onto a White Wall, With a Hand in the Foreground

Appendix B – Reference Objects .....

The captions this AI provided were reviewed and deemed to be satisfactory and so were used for the captions of all images in the appendix.

G.2 Chapter Re-write

Prompt: Can you please help me rewrite my further work section of my report? So far it is my rough draft, and i want to tidy it up and make it much nicer.

I want this section to describe points that have been identified to be lacking in terms of characterisation and validation. Especially sinc eht time frame of this project limited it

Do not make up information, and use data present in the report. I have added some todo points, and these should also be considered. Feel free to fix incorrrect statements, and add some detail where necesary

The main aim is to improve this chapter, to a presentable point.

If any fixes or changes are made, present them in a log.

Please feel free to ask me any quaestions that might be imporatn for your writing

This chapter should be at most one page

Response: The rewritten chapter is in 9_furtherwork.tex. It is about 620 words, which should fit on one page with your template. It uses only data and citation keys that are already in your report and 4022.bib.

Change log

Factual corrections

Minimum range. The draft said the D456's minimum operating distance is 600 mm. Your Chapter 3 derives Z_min ≈ 0.51 m and cites the datasheet value of 0.52 m, so I changed it to "about 0.52 m at 1280×720". I also added the 687 mm tilt anomaly from Chapter 8 as the practical limit. D456 range. "Optimised for longer range" is now tied to the 95 mm baseline and cited, instead of being stated without support.

TODOs resolved

Shorter-range cameras. I filled these in from sources already in your bib: D415: about 160 mm minimum (Carfagni), and best short-range reconstructions (Servi). D435: under 1 cm error within 1 m (Rustler).

Content added

Chapters 1 and 8 both say certain items would be "discussed in Chapter 10", but they were missing from the draft. I added them:

Feature detection. Automated mound and burrow detection, which was removed from scope (Chapter 1.4). Preset with fusion. Testing High Accuracy combined with fusion (Chapter 8.1).

I also carried over the limitations listed in Chapters 8 and 9:

single trials per condition, so repeatability is unknown; the ± values on the sand data reflect processing options, not repeat captures; no field deployment; specular noise on wet sand.

Other additions:

Lighting drift. Quantified with your auto-exposure data (5300 down to 1700–2050, 15:40–17:35). Spectral lighting. Linked to your daylight vs fluorescent result. Fusion and roughness section. Now names the flat-plate noise floor, which your pipeline already supports through its noise correction, and the effect of the 10 mm MLS radius.

Language and structure

Fixed spelling throughout: tecture, rigourus, suseptable, arteficially, characteristaion, referenc, rang, Ther ewas, wher ehigh, ans. Added a short intro framing the chapter around the 12-week limit. Merged "Fusion Characterisation" into "Fusion and Roughness Validation" and added a "Repeatability and Field Validation" section. Things to check D405. I left out the D405, Intel's dedicated short-range model, because it isn't in your bib. If you'd like it, add a datasheet citation and one clause. Section numbers. I avoided hard-coded section and table numbers because I don't know your ames. Add
refs if you want cross-links. Page fit. If it spills slightly over a page, the easiest cut is the last sentence of the Repeatability section (feature detection), though I'd keep it since Chapter 1 promises it.

Appendix B: Ethics approval

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PRE-SCREENING QUESTIONNAIRE OUTCOME LETTER

STU-EBE-2026-PSQ002548

2026/08/11

Dear Joab Kloppers,

Your Ethics pre-screening questionnaire (PSQ) has been evaluated by your departmental ethics representative. Based on the information supplied in your PSQ, it has been determined that you do not need to make a full ethics application for the research project in question.

You may proceed with your research project titled:

RGB-D microtopography of sandprawn bioturbation

Please note that should aspect(s) of your current project change, you should submit a new PSQ in order to determine whether the changed aspects increase the ethical risks of your project. It may be the case that project changes could require a full ethics application and review process.

Regards,

Faculty Research Ethics Committee

Appendix C: Topic description

The original topic description used during the project selection process is included below. This topic has since been further refined, and the exact problem that was investigated is described in Section 1.2.

EEE4022S RAV2026-06

Student Proposed?	**Y/N**	N/A
ID	**RAV2026-06**	
Supervisor	**RA Verrinder**	
Co-Supervisor(s)	**A/Prof D Pillay (UCT Biological Sciences), G Maniel**	
Title	**RGB-D microtopography of sandprawn bioturbation**	
Description		

Background
Burrowing sandprawns are important ecosystem engineers on South African sandy shores (**Venter** et al., 2020). Species such as *Kraussillichirus kraussi* (Stebbing, 1900) constantly rework the sediment as they burrow and feed. They move sediment to the surface, form mounds and burrow openings, and change the physical structure and chemical properties of the sandflat (**Kristensen** et al., 2012). These changes affect the substratum itself and the communities that live in it (**Pillay** and Branch, 2011; **Thomas** et al., 2023). Sediment surface microtopography, like small mounds, burrow openings and roughness features, can be used as a proxy for macro-invertebrate ecological activity (**Schenone** et al., 2024, 2025). Measuring this surface structure therefore provides a practical way to quantify superficial bioturbation intensity. The difficulty is that these surfaces are fragile, and contact-based measurements can easily disturb the features being measured.

Low-cost RGB-D cameras, which record both colour and depth, offer a non-contact way to measure soft-sediment microtopography at the millimetre scale (**Azhar** et al., 2022; **Kamal** et al., 2014). **Azhar** et al. (2022) demonstrated a practical approach in which the sensor is shielded from sunlight, calibrated, and used to produce depth images of the sediment surface. A fitted polynomial surface is then removed from the depth image to isolate the small-scale topography, from which roughness metrics such as arithmetic mean roughness and rugosity can be calculated. A similar problem has been addressed at UCT for sea ice, where LiDAR and camera data were used to reconstruct and quantify the roughness of pancake ice (**Spirakis**, 2021; **Spirakis** et al., 2023). The same ideas of detrending, surface reconstruction and roughness extraction carry over well to soft-sediment microtopography.

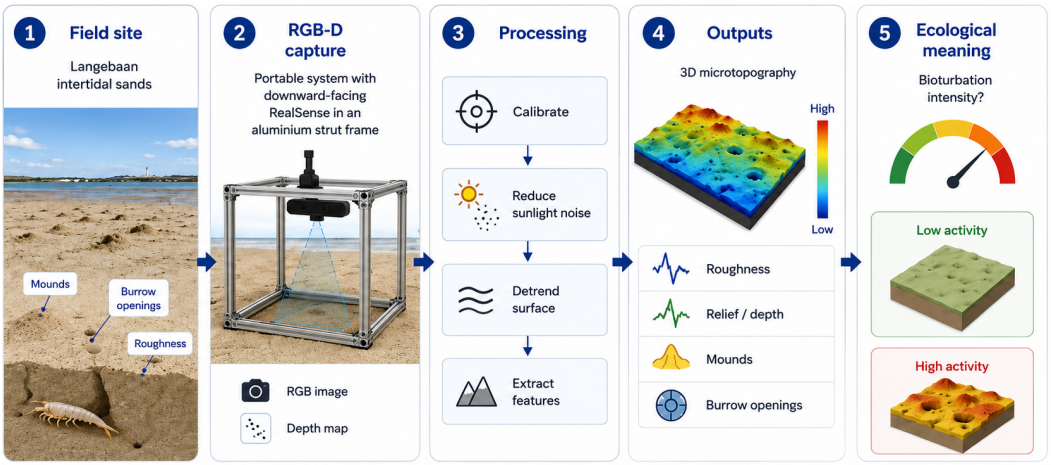

Fig. 6. Proposed RGB-D workflow for measuring sandprawn bioturbation. A downward-facing RealSense camera captures colour and depth images of the sediment surface, which are processed to recover microtopography, roughness, mounds and burrow openings. Schematic generated with assistance from ChatGPT (OpenAI, 2026) and edited by the author.

Subject of investigation
This project develops an RGB-D microtopography pipeline to quantify sandprawn bioturbation, in collaboration with the Department of Biological Sciences at UCT. The work is based on the framework of **Azhar** et al. (2022), but adapted to the Intel RealSense camera. The main tasks are to calibrate the sensor, characterise its depth noise, and develop a processing pipeline that extracts the detrended sediment microtopography and the roughness metrics that describe surface disturbance. The system will be validated against controlled targets of known relief, so that the depth accuracy and roughness measurements can be quantified. As an extension, the project will also detect and segment the specific surface features produced by sandprawns, including mounds and burrow openings, using classical morphological image-processing methods. This allows the project to move beyond general roughness metrics and measure the visible bioturbation features directly.

Deliverables	**The key objectives of this project are:** (a) To understand the full scope and requirements of the project. (b) To conduct a literature review of RGB-D microtopography measurement and sandprawn bioturbation, and critically evaluate the techniques that apply to this project. (c) To adapt and calibrate the Intel RealSense for microtopography capture, and characterise its depth noise under controlled laboratory conditions. (d) To develop the detrending and roughness-metric pipeline that extracts the microtopography from the depth images. (e) To detect and segment sandprawn features, the surface mounds and burrow openings, from the detrended depth. (f) To validate the pipeline in the laboratory against controlled targets of known relief, and characterise the geometric accuracy and sensitivity of the extracted microtopography metrics. (g) To discuss the performance of the system, draw conclusions, and make recommendations for future improvements. **The key deliverables of this project are:** (a) A literature review report and detailed project statement and plan (Hand-in 2 weeks from the initiation of the project). (b) Weekly reporting of project progress and plans to the supervisor(s) through an agreed-upon communication platform, which could include online meetings. (c) An RGB-D microtopography pipeline on the Intel RealSense that extracts roughness metrics and detects sandprawn features, validated in the laboratory to quantify bioturbation intensity. (d) A research project report, following the Department of Electrical Engineering Final Year Project report guidelines. (e) Satisfactory completion of all Engineering Council of South Africa's Graduate Attributes (ECSA GAs). (f) A poster summarising the research project report. (g) A seminar to the Department summarising the research project report. (h) Attendance and presentation at the annual Department Open Day.
Skills/Requirements	Image processing, 3D reconstruction, Interest in marine ecology
Extra Information	**References** M. **Azhar**, J. R. Hillman, T. Gee, S. Schenone, W. van der Mark, S. F. Thrush, and P. Delmas. An RGB-D framework for capturing soft-sediment microtopography. *Methods in Ecology and Evolution*, 13(8):1730–1745, 2022. **doi:** 10.1111/2041-210X.13899 S. **Kamal**, S. Y. Lee, and J. Warnken. Investigating three-dimensional mesoscale habitat complexity and its ecological implications using low-cost RGB-D sensor technology. *Methods in Ecology and Evolution*, 5(9):845–853, 2014. **doi:** 10.1111/2041-210X.12210 E. **Kristensen**, G. Penha-Lopes, M. Delefosse, T. Valdemarsen, C. Quintana, and G. Banta. What is bioturbation? the need for a precise definition for fauna in aquatic sciences. *Marine Ecology Progress Series*, 446:285–302, 2012. **doi:** 10.3354/meps09506 D. **Pillay** and G. M. Branch. Bioengineering effects of burrowing thalassinidean shrimps on marine soft-bottom ecosystems. *Oceanography and Marine Biology: An Annual Review*, 49:137–192, 2011. **doi:** 10.1201/b11009-5 S. **Schenone**, I. Bartl, and S. Thrush. Sediment microtopography predicts localised benthic ecosystem functioning and the effect of species interactions. *Marine Ecology Progress Series*, 749:47–55, 2024. **doi:** 10.3354/meps14735 S. **Schenone**, J. E. Hewitt, J. Hillman, R. Gladstone-Gallagher, J. Gammal, C. Pilditch, A. M. Lohrer, E. Ferretti, M. Azhar, P. Delmas, and S. F. Thrush. Seafloor sediment microtopography as a surrogate for biodiversity and ecosystem functioning. *Ecological Applications*, 35:e3069, 2025. **doi:** 10.1002/eap.3069 A. **Spirakis**. Investigation into surface roughness characterisation using LiDAR and cameras. BSc(Eng) final year project, Department of Electrical Engineering), University of Cape Town, 2021. **url:** https://tinyurl.com/spirakis2021 A. **Spirakis**, J. Hepworth, and R. Verrinder. 3D reconstruction of pancake sea ice using LiDAR and cameras. In *IGARSS 2023-2023 IEEE International Geoscience and Remote Sensing Symposium*, pages 60–63. IEEE, 2023. **doi:** 10.1109/igarss52108.2023.10282250 C. M. **Thomas**, C. de Cerff, G. A. V. Maniel, A. E. Oyatoye, E. Rocke, H. G. Marco, and D. Pillay. Water filtration by endobenthic sandprawns enhances resilience against eutrophication under experimental global change conditions. *Scientific Reports*, 13(1):19067, 2023. **doi:** 10.1038/s41598-023-46168-y O. **Venter**, D. Pillay, and K. Prayag. Water filtration by burrowing sandprawns provides novel insights on endobenthic engineering and solutions for eutrophication. *Scientific Reports*, 10(1):1913, 2020. **doi:** 10.1038/s41598-020-58677-1
Broad Research Area	RGB-D imaging, 3D reconstruction, Microtopography, Marine ecology
Project suitable for: ME/ECE/EE/ALL?	EE, EC, ME

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EEE4022S Topic RAV2026-06 GAs

Student Proposed?	Y/N	N/A
ID	**RAV2026-06**	
Supervisor	**RA Verrinder**	
Co-Supervisor(s)	**A/Prof D Pillay (UCT Biological Sciences), G Maniel**	
Title	**RGB-D microtopography of sandprawn bioturbation**	
GA 1: Problem solving* Identify, formulate, analyse and solve complex engineering problems creatively and innovatively.	This project meets GA1 by addressing a complex engineering problem in capturing and quantifying fine-scale sediment microtopography with a low-cost RGB-D device at the millimetre scale. It involves ill-posed and under-specified problems, such as the: • adaptation of the Intel RealSense to resolve millimetre-scale relief reliably on low-texture sediment, • separation of the sandprawn microtopography from the underlying sediment trend and sensor noise. It also presents high-level problems, such as: • Calibrating the device and characterising its depth noise under controlled laboratory conditions. • Detecting and segmenting sandprawn mounds and burrow openings from the detrended depth. • Relating the extracted metrics to sandprawn bioturbation intensity. The project also necessitates handling complex and incomplete information by: • Synthesising information from RGB-D imaging, surface metrology, and sandprawn ecology literature. • Balancing technical challenges, engineering design, and the interests of the Biological Sciences collaboration.	
GA 4: Investigations, experiments and analysis† Demonstrate competence to design and conduct investigations and experiments.	This project will require iterative implementation of solutions to: • Adapt, calibrate, and characterise the Intel RealSense for microtopography capture. • Develop the detrending and roughness-metric pipeline. • Detect and segment sandprawn features from the detrended depth. • Validate the pipeline in the laboratory against controlled targets of known relief. • Apply statistical analysis to evaluate the metrics as a bioturbation proxy.	
GA 5: Use of engineering tools‡ Demonstrate competence to create, select and apply and recognise limitations of appropriate techniques, resources and modern engineering and IT tools, including prediction and modelling, to complex engineering problems.	This project will be computational and experimental in nature and will require competencies in sensor calibration, depth-image processing, 3D reconstruction, and data analysis. As such, the candidate will demonstrate competency in the use of engineering tools and software, selecting appropriate image processing and data analysis tools to achieve project objectives. **Software required may include:** • Python/C++ with the Intel RealSense SDK for device interfacing and calibration • Python/MATLAB with OpenCV for depth-image processing and detrending • Python/MATLAB for feature detection, roughness metrics, and analysis	

*Graduate Attribute 1: Problem solving

Complex engineering problems require in-depth fundamental and specialised engineering knowledge and have one or more of these characteristics:

- are ill-posed, under- or over-specified, or require identification and refinement;
- are high-level problems including component parts or sub-problems;
- are unfamiliar or involve infrequently encountered issues;

and their solutions have one or more of the characteristics:

- are not obvious, require originality or analysis based on fundamentals;
- are outside the scope of standards and codes;
- require information from a variety of sources that is complex, abstract or incomplete;
- involve wide-ranging or conflicting issues: technical, engineering and interested or affected parties.

†Graduate Attribute 4: Investigations, experiments and data analysis

The balance of **investigation and experiment** should be appropriate to the discipline. Research methodology to be applied in research or investigation where the student engages with selected knowledge in the research literature of the discipline.

An **investigation differs from a design** in that the objective is to produce knowledge and understanding of a phenomenon and a recommended course of action rather than specifying how an artefact could be produced.

‡Graduate Attribute 5: Engineering methods, skills and tools, including information technology

A range of methods, skills and tools appropriate to the disciplinary designation of the program including:

- discipline-specific tools, processes or procedures;
- computer packages for computation, modelling, simulation, and information handling;
- computers and networks and information infrastructures for accessing, processing, managing, and storing information to enhance personal productivity and teamwork.

Ethics clearance questionnaire: RAV2026-06

Question	Question Text	Yes	No
Q1	Does this project involve data collection	X	
Q2	Does this project involve utilizing a third-party data set		X
Q3	Does this project utilize machine learning (ML) or artificial intelligence (AI)?		X
Q4	Does it exceed the minimum risk defined **here**.		X
Answer is **No** here if your project does not utilize ML and AI			
Q5	Does this project involve external parties, funders, etc		X
Answer the following questions if you answer **Yes** to any of the above questions.			
If the answer is **Yes** to **Q1**, please answer the following questions:			
Q6	Are there humans or animals directly involved in the data collection process or contains any identification information		X
If the answer is **Yes** to **Q2**, please answer the following questions:			
Q7	Are the third-party data used anonymous (data does not contain human or animal-related information?)		X
Q8	Are the third-party data used from an open source?		X
Q9	Are the third-party data used from a different research group?		X
Q10	If the answer to **Q9** is **Yes**, do you have the approval to use third-party data sets? Attach the proof to PSQ application.		X
If the answer is **Yes** to **Q5**, please answer the following questions:			
Q11	Have you signed an MOU between the parties [If Yes, attach the proof to PSQ application.]		X
Q12	Will there be a chance for any conflict of interest between the parties? [If **Yes**, provide details of the issue and your plan to solve it]		X

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Appendix D: ECSA Graduate Attributes

Project mapping to ECSA Graduate Attributes

The table below provides a structured reflection on where each of the required Graduate Attributes (GAs) as defined by Engineering Council of South Africa (ECSA) associated with the final year project is met. This includes reference to the specific Chapter/Section (where applicable).

GA	Graduate Attribute Description	Student reflection: How this outcome was achieved during the project
GA1	*Problem solving*	The system I inherited was functional, but it had not been characterised or optimised for measuring roughness on sediment. To address this, I broke the problem down into four objectives, each tied to a gap identified in the literature (section 2.6). Within each objective, several smaller problems remained. Most had no obvious existing solution, so I had to work from fundamentals. For example, nearly flat sediment is close to a degenerate case for ICP (subsection 3.2.4). I therefore designed a multi-hypothesis coarse alignment: several independent methods each propose a pose, and the best-scoring one is passed to ICP for refinement. Similarly, the commanded servo angles turned out to be inaccurate, so I measured tilt directly from the IMU's gravity readings and found the unknown axis convention, tilt pivot and rotation direction through joint searches (subsection 5.2.2). Merging the registered scans directly left offset duplicate surface layers. I solved this with a confidence-weighted trimmed mean, which halved the fused error from 0.96 to 0.45 mm RMS (subsection 5.2.5).

GA	Graduate Attribute Description	Student reflection: How this outcome was achieved during the project
GA4	*Investigations, experiments and data analysis*	In order to determine optimal configurations of the D456 camera for this specific use case, I designed and carried out a two-stage characterisation plan(chapter 6). The first stage (section 6.1) included planar tests, which used a reference plane to isolate the effects of working distance, tilt and ambient light on the cameras ability to reconstruct these planar surfaces. The second stage (section 6.2) was predominantly used to evaluate the performance of the camera using different configurations and post processing methods. For this, existing 3D printed objects (subsection 4.5.1) of known geometry were used to quantitatively examine the reconstruction quality used the following sweeps: • A sweep over resolution, depth unit and visual preset; • 257 post-processing filter configurations, applied offline to the same recorded data so that only the filter settings varied; • 44-view tilt and rotation captures, fused in subsets. Each test was evaluated with well defined metrics: RMSE, signed bias, completeness and F-score (section 3.4). The complete pipeline was then validated against the analytic references and on sand taken from the Langebaan Lagoon in question, in dry, wet and waterlogged states (chapter 7). All results were analysed critically. For example, I identified the auto-exposure drift as a confound in the distance sweep, and noted that the tilt analysis coupled distance (section 6.1). I also attributed the seemingly closer matching roughness metrics of the single scans, compared to fused scans, to the depth noise present in single scans, rather than on absolute reconstruction ability (chapter 7).
GA5	*Use of engineering tools*	I chose each tool to suit its workload and justified the choice (chapter 5): • C++ with the Point Cloud Library for the computationally heavy registration and fusion (section 5.2); • Python with Open3D, NumPy and SciPy for cropping and the ISO 25178-2 roughness metrics (section 5.1 and section 5.3), chained by a batch-processing script. Hardware tools included an Arduino-driven tilt servo, the camera IMU, AprilTag fiducials, and CAD-designed adjustable tag mounts (section 4.3) I also recognised the limitations of these tools and worked around them: • FPFH matching is unreliable on smooth sediment, so it serves only as a fallback (subsection 5.2.3). • The statistical outlier filter punched holes in sparsely sampled regions, so I replaced it with a plane-distance test (subsection 5.2.5). • MLS smoothing acts as a low-pass filter on the relief (subsection 5.2.5). All code is version-controlled on GitHub (chapter A).

GA	Graduate Attribute Description	Student reflection: How this outcome was achieved during the project
GA6	*Professional and technical communication*	The report follows the departmental final year project guidelines. It moves from the problem statement and literature review through theory, system design, results and discussion to conclusions and further work (section 1.5). Within each technical chapter, method, results and discussion are kept separate, and limitations are stated alongside each processing stage (subsection 5.1.7, subsection 5.2.6 and subsection 5.3.9). Technical content is supported by a list of symbols, a glossary of acronyms, numbered equations and IEEE referencing. Each figure caption states the sample size and the statistic plotted. The underlying data is tabulated in Appendices D–F so that every plotted result can be checked. The end users of this system are ecologists in the Department of Biological Sciences. I therefore condensed the engineering findings into a concrete capture protocol, together with a plain statement of when rugosity values can and cannot be compared (chapter 9 and chapter 10). Throughout the project, I reported progress and plans regularly to my supervisor. The work will also be presented in a poster, a departmental seminar and at the Department Open Day.
GA8	*Individual and collaborative teamwork*	This was an individual project within a larger interdisciplinary study of human impacts on intertidal ecosystems (section 1.1). I Individually managed the planning and execution of the work. I set my own milestones within the 12-week timeline, including a data cut-off date and a first draft for feedback. When automated detection of mounds and burrow openings could not be completed in time, I re-scoped the project and moved it to further work (chapter 10). Collaboratively, I worked with co-supervisors from UCT's Department of Biological Sciences (G. Maniel), balancing engineering requirements against the ecological questions the measurements must answer (section 2.2 and section 8.4). I built on the rig and capture software inherited from earlier work and modified them for this project, adding a height-adjustable cross member and adjustable tag mounts (section 4.3). I worked in the shared ARU laboratory, where I drew on postgraduate students for equipment and advice. Weekly progress reports to my supervisor kept the work aligned with the expectations of all stakeholders.

GA	Graduate Attribute Description	Student reflection: How this outcome was achieved during the project
GA9	*Independent learning ability*	The project required substantial knowledge beyond the undergraduate curriculum, which I acquired independently from research literature and technical documentation. New areas included: • benthic ecology and bioturbation (section 2.1–section 2.2); • stereo and active-stereo depth sensing (section 3.1); • point-cloud registration: closed-form SVD alignment, fiducial markers, FPFH with RANSAC, and point-to-plane ICP (section 3.2); • volumetric and height-field fusion (section 3.3); • reconstruction evaluation metrics (section 3.4); • areal surface metrology under ISO 25178-2 (section 3.5 and section 5.3). I also learnt the RealSense SDK, PCL and Open3D well enough to build a working end-to-end pipeline. I applied this knowledge critically rather than accepting it as given. For example, I noticed that the measured noise trend was near-linear where stereo theory predicts a quadratic trend, and identified why (subsection 6.1.4). I also replaced approaches that did not work in practice, such as the original merge-and-thin fusion (subsection 5.2.5). My supervisor gave me the freedom to direct the investigation myself. I reflected on the gaps in my own results to set out a programme of further work (chapter 10).

Bibliography

[1] Camera Depth Testing Methodology. URL https://www.intel.com/content/www/us/en/content-details/841706/intel-realsense-camera-depth-testing-methodology.html.

[2] ISO 25178-2:2021. https://www.iso.org/standard/74591.html.

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[4] Intel RealSense Product Family D400 Series, 2023. URL https://www.realsenseai.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/06/Intel-RealSense-D400-Series-Datasheet-June-2020.pdf.

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